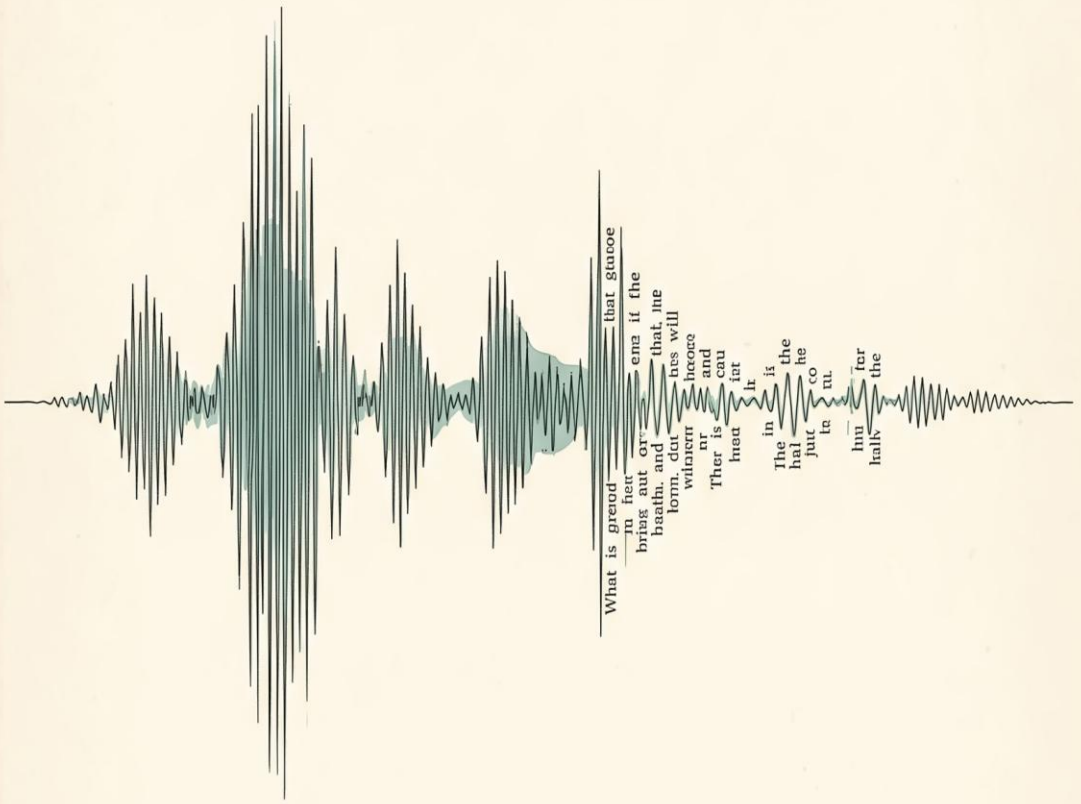
Wispr Flow

The Complete Field Guide to Talking Instead of Typing



Written by Claude Code
Instructed by V.Korostyshevskiy

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PREFACE

Wispr Flow is not a transcriber. It is a rewriter.

Hold a key, talk, and finished text appears where the cursor was. Not what was said. What was meant. The filler is gone, the punctuation lands in the right places, the half-sentence that doubled back on itself comes out clean. Call it the Rewrite Pass, because a language model sits between the microphone and the screen and quietly fixes the speaker on the way through. Everything Flow does well and everything it does badly starts there.

By mid-2026 the tool had a large paying base and a sprawling help center. What it did not have was a book. The documentation existed, but it existed as more than a hundred separate articles, each answering one question, none of them meant to be read end to end. Anyone who wanted to actually understand the tool had to click, read, click, read, and assemble the picture alone. That is a poor way to learn anything nontrivial.

This book is the assembly. One continuous read, the kind that survives on an e-reader on a couch, instead of a hundred open browser tabs. It is built for the human who is a week into Flow, newly on a paid plan, and after the whole shape of the thing in one sitting rather than a scavenger hunt through a support site.

A few things about how to read it.

It is *independent* and *unofficial*. Wispr Flow did not produce it, review it, or endorse it. The product names belong to their owners. What is here was synthesized from the official help center and from independent research run across several sources, then checked against itself.

It is a snapshot. The app ships changes at roughly a monthly cadence, which means some specific number, menu path, or limit in these pages will eventually be wrong. Where a claim is sensitive to versions, it carries a date. When a screen does not match the text, trust the screen, and let the date on the claim tell you how stale it might be.

It is honest about what it knows. Three kinds of claim live in this book, and each one is marked. Documented means the help center says so. Inferred means the sources

point hard at it without stating it outright. Test-it means the answer was never nailed down anywhere and the only real authority is the device in your hand. The markers are not hedging. They are the line between a fact and a good guess, drawn in the open so the reader can tell which is which.

It does not have to be read in order. The foundations and the output chapters apply to everyone. The four platform chapters, Windows, macOS, iPhone, and Android, stand alone, so a Windows reader never has to wade through the iPhone keyboard and an Android reader can skip the Mac permission dance. The workflow chapters are self-contained. The chapter on teams and enterprise can be ignored entirely by anyone running Flow alone.

The rest of the book assumes one thing about its reader: full attention, and no need for cheerleading. Flow is fast when it is trusted and maddening when it is fought, and most of the friction people hit with it traces back to expecting a transcriber and getting a rewriter instead. Learn where the rewrite helps. Learn where it overreaches. The rest is detail.

Talk instead of type. The machine will handle the typing.

CHAPTER 1: WHAT WISPR FLOW IS AND HOW IT WORKS

In this chapter, you learn what Wispr Flow actually does beneath the surface: not a transcriber that records your words verbatim, but a language-model pipeline that rewrites your speech into finished prose and drops the result wherever your cursor sits. The mental model you build here, The Rewrite Pass, is the lens through which every chapter that follows makes sense.

Most humans who try a dictation tool bring a transcription model in their heads: speak, get words, clean it up yourself. Dictation as a faster keyboard.

Wispr Flow does not work that way.

That mismatch is the source of almost every surprise this book addresses, good and bad. Flow captures your voice, sends it to cloud servers, runs it through speech recognition, hands the raw transcript to a language model for cleanup and formatting, and inserts the result into whatever text field has focus on your device. The text that appears is not your words. It is a rewrite of your words. *That distinction is the whole game.*

Call it The Rewrite Pass. Everything else in this book is a variation on that one operation: how far the pass goes, how to control it, how to teach it your vocabulary, and how to work around the places where it overshoots or annoys you. If you internalize one concept from this entire guide, make it this one.

The product's own description gestures at the idea: "Flow transcribes your speech in real time, runs AI commands to edit your text, and adapts to your vocabulary over time."[1] That sentence buries the lead. The AI editing is not an add-on feature you discover later. It is the primary operation. The transcription is an intermediate step, a waypoint the audio passes through on the way to becoming prose. The help center also describes Flow this way: "Press a hotkey, speak naturally, and Flow types your words in real time. It learns your vocabulary over time and can run AI commands."[1] The vocabulary learning and the AI commands are not accessories. They are the core of what differentiates this tool from the dictation engines built into your operating system.

The Four-Stage Pipeline

Understanding the pipeline in concrete terms makes the product's behavior predictable. There are four stages, and knowing which one is responsible for a given behavior is the fastest route to diagnosing surprises.

Stage 1: Capture. A hotkey or on-screen control activates the microphone and starts recording. On Mac and Windows, you hold a keyboard shortcut and release it when you finish speaking.[2] On iOS, you switch to the Flow Keyboard and tap a microphone button. On Android, a floating overlay called the Flow Bubble appears when you open a text field and the on-screen keyboard is visible; tap the bubble to begin.[1] The capture stage is purely local. The microphone records audio that will be uploaded. Nothing is processed yet.

The practical implication of Stage 1 is that microphone quality and proximity matter more than any software setting. A quiet, close mic gives the recognition engine clean signal; a distant Bluetooth earbud gives it noise. Chapter 18 covers the audio hardware chain in detail, but the principle belongs here: garbage into capture means garbage through the rest of the pipeline.

Stage 2: Cloud speech recognition. The audio is uploaded to Wispr's servers. There is no on-device processing and no offline fallback. The help center puts it plainly: "Flow requires an internet connection for voice transcription."[1] No connection means no dictation. That is not a limitation of the free tier or a missing feature. It is the architecture of every tier, on every platform.

At this stage, the audio becomes raw text. The words you spoke are now a transcript, not yet cleaned up and not yet useful as something you would paste into an email or a document.

Stage 3: The Rewrite Pass. This is where the product earns its name and its reputation for both polish and occasional overreach. The raw transcript is handed to a language-model layer that does far more than spell-check. The help center describes it as "AI commands to edit your text" and notes that Flow "adapts to your vocabulary over time for more accurate transcription."[1] In practice, the cleanup adds punctuation and capitalization, restructures grammar, and reshapes your spoken words into finished prose. Chapter 7 covers the specific behaviors (including

filler-word removal, list formatting, and mid-sentence self-correction) under The Cleanup Dial.

The user does not choose which model handles a given request; the routing is server-side and invisible. What matters from this side of the screen is the result: without this stage, you get a raw transcript. With it, you get a prose draft. The difference is the product.

Stage 4: Insertion. The rewritten text is inserted at the cursor using operating-system APIs. On Mac, that requires Accessibility permission (Chapter 4, The Permission Gate). On Android, it requires the accessibility service (Chapter 6, The Floating Bubble). On iOS, the insertion works through the keyboard extension.[1,2] The result lands in whichever text field has focus: a Slack message, a document, a code comment, a browser form. Any field, any application, without requiring the receiving application to know anything about Flow.

Flow works across all apps because it inserts transcribed text into whichever app has focus, without requiring any in-app integration.[1] That universality is what makes the setup overhead worth absorbing.

The Cloud-Only Consequence

The cloud dependency is not a quirk or a temporary limitation. It is the architecture.

Every dictation session round-trips through Wispr's servers. In practice, you perceive a short pause between releasing the hotkey and seeing text appear. That is not a bug; it is the transit time for audio traveling to a server, being recognized, rewritten, and sent back. Flow is not a live stenographer typing in step with your syllables. The text arrives as a block after you stop speaking.

The practical consequence: use Flow where you have a reliable internet connection. In airplane mode, in a network-restricted corporate environment, in a conference room where cloud services are blocked by policy, Flow cannot function. There is no offline fallback at any subscription tier, on any platform, as of Q2 2026.[1]

The cloud architecture also carries a privacy dimension worth knowing about early. Every utterance you dictate leaves your device. Controls exist: a Privacy Mode that prevents retention of your audio and transcripts, and a HIPAA Business Associate Agreement available to subscribers who need it.[1] Those controls are significant,

and Chapter 21 covers them in full under The Cloud Boundary. For now, the relevant fact is that your audio travels to a server, gets processed, and comes back as text. That is the product. If the round-trip is a dealbreaker for your use case, you need to know that before you build a workflow around Flow.

The Rewrite Is the Point

Here is where the mental model becomes specific enough to use daily.

When you dictate into a typing interface expecting verbatim output, The Rewrite Pass feels like interference. The tool is changing your words without asking. When you dictate *expecting* the pass, the same behavior reads as assistance. You speak loosely, Flow writes tightly. The shift is not in the software. It is in your expectations.

The pass does quite a lot by default. The help center describes AI commands that edit, rephrase, and restructure your text, and a vocabulary-adaptation layer that learns your words over time.[1] Practically, that means the output you see is cleaner, more punctuated, and more grammatically polished than what you said. The pass also adapts to the active application; in a personal messaging app it formats casually, while in a work email client it formats formally. That context-adaptive layer is called The App-Aware Rewrite and belongs to Chapter 9.

What the pass does not do is read your mind. It rewrites what it heard toward plausible finished prose, using whatever context it has. The heavier the rewrite level, the more aggressively it polishes. The lighter the level, the closer the output stays to your raw speech. At the lightest setting, sentence structure stays mostly intact. At the heaviest, you can get a substantially different version of what you said: shorter, more polished, which is great for rough first drafts and genuinely problematic for precise technical instructions where every word was chosen deliberately.

That dial is adjustable. Learning to set it correctly for each context is half the skill of using Flow well. Chapter 7 covers The Cleanup Dial in full. For now, know the dial exists, know the default setting is not the only option, and know that when the output surprises you, the correct question is “what level is the dial set to?” not “why is the tool broken?”

The Rewrite Pass is not a problem to solve. It is the product. Work with it and you write faster. Fight it and you spend your time correcting corrections.

Four Platforms, Four Entry Points

Flow is available as native applications for Mac (macOS 12.0 or later), Windows 10 or 11, iOS (18.3 or later), and Android (13 through 16).[1,3] Each platform has a distinct interface for entering and exiting a dictation session. The backend pipeline is identical. The front door is different.

Mac and Windows (desktop). The primary interface is the Flow Bar, a small floating element that shows an animated waveform while recording. You invoke dictation by holding a keyboard shortcut; the default on Mac is the Fn key.[1,2] The app lives in the menu bar on Mac and the system tray on Windows.[2] It does not appear in the Dock or the application switcher and has no main window in the traditional sense.

Desktop is also where the Hub lives: a home base for dictation stats, transcription history, your dictionary, snippets, styles, notes, and insights.[1] New users see a get-started message with the dictation shortcut; returning users see a welcome-back greeting, recent activity, and stats.[1] The Hub is the administrative center of the product.

The desktop experience is the most feature-complete and is where most of this book's discussion is centered. Mac requires Accessibility permission and offers separate builds for Apple Silicon and Intel hardware.[2,3] Windows requires only system microphone access and runs on x64 processors.[3] Chapter 4 covers Mac setup under The Permission Gate, and Chapter 3 covers Windows under The Electron Tax.

iOS. Flow operates as a keyboard extension, not a system-wide hotkey. To dictate, you switch to the Flow Keyboard using the globe icon, then tap the microphone button.[2] This is deliberately different from the desktop model, and the whole iOS chapter is organized around the friction of that extra step and the ways to reduce it. Chapter 5 names this The Keyboard Detour.

The gap narrows with the Action Button on supported models: iPhone 15 Pro, iPhone 15 Pro Max, all iPhone 16 models (including iPhone 16e), iPhone 17, iPhone 17 Pro, iPhone 17 Pro Max, and iPhone Air.[4] The iPhone 17e is not supported

because it lacks a physical Action Button.[4] The Action Button can be configured as a quick dictation trigger. Six Siri Shortcuts also install automatically with Flow on iOS and provide additional entry points without touching the keyboard at all.[3] iOS also has its own Notes feature with Spotlight indexing and lock-screen widgets for quick capture.[1]

Android. Rather than replacing the keyboard, Flow places a floating overlay (the Flow Bubble) over whatever you are doing on screen. When you open a text field and the on-screen keyboard appears, the bubble appears alongside it. Tap the bubble to start dictating; tap again to submit.[1] The bubble is customizable in size and opacity, can be snoozed by dragging it to the bottom of the screen, and is automatically hidden in banking and financial applications, in password fields, and in numeric and phone number inputs.[1,3] Chapter 6 covers this as The Floating Bubble.

The common thread. All four platform interfaces invoke the same backend. A dictation from an Android phone and a dictation from a MacBook Pro go through the same speech recognition and the same rewrite pass. What differs is how you start it, how the application fits into your device's security model, and what permissions you grant before the first session.

Languages, Requirements, and Universal Insertion

Language support. Flow supports over 100 languages.[1] On Mac, Windows, and iOS, an Auto-detect option identifies the language you are speaking without requiring you to switch manually.[2] Auto-detect is not available on Android, where you must select at least one specific language before dictating.[1] The rewrite pass is most consistent in English; Chapter 13 covers multilingual behavior and its limits under the name One Language Per Breath.

System requirements (as of Q2 2026). Mac requires macOS 12.0 or later on either Apple Silicon or Intel hardware, with approximately 500 MB of free storage.[1,3] Windows requires Windows 10 (64-bit) or Windows 11, with x64 processors; ARM-based Windows devices (including Snapdragon) are not officially supported.[1,3] iOS requires iOS 18.3 or later on iPhone.[1,3] Android runs on Android 13 through 16 and

requires an accelerometer for shake-gesture support.[3] All platforms require an active internet connection and a working microphone.[1]

Where Flow inserts. Flow works in any text field in any application, without requiring special integration or support from the receiving app.[1] The insertion mechanism goes through the operating system. Slack, Gmail, Notion, VS Code, Microsoft Word, ChatGPT, browser form fields, chat windows, code editors: Flow inserts into all of them. The help center frames the proposition directly: "Dictate anywhere you can type."[1] You grant permissions once, learn one set of habits, and those habits work everywhere you type.

Chapter 17 covers the exceptions under The Insertion Boundary: remote desktop configurations, security software, non-standard keyboard layouts, and banking-app detection logic on Android. Those exceptions are real, and knowing them is useful. But they are exceptions to a broad rule.

What the Rest of the Book Is

Every chapter from here forward either expands one part of The Rewrite Pass pipeline or explains how to control it in a specific context.

Chapters 3 through 6 cover platform setup. The entry point, the required permissions, and the device-specific behavior differ enough across Mac, Windows, iPhone, and Android that each gets its own chapter. Read the chapter for your platform; the others are optional reference.

Chapters 7 through 14 cover the layers you can configure on the rewrite: the cleanup level (The Cleanup Dial), voice editing commands (Voice as Editor), context adaptation (The App-Aware Rewrite), vocabulary teaching (The Personal Lexicon), spoken macros (The Spoken Macro), style tuning (The Style Layer), multilingual behavior (One Language Per Breath), and coding-specific features (Vibe Coding). Each is a way to make The Rewrite Pass work better for a specific task.

Chapters 15 through 18 cover the contexts where you use Flow: writing and messaging workflows, notes and capture, remote and restricted environments, and audio hardware. These address the edges of Stage 4 (insertion) and the beginning of Stage 1 (capture).

Chapters 19 through 21 cover the business and privacy of using Flow: subscription plans (The Word Budget), account management (The Synced Identity), and what happens to your voice data when every utterance goes to a cloud server (The Cloud Boundary).

Chapters 22 through 24 cover usage insights (The Voice Profile), team deployment (The Org Layer), and troubleshooting when the pipeline breaks (The Failure Map).

The rewrite model and the cloud-only architecture are not footnotes. They are the product's identity. Every setting, every failure mode, every pleasant surprise in this book traces back to one of those four pipeline stages. Keep the pipeline in mind, and the book becomes a navigation map.

Key Points

- Flow is not a transcription tool; it rewrites your speech into finished prose before inserting the result at your cursor.
- All processing happens in the cloud; there is no offline mode on any platform or at any subscription tier.
- The pipeline has four stages: capture, cloud speech recognition, the LLM rewrite pass, and insertion at the cursor.
- Each platform uses a different entry point: a hotkey on desktop, the Flow Keyboard on iOS, and the Flow Bubble on Android.
- The rewrite aggressiveness is adjustable; matching the cleanup level to the task is the core skill of using Flow well.
- Flow inserts into any text field in any application without requiring integration from the receiving app.
- Over 100 languages are supported, with Auto-detect available on all platforms except Android.

THE DICTATION MODEL

In this chapter, we explore the physical act of starting and stopping Flow: the hotkey hold, the hands-free lock, and the whisper mode that lets you dictate in a shared office. Choosing the right trigger for the moment is a skill unto itself, one that determines whether Flow feels like an extension of your voice or a clumsy interruption.

You installed Flow. You granted permissions. You see the Flow Bar sitting at the center of your screen, politely waiting. Now what?

You press a key, you talk, and you let go. That is the entire interaction in its simplest form. But “press a key, talk, let go” is to dictation what “move the mouse and click” is to computing. The description is accurate. It is also nearly useless as guidance for someone who needs to dictate a three-paragraph email while standing in line at the pharmacy, or capture a ten-minute product spec while pacing their living room, or whisper a reply during a meeting without the person next to them noticing.

Flow gives you three distinct ways to start dictating. Each fits a different posture, a different context, a different level of ambient noise. Learning when to reach for which one is the core skill of this chapter. Call it Trigger Discipline.

Push-to-Talk: The Default

Push-to-talk is the mode you meet on day one. On Mac, the default hotkey is Fn. On Windows, it is Ctrl + Win.[1] You hold the key, you speak, and you release. Flow captures the audio while the key is down, sends it to the cloud for processing, and pastes the formatted result into whatever text field had focus when you started.[1]

The interaction has a physical feel to it, like a walkie-talkie. Hold to transmit. Release to send. That physicality is the point: your finger on the key is an unambiguous signal to the system (and to yourself) that you are dictating, not thinking aloud.

A few details matter more than you would expect.

THE BRIEF-HOLD CANCEL

On Mac, holding Fn for less than roughly half a second registers as a tap, not a hold, and Flow cancels the session.[1] This is a feature, not a bug. The Fn key serves double

duty on Apple keyboards, and Flow needs to distinguish between “I want to dictate” and “I tapped Fn while reaching for a function key.” The threshold is short enough that you will rarely hit it on purpose, but if you are a fast-twitch person who jabs and releases, you will wonder why nothing happened.

Slow down the press. Give it a beat. You are starting a conversation with a cloud-hosted language model; it can afford half a second of your time.

THE VISUAL HANDSHAKE

When Flow begins listening, it shows a white animated waveform on the Flow Bar. When it detects your voice, the bar turns blue.[1] This two-state feedback is your confirmation that the mic is live and that the system is receiving signal. White bars that never turn blue mean the mic is picking up silence; check your input device. No bars at all means the hotkey did not register; check your shortcut settings.

There is also an auditory cue. Flow plays a ping when recording starts and a paste sound when your text is submitted, provided you have Sound Effects enabled in Settings.[1] If you dictate in environments where you cannot watch the screen (standing at a whiteboard, pacing a room), the ping is your confirmation that the session is live. No ping, no session.

You can also start a dictation session by clicking the Flow Bar directly, without touching a hotkey at all.[1] This is useful when you have reassigned Fn to something else, or when you are orienting a new user who is not yet comfortable with the hotkey. Click the bar, wait for the ping or the moving white bars, and speak.

ESCAPE AS CANCEL

Press Esc while dictating and Flow kills the session.[1] The text is not transcribed. On Mac and Windows, the audio is saved to Recent Activity if it was long enough to be useful, so you can recover it later if you change your mind.[1] This is a quiet safety net: if you start dictating and immediately realize you are in the wrong app or the wrong meeting context, Esc bails you out without leaving a trace in the text field.

THE “STILL PROCESSING” GATE

If you try to start a new session while a previous transcript is still being processed, Flow blocks the attempt and shows a notification: “Flow was processing your last transcript.”[1] Dismiss the notification, wait for the processing to finish (usually a few

seconds), and press your hotkey again. You can also click Cancel in the notification to abandon the in-progress transcription and start fresh.[1]

This is worth knowing because it explains a specific frustration: you release the hotkey, immediately press it again for a second dictation, and nothing happens. Flow is not ignoring you. It is finishing the previous job. The pipeline is sequential, not parallel.

Hands-Free: The Long-Form Mode

Push-to-talk works beautifully for a sentence or a paragraph. For a long email, a journal entry, or a product specification, holding a key for several minutes gets uncomfortable. That is where hands-free mode comes in.

On Mac, press Fn + Space. On Windows, press Ctrl + Win + Space.[2] Flow locks into continuous recording. You take your hands off the keyboard, lean back, and talk. When you are finished, press the same shortcut again (or click the stop icon in the Flow Bar) and Flow pastes the result.[2]

The mental shift from push-to-talk to hands-free is nontrivial. In push-to-talk, the key under your finger is a constant physical reminder that you are recording. In hands-free, that reminder vanishes. You need to build a new habit: glance at the Flow Bar. If the waveform is moving, you are live. If you forget you are recording, you may dictate an aside to your dog that ends up in the quarterly review.

THE FLOW BAR ASYMMETRY

One behavioral note catches people: during hands-free dictation, clicking the Flow Bar does not stop your recording.[2] Use the stop or cancel buttons, or press your hands-free shortcut key. During push-to-talk, clicking the Flow Bar does end the session, which is the opposite behavior. The distinction is deliberate. Hands-free sessions are meant to be long, so an accidental click should not cut you off. Push-to-talk sessions are short, so a click is a convenient way to finish. The logic is sound, but the asymmetry trips up users who switch between modes without thinking about it.

“PRESS ENTER” WITHOUT TOUCHING THE KEYBOARD

Here is a detail that turns hands-free dictation from convenient to genuinely hands-free: say “press enter” at the very end of your dictation and Flow presses the Enter

key after pasting your text.[2] The words “press enter” are stripped from your transcript. This is useful for sending messages in Slack, submitting prompts in a chat interface, or any context where you need to hit Enter after your text lands.

The phrase is only recognized at the end of your dictation. If you say it in the middle of a sentence, it appears as regular text.[2] The first time Flow detects the phrase, a one-time notification explains the feature and asks you to confirm.[2] After that, it works silently.

THE IOS PATH

iOS does not support keyboard shortcuts for hands-free dictation.[2] Instead, you tap the microphone button on the Flow Keyboard, speak, and tap the check button when done.[1] For a more hands-free experience, Siri can start Flow for you: say “Quick dictate to notes with Flow” or “Dictate with Flow” to begin a session that runs through Flow’s own speech recognition.[2] A separate Siri phrase, “Save Flow note,” uses Siri’s built-in speech recognition instead of Flow’s, which produces different results. Several Siri Shortcuts are available automatically upon installation, requiring no manual setup; Chapter 5 (The Keyboard Detour) covers the full list and configuration.

The iOS path is covered in depth in Chapter 5 (The Keyboard Detour). What matters here is the principle: on iOS, the trigger is a tap or a Siri phrase, not a hardware key.

THE ANDROID PATH

On Android, the trigger is the Flow Bubble, a floating overlay that appears when the on-screen keyboard opens.[1] You can tap it once to start a tap-to-dictate session (tap the checkmark when done), or long-press it for hold-to-dictate (release to submit).[2] There is no hardware hotkey equivalent. The Bubble is suppressed in password fields, phone-number fields, and numeric inputs, and it hides itself entirely inside banking and financial apps.[1]

After a successful dictation, a copy-to-clipboard button appears next to the Bubble for five seconds.[2] If Flow cannot insert text into the active field (some apps resist), the Bubble shows a Paste button so you can paste from the clipboard manually.[1] Your dictation is never lost.

Android has no equivalent of the iOS Siri trigger.[2] The Bubble is the one entry point, and it only appears when the on-screen keyboard is visible. If you are using an external hardware keyboard with your Android device, the on-screen keyboard does not open, and the Bubble does not appear.[3]

The Android path gets its own chapter (Chapter 6, The Floating Bubble). For Trigger Discipline purposes, the key point is that Android users must be comfortable with the Bubble as their primary and only entry point.

Session Limits: The Clock You Cannot Ignore

Every dictation session has a ceiling.

On Mac and Windows, the maximum is 20 minutes. At the 19-minute mark, Flow displays a warning: “You have less than 1 minute left before you reach the 20 minute limit!”[4] At 20 minutes, the session ends automatically. Flow transcribes what you said and pastes it into the active text field. A notification titled “Transcription session ended” confirms what happened and includes a “Recover text” button that re-pastes the transcript.[4]

The 20-minute limit applies to both Basic (free) and Pro plans.[4] There is no cooldown between sessions: once the previous transcript finishes processing (usually a few seconds), you can press your hotkey and start again.[4] In practice, this means the 20-minute limit is not a wall so much as a mandatory breath. You dictate for 20 minutes, wait a few seconds, and pick up where you left off.

On Android, the session limit is 5 minutes.[5] About a minute before the limit, a toast notification appears with haptic feedback: “1 minute left before you reach the 5-minute limit.”[5] At 5 minutes, the session stops and submits automatically; your audio is preserved and transcribed normally.[2] A toast message and a system notification confirm the session has ended.[5]

On iOS, the session limit is also 5 minutes.[5] Unlike Android, iOS shows no advance warning. At 5 minutes, the session simply stops and submits your transcription automatically.[5]

These numbers are worth committing to memory. If you are a desktop user dictating a long document, the 20-minute wall is generous but real. Plan your natural breaks around it. On mobile, whether iOS or Android, five minutes goes fast

when you are thinking aloud; structure your dictation into shorter bursts rather than one unbroken monologue. On iOS, the absence of an advance warning makes this discipline especially important. You will not get a tap on the shoulder before the clock runs out.

Note that session limits are separate from the weekly word cap on free-tier accounts (covered in Chapter 19, The Word Budget). A session limit is about continuous recording time. The word cap is about total output volume per week. You can hit one without hitting the other.

Discreet and Whisper Input

Sometimes you need to dictate in a space where speaking at full volume would be inappropriate or conspicuous. Flow handles low-volume input, but the accuracy trade-off is real.

In a quiet room, whispering works well. The cloud-based speech recognition model can resolve low-volume phonemes when there is minimal competing noise. In a noisy environment (a coffee shop, an open-plan office, a conference hallway), the accuracy drops significantly. The system struggles to isolate a whisper from background noise, and you will see more misrecognized words in the output. This is a physics problem, not a software problem: the signal-to-noise ratio determines what the model has to work with, and a whisper in noise is a weak signal.

Microphone choice matters here more than anywhere else in your Flow setup. A close-range mic (a clip-on lavalier, a boom headset) captures your whisper with less room noise than a laptop's built-in mic sitting twelve inches from your mouth. Chapter 18 (The Input Chain) covers hardware selection in detail. For Trigger Discipline purposes, the principle is: if you plan to whisper regularly, invest in a mic that sits close to your lips.

The accuracy of whisper-mode dictation is something you should test on your own device, in your own typical environment, before relying on it for production work. Results vary enough by hardware and ambient conditions that a blanket quality verdict would be misleading.

Customizing Your Triggers

Flow does not lock you into the default hotkeys. On Mac and Windows, you can reassign both the push-to-talk and hands-free shortcuts in Settings, under General, then Shortcuts.[2] Each action can have up to four different shortcuts assigned, and each shortcut can contain up to three keys (keyboard keys and mouse buttons combined).[1]

Mouse buttons are valid triggers. You can bind Middle Click, Mouse 4, Mouse 5, or an Aux Button entry for mice that send extra button codes.[1] You can also combine a keyboard modifier with a mouse button (Ctrl + Mouse 4, for example). Left click and right click cannot be used as triggers.[1] When a mouse button is assigned as a dictation trigger, it no longer performs its default action in other apps; Mouse 4 will not trigger browser back navigation, for instance.[1] Some Logitech mice using Logi Options+ may not support Mouse 4 or Mouse 5 for push-to-talk, because the driver remaps those buttons to trackpad gestures.[1]

If your push-to-talk shortcut overlaps with your hands-free shortcut, Flow shows a five-second warning toast.[2] This is worth watching for: overlapping shortcuts cause unpredictable behavior where pressing one trigger activates the wrong mode. The fix is simple. Open the Shortcuts dialog, check that your push-to-talk and hands-free bindings do not share key combinations, and use “Reset to default” if you have tangled things beyond easy repair.[2]

On iOS, hardware keyboard shortcuts are not supported. The triggers are the microphone button on the Flow Keyboard, the Action Button (iPhone 15 Pro and later), Siri Shortcuts, and home screen widgets.[2] On Android, the trigger is always the Flow Bubble.

If your Mac does not have an Fn key (some external keyboards omit it), Flow assigns Ctrl + Option as the default push-to-talk hotkey during setup.[1] You can change this at any time.

Accessibility: Keyboard and Screen Reader Paths

Trigger Discipline is not only about hotkeys and mouse buttons. For users who navigate by keyboard or screen reader, Flow provides a parallel set of paths.

Flow is built to be driven entirely from the keyboard. Tab moves focus between interactive elements. Space or Enter activates the focused item. Escape closes menus and returns focus to the previous element.[3] A visible focus ring shows which element is selected at any moment, so keyboard-only users always know where they are in the interface. History navigation works via Cmd+[and Cmd+] on Mac (Ctrl+[and Ctrl+] on Windows).[3]

Screen readers work with Flow across platforms. VoiceOver on Mac, NVDA and JAWS on Windows, and TalkBack on Android have been tested.[3] Flow uses semantic HTML and ARIA attributes, announces interactive element states (expanded, collapsed, disabled), and maintains a logical reading order. Navigation landmarks help screen reader users understand page structure without visual cues. Decorative images are hidden from screen readers to reduce noise, and disabled controls are communicated via the HTML disabled attribute and aria-disabled.[3]

Flow also respects your system's reduced-motion preference. When enabled (System Settings on Mac, Accessibility settings on Windows), animations are minimized, including the onboarding toast and the animated glow ring around the Start Flow button on the keyboard.[3] No in-app configuration is needed; Flow detects the system preference automatically.

On Android, the accessibility layer goes deeper. The Flow Bubble automatically repositions after landscape rotation. The Bubble signals connection status visually: a pulsing spinner means Flow is reconnecting; a warning triangle means accessibility permission may need re-granting.[3] Tapping the warning triangle opens the accessibility settings screen directly. On iOS, the QWERTY keyboard includes refinements for tap accuracy (gaps between keys activate the nearest key) and a globe button on smaller iPhone models for switching keyboards.[3]

A few gaps remain, as of Q2 2026. The Hub top bar (sidebar toggle, account panel, notifications) is not yet keyboard-accessible. Collapsed sidebar tooltips are mouse-only. Tab controls throughout the app are not yet keyboard-navigable. Some icon-only buttons lack accessible labels.[3] These are limitations, not showstoppers, and they are the kind of thing that gets incrementally fixed in monthly updates. But if you rely on keyboard navigation or a screen reader as your primary interface, it is worth testing your specific workflow before committing to Flow as your daily driver.

Trigger Discipline in Practice

Trigger Discipline is not a feature you toggle on. It is a habit you develop. It means choosing push-to-talk for a quick Slack reply, switching to hands-free for a long email, whispering into a close-range mic when the open office is full, and knowing the session limits well enough that you never lose text to a timeout you did not see coming.

The three modes are not ranked. Push-to-talk is not “basic” and hands-free is not “advanced.” They are tools for different contexts, and the skilled user moves between them without thinking about it, the same way a driver shifts gears without looking at the gearshift.

Consider the shape of a typical workday. Morning email triage: push-to-talk, one message at a time, hold and release. A long product brief after lunch: hands-free, twenty minutes of unbroken thinking poured into a document. A quick reply during a video call you are not leading: whisper mode with a lavalier mic clipped to your collar. Each scenario demands a different trigger, and Trigger Discipline is the instinct that selects the right one without deliberation.

The work here is building the muscle memory. That takes a week, maybe two. After that, the trigger disappears from your attention and what remains is the voice. That is the goal.

Key Points

- Push-to-talk, hands-free, and whisper input are three distinct modes suited to different physical contexts; none is superior to the others.
- Desktop sessions cap at 20 minutes with a warning at 19; both iOS and Android cap at 5 minutes.
- On Android you receive a warning about one minute before the 5-minute limit; on iOS there is no advance warning at all.
- Hotkeys are fully customizable on desktop, including mouse buttons, with up to four shortcuts per action and three keys per shortcut.

- On iOS the trigger is a tap or a Siri phrase; on Android it is always the Flow Bubble overlay.
- Whisper dictation accuracy depends on mic proximity and ambient noise; test it in your own environment before relying on it.
- Keyboard navigation and screen reader support are built in across platforms, though some interface elements are not yet fully accessible.

WINDOWS

In this chapter, you meet the Windows build of Wispr Flow and the resource cost it carries. Setup is simpler than on macOS because Windows asks for fewer permissions, but the Electron runtime underneath means higher RAM, higher CPU, and occasional friction with the apps you are dictating into. This chapter covers installation, permissions, hotkeys, data locations, and what to expect from the platform that trades polish for reach.

Every desktop application is a bet on a runtime. Native apps bet on tight integration with one operating system. Cross-platform apps bet on reach. Wispr Flow on Windows is an Electron app, and Electron apps pay a tax.

Call it The Electron Tax.

You get the same features as the Mac build. You get dictation, hands-free mode, the Cleanup Dial (see Ch7), Context Awareness (see Ch9), Dictionary, Snippets, Transforms. Feature parity, on paper, is real.[1] But the Windows client wraps all of it inside Chromium, and Chromium is not free. Independent reviews in early-to-mid 2026 consistently report the Windows app consuming roughly 800 MB of RAM and around 8 percent CPU while idle (inferred from multiple third-party benchmarks; Wispr's own documentation does not publish these figures).[2] On a machine with 8 GB of RAM, that idle footprint is nontrivial.

The tax is not just memory. Several reviews and user reports describe the Electron app freezing target applications such as VS Code and Notepad++ during active dictation (inferred from third-party reports, not Wispr documentation).[2] The pattern is consistent with the desktop stability work visible across recent versions of the help center documentation, which addresses repeated crash, freeze, and paste-failure fixes on Windows.[2]

If you are on a well-provisioned machine (16 GB or more, a recent x64 processor), the tax is manageable. If you are on a thin-client laptop or running heavy IDE workloads alongside Flow, you will feel it.

That is the honest trade-off. The rest of this chapter is the practical setup.

System Requirements

Wispr Flow on Windows requires Windows 10 (64-bit) or Windows 11.[3] The hardware recommendations from the help center are straightforward: an x64 processor, 8 GB of RAM or more, approximately 200 MB of available storage, and a working microphone (built-in or external).[3]

One hard boundary: ARM-based Windows devices, including Snapdragon-powered systems, are “not officially supported and may not work correctly.”[3] If you are on a Surface Pro with a Snapdragon chip or a Qualcomm-based laptop, Flow is not a reliable option as of Q2 2026.

An audio output device is optional. Flow works without a default audio output configured.[3]

Installation

There is no dedicated Windows install article in the help center. The Setup Guide covers all four platforms, and the Windows section is compact.[1]

Download the installer from wisprflow.ai. Open it, follow the on-screen steps. Launch Wispr Flow from the Start menu. The app icon appears in your system tray when it is running.[1]

Two installer variants exist for enterprise scenarios: a per-user Wispr Flow Setup.exe for self-install, and a machine-wide Wispr Flow.msi for deployment via Intune, SCCM, or similar MDM tools.[3]

Sign in through the browser. Flow opens your default browser to the login page, where you can use Google, Apple, Microsoft, SSO, or email/password. The session transfers back automatically. If you wait too long, the sign-in attempt times out and you start again.[1]

One tip worth noting: turn on “Start at login” so Flow launches automatically when Windows starts. The setting stays active after app updates.[1]

Permissions (or the Lack of Them)

This is where the Windows experience diverges sharply from macOS. On the Mac, you navigate a Permission Gate (see Ch4) involving Accessibility, Microphone, and

optionally Screen Capture. On Windows, the permission model is simpler to the point of near-invisibility.

Windows does not require app-level Microphone or Accessibility permissions. Only system-level microphone access matters.[4,5] If Windows prompts you for microphone access during setup, allow it. If you skipped the prompt, open Settings, then Privacy & Security, then Microphone, and turn on access for Wispr Flow. If microphone access is already granted system-wide, Flow skips this step automatically.[1]

In recent versions, Flow checks microphone availability at runtime, so you typically do not need to manually re-verify permissions after an update.[4] The in-app button is labeled “Open Settings” (rather than “Allow” as on Mac) and takes you to Windows Sound Settings. If you see a “microphone privacy disabled” notification, Windows is genuinely blocking microphone access.[4]

The simplicity is real, but it comes with a subtlety. Because Windows has no Accessibility permission layer, Flow relies on standard keyboard and clipboard injection rather than OS-level accessibility APIs (inferred from documentation structure; not explicitly stated). This reduces setup friction but makes interference with other keyboard automation tools more likely if you run global hotkeys or text expanders alongside Flow.

Hotkeys

The default push-to-talk shortcut on Windows is Ctrl+Win.[6] Hold it to dictate, release to submit. Double-tap to enter hands-free mode. The hands-free shortcut defaults to Ctrl+Win+Space, and Command Mode to Ctrl+Win+Alt.[6]

Other default shortcuts on Windows:[6]

- Paste last transcript: Shift+Alt+Z
- Copy last transcript: Shift+Alt+X
- Polish (Transform): Win+Alt+1
- Prompt Engineer (Transform): Win+Alt+2
- View Diff: Win+Alt+O

- Cancel: Escape
- Open Scratchpad: no default (opt-in only)

Each binding supports up to four shortcuts. Cancel allows only one.[6]

A valid shortcut requires three keys or fewer, with at least one modifier key (Ctrl, Alt, Shift, Win) or a valid mouse button (middle click, Mouse 4 through Mouse 10).[6] Left and right click are intentionally excluded. Caps Lock cannot be used. And standalone Ctrl or Right Ctrl cannot serve as a single-key hotkey because it would intercept every Ctrl-based shortcut in Windows, breaking copy, paste, and undo.[6]

The system reserves a long list of combinations. Ctrl+C, Ctrl+V, Ctrl+X, Alt+Tab, Alt+F4, Win+E, Win+L, and many more are blocked because Windows or common apps use them.[6] If your shortcut is rejected and it is not in the reserved list, it is likely already assigned to another Flow action. Check Settings, then General, then Shortcuts to see all current assignments.[6]

Here is the conflict scenario worth understanding: if you set your hotkey to a combination that collides with a system shortcut, the pasted output may come out as the conflicted key's character. The documentation gives the example of a hotkey conflict with Ctrl+V causing the output to be the letter "v" instead of your dictated text.[7] The fix is to remap Flow's activation shortcut or adjust the conflicting tool.

Mouse button shortcuts are available on desktop. When bound, the mouse button is intercepted system-wide while Flow is running. Apple Magic Mouse and trackpads are not compatible, but that is a Mac concern, not a Windows one.[6]

Custom keybind shortcuts are stored per-device in your local preferences. They do not sync across machines.[6]

After Updates: Re-verifying

When Flow stops listening, typing, or responding to shortcuts after a system or app update, the issue is almost always permissions or microphone state.[4]

On Windows, the re-verification process is minimal:

1. Check that your system microphone is working in Windows Sound Settings and that no other app is using it exclusively.

2. Close and reopen Wispr Flow.

3. Dictate a short phrase. If text appears in Recent Activity, you are done.[4]

A few Windows-specific issues have surfaced and been fixed in recent updates. Some users saw an empty microphone list in Settings. Others got a false "microphone privacy disabled" error even though their microphone was enabled, particularly on machines managed by IT policies (MDM/GPO) or running Dell Optimizer or similar third-party privacy tools.[4] Both were resolved in recent versions; updating and restarting Flow fixes them.

Another fixed issue: dictation could fail repeatedly and require a full app restart to recover. The audio recorder could become unavailable after restarting onboarding or due to audio driver issues on Windows, causing a false "Listening" state on each push-to-talk attempt. Recent versions recover from this automatically, though you may notice a small delay on the first dictation press after recovery.[4]

Data Locations

Flow stores its data in two Windows directories: %LOCALAPPDATA%\WisprFlow for app files, and %APPDATA%\Wispr Flow for data, database, session, and logs.[8] A legacy path, %APPDATA%\Flow, may also exist from older installations.[8]

If you ever need a completely clean reset, those are the directories to clear. But note: the "Reset & Restart" option in the app (available on desktop only) clears local data and restarts the app. Transcript history is stored locally only and is permanently lost after a reset. Dictionary, Snippets, and Notes re-sync from your account on restart. Shortcuts, stats, and settings are preserved (see Ch24 for details).[9]

One warning that applies to all desktop platforms: do not store Flow's local data in a cloud-synced folder such as OneDrive. This can cause database corruption.[8]

What Windows Does Not Require

It is worth explicitly listing what Windows does *not* ask for, because if you are coming from the Mac chapters or have read about macOS setup elsewhere, the contrast is stark:

- No Accessibility permission. Flow inserts text without it on Windows.

- No Screen Capture permission. Context Awareness on Windows uses a different mechanism.
- No per-app microphone permission. Windows manages this at the OS level.

This makes the Windows setup faster and less error-prone than macOS. It also means there is no Permission Gate to troubleshoot when things break. If dictation stops working on Windows, the fault is almost always microphone access, a hotkey conflict, or the Electron runtime itself.

The Honest Picture

The Electron Tax is real but not disqualifying. The Windows build gives you full feature parity with the Mac build inside a runtime that costs more resources and occasionally interferes with the apps it is serving. If you have the hardware headroom, that trade-off is acceptable. If you are on a constrained machine, test before you commit.

For enterprise deployments, the MSI installer and MDM support make Windows distribution straightforward. Auto-updates will not apply during active dictation, and enterprise admins can configure the update cadence to weekly, bi-weekly, or monthly.[4]

The Windows build works. It just makes you pay for the privilege.

Key Points

- The Windows build is an Electron app that trades higher resource usage for full feature parity with the native Mac client.
- Windows requires only system-level microphone access, with no Accessibility or Screen Capture permissions to configure.
- ARM-based Windows devices (Snapdragon) are not officially supported as of Q2 2026; only x64 processors are valid.
- Hotkey conflicts can cause pasted output to appear as a stray character; remapping the activation shortcut is the fix.

- Store Flow data in its default local directories, never in a cloud-synced folder like OneDrive, to avoid database corruption.

MACOS

In this chapter you will learn why Accessibility permission is the single gate that controls whether Wispr Flow works or silently fails on your Mac, how to install the correct build for your hardware, and what to do when a system update resets the permissions you already granted.

Every operating system has a chokepoint. On the Mac, it is a single toggle buried three clicks deep in System Settings. Grant Wispr Flow the Accessibility permission and dictation flows into every text field on your machine. Withhold it, or let a macOS update reset it, and Flow sits in your menu bar doing nothing useful while you wonder what broke. That toggle is The Permission Gate, and understanding it is the difference between a tool that works everywhere and one that fails in ways Apple never bothers to explain.

Getting the Right Build

Before you touch permissions, you need the right binary. Wispr Flow ships two separate downloads: one for Apple Silicon (M1 and later) and one for Intel.[1] Install the wrong one and the app quits on launch with a dialog titled “Incorrect App Version” that reads: “You are running the Intel version of Wispr Flow on an Apple Silicon Mac. Please download the Apple Silicon version from wisprflow.ai for better performance.”[1]

Check your chip first. Apple menu, About This Mac, look at the Chip or Processor line. Apple Silicon says something like “Apple M1” or “Apple M2 Pro.” Intel says “Intel Core i5” or similar. Download the matching build from wisprflow.ai and move on.

The minimum is macOS 12.0, Monterey.[1] Anything older gets an “Unsupported MacOS Version” dialog and the app refuses to launch.[1] As of Q2 2026, Monterey is four major releases behind the current macOS. If you are still on it, Flow will run, but you are living on the edge of Apple’s own support window.

Installation in Under a Minute

The install is a drag-and-drop. Open the downloaded .dmg, drag the Wispr Flow icon onto the Applications folder shortcut in the installer window, close the installer window, and launch from Applications, Launchpad, or Spotlight.[1]

Three constraints matter here:

- Flow must live in an Applications folder. It accepts /Applications, ~/Applications, or /System/Applications, and nothing else.[1] Launching it from your Downloads folder or from the still-open installer window triggers a "Flow needs to be in the Applications folder to run" error, even if you already dragged the app to the right place.[1]
- Flow runs in the menu bar only. It does not appear in the Dock. It does not appear in the Cmd+Tab switcher. It sets itself to launch at login automatically.[1,2] If you are the kind of user who force-quits Dock-less apps and then wonders where they went, look up. The Wispr Flow icon is in your menu bar.
- After you eject the .dmg, delete the installer file from Downloads. It is just taking up space.

The Permission Gate

Here is where the Mac diverges from every other platform Flow runs on. On Windows, Flow needs only system microphone access (see Ch3, The Electron Tax). On iOS, it is a keyboard extension with its own toggle (see Ch5). On Android, it is an overlay service (see Ch6). On macOS, Flow needs two permissions granted manually, and a third is optional.[3]

MICROPHONE

This one is obvious. A dictation app needs to hear you. On first launch, macOS shows the native permission dialog asking whether Wispr Flow can access the microphone. Click Allow.[1]

If you click "Don't Allow" (or if a previous install left the permission denied), Flow detects the denial and opens System Settings directly to Privacy & Security,

Microphone, so you can flip the toggle yourself.[1,3] Flow picks up the change automatically; no restart required.

Microphone permission is necessary but not sufficient. Without it, Flow cannot record. With it alone, Flow can record but cannot insert text reliably, because insertion on macOS depends on the next permission.

ACCESSIBILITY

This is The Permission Gate itself. On Mac, Accessibility permission is what allows Flow to read the active text field, detect which app has focus, respond to the hotkey even when another app is in the foreground, and insert transcribed text at the cursor.[3] Context Awareness, the feature that adapts output to the app you are using (see Ch9, The App-Aware Rewrite), also requires Accessibility on Mac.[4]

Without Accessibility, Flow records your voice, sends it to the cloud, gets a transcript back, and then has nowhere to put it. The symptom is silence: you speak, the waveform animates, and nothing appears. No error, no explanation. Just nothing.

Open System Settings, Privacy & Security, Accessibility, and make sure Wispr Flow is toggled on.[3] If it is not listed at all, reinstall Flow. If it is listed but toggled off, toggle it on. macOS may ask you to authenticate with your password or Touch ID.

The hotkey behavior depends on this permission too. The default Mac hotkey is Fn: hold it to dictate, release to submit. The backup is Ctrl+Option for Macs or external keyboards where the Fn key behaves differently.[5] If your hotkey press does nothing at all, check Accessibility first. Keyboard shortcuts require it.[3]

SCREEN CAPTURE (OPTIONAL)

Screen Capture permission is not required for basic dictation. It enables advanced features that benefit from reading on-screen content beyond what Accessibility alone provides.[3] You can grant it later if you find you want those features. Skipping it does not break anything fundamental.

What Lives Where

Flow stores its data in several standard macOS locations:

- ~/Library/Application Support/Wispr Flow (main data)

- ~/Library/Logs/Wispr Flow (logs)
- ~/Library/Caches/Wispr Flow (cache)
- ~/Library/Preferences/Wispr Flow.plist (preferences)
- ~/Library/Saved Application State/Wispr Flow.savedState (window state)
- ~/Library/HTTPStorages/Wispr Flow (network storage)[6]

A legacy path, ~/Library/Application Support/Flow, may exist if you installed an earlier version of the app.[6]

You do not need to manage these directly under normal use. They matter when troubleshooting, when doing a clean uninstall, or when you discover that your iCloud Drive or OneDrive sync has been pointed at ~/Library and is silently corrupting Flow's database (see Ch20, The Synced Identity, for the sync-corruption scenario).

After Updates: the Gate Can Close

macOS has a habit of resetting permissions after system updates. Apple does this for security reasons that are defensible in theory and infuriating in practice. You granted Accessibility last month; you updated to macOS 15.5; now Accessibility is toggled off and Flow has stopped inserting text. No notification. No prompt. You just start talking and nothing happens.

The fix is the same every time.[3]

1. Quit Flow (click the menu bar icon, select Quit).
2. Open System Settings, Privacy & Security, Microphone. Find Wispr Flow, toggle it off, then on again.
3. Go to Privacy & Security, Accessibility. Confirm Wispr Flow is enabled.
4. Reopen Flow from Applications.
5. Dictate a short phrase. If text appears, you are done.

On recent macOS versions, Flow's in-app permission links open the correct System Settings pane automatically.[3] On older versions, or on macOS Tahoe where a bug

caused permission links to open the wrong pane, you may need to navigate manually. That specific bug was fixed in a recent Flow update.[3]

The real lesson is this: if Flow was working yesterday and is not working today, and you recently updated macOS, the answer is almost always permissions. Re-verify before you do anything else.

The Menu Bar Life

Flow on Mac is a menu-bar-only application.[1,2] There is no window. There is no Dock icon. Cmd+Tab will not find it. This is by design: a dictation tool that sits in your peripheral vision, ready when summoned, invisible when not.

The Flow Bar appears when you activate dictation (hold Fn or your configured hotkey). It shows an animated waveform while listening (verify the exact color behavior on your device). When you release the hotkey, the audio goes to the cloud, the transcript comes back, and Flow inserts it at your cursor. The Flow Bar disappears.

This interaction model is clean once you internalize it. The confusion comes when something goes wrong and you look for Flow in the Dock, in Cmd+Tab, in the App Switcher, and find nothing. Flow is always in the menu bar. Click the icon there to access settings, check for updates, or quit.

What This Chapter Does Not Cover

The Mac chapter is self-contained. You do not need to read Ch3 (Windows), Ch5 (iPhone), or Ch6 (Android) to set up Flow on your Mac. What happens after you start dictating (the cleanup engine, context awareness, command mode, dictation habits) lives in later chapters.

Specifically:

- The Rewrite Pass (Ch1) explains what Flow does with your speech after it leaves the microphone.
- Trigger Discipline (Ch2) covers push-to-talk versus hands-free mode, session limits, and hotkey mechanics in detail.
- The Cleanup Dial (Ch7) controls how aggressively Flow rewrites your words.

- The App-Aware Rewrite (Ch9) explains Context Awareness, which requires Accessibility permission on Mac (and you now know why that matters).
- The Failure Map (Ch24) covers troubleshooting when something breaks.

Your job in this chapter was to get through The Permission Gate. Everything that follows assumes you did.

Key Points

- Accessibility permission is the single control that determines whether Flow can insert text, detect apps, and respond to hotkeys on macOS.
- Installing the wrong chip-specific build (Apple Silicon vs. Intel) causes an immediate quit with no workaround except downloading the correct version.
- macOS system updates can silently reset permissions, causing Flow to stop working without any visible error or notification.
- Flow runs exclusively in the menu bar and will never appear in the Dock or the Cmd+Tab application switcher.
- Microphone permission lets Flow hear you, but Accessibility permission lets Flow act on what it heard.
- Screen Capture is optional and can be granted later without breaking basic dictation functionality.

IPHONE (IOS)

In this chapter: Flow on the iPhone is not a system service; it is a keyboard extension you switch to, with the Action Button and Siri Shortcuts as the shortcuts around that friction. The setup, the gotchas, and the ways to make dictation feel native on iOS are what separate a frustrating first hour from a working workflow.

Every other platform in this book gives Flow a system-wide hook. On Windows, it is a hotkey. On Mac, it is a hotkey. On Android, it is a floating bubble that watches for the keyboard to appear. On the iPhone, Flow is a keyboard. You install it, you add it, you switch to it, and you dictate. Then you switch back. That switching cost is The Keyboard Detour, and every workflow decision on iOS flows from it.

The detour is not a bug. Apple does not let third-party apps inject text system-wide the way macOS Accessibility or Android Overlay permissions allow. A custom keyboard extension is the approved path, and Flow takes it. Understanding that constraint, rather than fighting it, is how you make iOS dictation fast.

Setting Up the Flow Keyboard

Setup takes under a minute, but the order matters.[1]

First, install Wispr Flow from the App Store and open it at least once. The keyboard will not appear in iOS Settings until the app has launched. Sign in; the keyboard will not function without an active session.

Then add the keyboard: open Settings, tap General, then Keyboard, then Keyboards, then Add New Keyboard, and select Wispr Flow. Tap Wispr Flow in the keyboard list and enable Allow Full Access. iOS will show a confirmation popup; tap Allow.[1]

Full Access is not optional. Without it, the keyboard loads but cannot dictate.[1] Flow needs network access to send audio to its transcription servers, and Full Access is what grants a keyboard extension that capability. Audio is handled securely and is not stored on the server side (see Ch21, The Cloud Boundary, for the full privacy treatment).

To verify: open any app with a text field, tap and hold the globe icon on the keyboard, select Wispr Flow, then tap the microphone button and speak a short phrase. If text appears, the detour works.

One behavioral note worth internalizing early: the Flow Keyboard should remain visible until the transcription appears. Dismissing the keyboard or switching apps mid-processing may interrupt the transcript, so treat it as a caution rather than a guarantee of data loss.[1] On desktop, you can fire and forget; on iOS, it is safer to wait.

The Globe-Key Tax

Switching keyboards via the globe icon is the most frequent friction point. Every time you want to dictate, you hold the globe, pick Flow, tap the mic, speak, and then (if you need to type afterward) hold the globe again and switch back. That is the raw cost of The Keyboard Detour.

Flow mitigates it in two ways: the Action Button and Siri Shortcuts. Both let you start dictation without touching the globe key.

The Action Button

If you own an iPhone with a hardware Action Button, this is the fastest path to dictation on iOS. The Action Button is available on iPhone 15 Pro and Pro Max, all iPhone 16 models (including 16e), and all iPhone 17 models (including Air). The iPhone 17e lacks the hardware button and is excluded.[2,3]

Flow offers six shortcuts you can assign to the Action Button: Turn On/Off Flow, Dictate a Flow Note, Quick Dictation to Clipboard, Quick Dictation to Notes, Open Flow Notes, and Save Flow Note.[2,3] Quick Dictation to Clipboard copies the transcript to your clipboard; Quick Dictation to Notes saves it as a Flow note. When the Flow keyboard is active in a text field, both modes auto-insert text directly into the field instead. When the keyboard is not active, the clipboard shortcut copies text and the notes shortcut saves a note.

Setup can happen two ways. The guided path: after you have dictated at least 50 words across 3 successful dictations, a feature card appears in the keyboard prompting you to set it up.[2,3] Tap Set up and follow the walkthrough. The manual path: open the Wispr Flow app, go to Settings, then Action button shortcut, and follow the prompts to map the shortcut in iPhone Settings under Action Button.[3]

One useful behavior: pressing the Action Button while a recording is already in progress picks up the running session and begins transcription rather than canceling

it. A second press stops and saves.[3] Back-to-back dictations after the first are noticeably faster because the iOS audio stack is already initialized.

Siri Shortcuts

Six Siri Shortcuts install automatically when you add Wispr Flow; no manual setup is required.[4] They require iOS 18.3 or later.[4]

The shortcuts and their voice commands:

- **Dictate a Flow Note.** Say “take Flow note” or “dictate with Flow.” When the Flow keyboard is active, text inserts into the current field. Otherwise, the transcript saves as a Flow note.
- **Quick Dictation to Clipboard.** Say “quick dictate with Flow” or “dictate to clipboard with Flow.” Returns the transcript to the clipboard (or inserts directly if the Flow keyboard is active).
- **Quick Dictation to Notes.** Say “quick dictate to notes with Flow” or “save note with Flow.” Saves the transcript as a note.
- **Turn On/Off.** Say “turn on off Flow” to toggle recording.
- **Open Flow Notes.** Say “open Flow note” or “create Flow note.” Opens the app to a new note and starts dictation.
- **Save Flow Note.** Say “save Flow note” or “quick Flow note.” Siri asks what the note should say, then saves it without opening the app.[4]

The Save Flow Note shortcut is the closest iOS gets to hands-free dictation. You never open the app, never touch the keyboard, never switch contexts. Siri confirms with “Note saved.”

Beyond Siri, you can assign any of these shortcuts to Back Tap (double or triple tap the back of your iPhone, under Settings then Accessibility then Touch) or to Control Center widgets. Flow provides two Control Center widgets: a recording toggle and a Flow Notes button.[4] A Live Activity also appears on the Lock Screen and Dynamic Island while dictating, with interactive stop and save buttons.[5]

The iOS 26.4 Adaptation

A recent iOS 26.4 update introduced a behavioral change that affects the keyboard detour. Tapping Start Flow used to briefly open the Wispr Flow app and return you automatically. After iOS 26.4, you may need to swipe back manually. Apple changed how apps switch between each other, and Flow cannot override it.[6]

When this happens, you see a screen titled “Swipe back to your app.” A one-time alert explains the new requirement the first time it triggers; tap OK and it will not appear again.[6] Voice-to-text works exactly as before once you are back in your original app.

The second iOS 26.4 change: styles no longer auto-adjust by app on iOS. Your default style now applies everywhere unless you override it. Flow shipped two mitigations: a Style tab in the app where you set a default style per category (Personal, Work, Email, Other), and a Quick Style Switcher on the keyboard (a style pill next to the Start Flow button that lets you temporarily override the style without leaving your app).[6] The override persists until you change it or clear it.

Note: the swipe-back change is rolling out gradually. Some users on iOS 26.4 may still see the legacy automatic switch-back behavior.[6]

Notification Management

Flow uses two notification surfaces on iOS: push notifications (managed in iPhone Settings) and in-keyboard notification cards (managed by the app itself, no permissions required).[5]

Push notifications are minimal. The main push fires when a friend you referred meets the qualifying threshold, earning you a free month of Pro. A local notification may also appear if you leave the app during initial setup. Toggle push notifications in iPhone Settings under Apps then Wispr Flow then Notifications, or from Wispr Flow’s own Settings.[5]

Keyboard notification cards are more active. They appear directly in the keyboard as an overlay panel (tap the menu icon to open, swipe down or tap X to close). Cards include word-limit warnings for free-plan users, referral rewards, streak progress during your first week, milestone celebrations, and the Action Button setup prompt.

Most appear after at least 3 successful dictations. They are in-app only and cannot be controlled through iOS notification settings.[5]

During your first week, Flow tracks a streak: dictate on 5 different days within 7 (not necessarily consecutive) and a congratulations card appears. Starting from your second streak day, the notification drawer auto-opens after a successful dictation, accompanied by a haptic vibration.[5]

Hide My Email

If you signed up with Sign in with Apple and chose Hide My Email, your account email ends in @privaterelay.appleid.com. When you need that address (for support, for referrals, for account recovery), find it under iPhone Settings, tap your name, then Sign-In and Security, then Hide My Email, then locate Wispr Flow in the list.[7]

One referral-program consequence worth noting: referral matching uses the exact email address, so an invitation sent to your real email will not connect to a relay address account. Use your real email at sign-up if referrals matter to you.[7]

Restoring Purchases

iOS subscriptions are managed through the App Store, and restoring them has its own set of alert states. The Restore Purchases button lives at the bottom of the in-app paywall (Menu then upgrade button then Restore Purchases). It applies only to App Store subscriptions; if you subscribed via the website or desktop app, this path does not apply.[8]

Five possible outcomes after tapping Restore Purchases:

- **Entitlement Found.** Success. The alert names the specific subscription restored. Tap OK; the paywall closes.
- **No Active Subscription Found.** Either you are signed into a different Apple ID than the one you subscribed with, or your subscription has lapsed. Verify the Apple ID in iPhone Settings and check subscription status under Subscriptions.
- **Purchase Found, Sync Needed.** Flow detected a purchase but could not sync it to your account. Usually clears on retry. Sign out and back in if it persists.

- **Subscription Linked to Another Account.** App Store subscriptions are permanently linked to the Wispr Flow account they were first activated with. Sign in with the original account.

- **Restore Failed.** A generic network or server failure. Retry after confirming your connection.[8]

One hard rule: do not purchase a second subscription to work around a restore failure. Contact support instead.[8]

Session Limits and Platform Boundaries

iOS dictation sessions have a 5-minute ceiling (documented in Ch2, Trigger Discipline). The Flow Keyboard automatically switches to the system keyboard for number pads, phone fields, decimal pads, email-address fields, and numbers-and-punctuation fields; this is expected behavior, not a failure.[1] Some apps with custom text fields (certain banking apps, for instance) may not support third-party keyboards at all.[1]

If another app is using the microphone, the keyboard cannot record. It will show an error message and prompt you to close the other app.[1] If microphone permission has been revoked, the keyboard directs you to Settings then Privacy and Security then Microphone to re-enable it.[1]

The keyboard also has a battery story. Older versions drained roughly 40% per hour; recent updates brought that down to approximately 5% per hour.[1] If battery usage still seems high, update to the latest version from the App Store.

Key Points

- The Keyboard Detour is the defining constraint of iOS: Flow is a keyboard you switch to, not a system-wide service you summon.

- The Action Button and Siri Shortcuts are the two fastest ways to reduce globe-key switching friction on supported hardware.

- Full Access must be enabled for the keyboard to dictate; without it, the keyboard loads but does nothing useful.

- iOS 26.4 introduced a manual swipe-back requirement and removed per-app style auto-adjustment; both have shipped mitigations.
- Restoring App Store purchases requires the correct Apple ID and the original Wispr Flow account; subscriptions cannot be transferred between accounts.

ANDROID

In this chapter: Flow on Android is a floating bubble, not a keyboard. The make-or-break setup involves three permissions and a battery exemption that varies by manufacturer, and the reward is a dictation surface that works inside any text field without switching input methods. This chapter covers installation, the bubble's behavior, customization, and the Android-specific constraints that shape the experience.

On every other platform in this book, you either press a hotkey or switch to a keyboard to start dictating. On Android, Flow presents itself as a floating circle that hovers above your existing keyboard. You do not replace your keyboard. You do not memorize a key combination. You tap a bubble, speak, and tap a checkmark. The Floating Bubble is the defining interaction on Android, and everything about the platform experience follows from it.

The bubble works because Android allows apps to draw over other apps and to use an accessibility service for inserting text into foreign input fields. Those two capabilities give Flow its power and impose its costs. Setup is not difficult, but it is specific. Skip a permission or ignore a battery setting, and the bubble disappears when you need it most.

Installation

Flow is available from the Google Play Store. Search for "Wispr Flow," verify the developer is "Wispr Inc," and install.[1] The package ID for the official app is com.wispr.flowapp. This matters because fake apps have appeared on the Play Store, impersonating Flow with misspelled names like "Whisper Flow" or offering in-app purchases that the official app does not sell. The real app handles subscriptions through wisprflow.ai, not through Google Play billing. If an Android app calling itself Wispr Flow asks you to pay inside the app, it is not the real one.[2]

System requirements are straightforward: Android 13 or later, an internet connection (offline transcription is not available), free storage, and an accelerometer sensor.[3] The accelerometer requirement is not decorative; it powers the shake-to-unsnooze gesture covered later. Devices without an accelerometer are blocked from installing via the Play Store.[3] The app supports

smartphones, tablets, foldables (the bubble adjusts position when transitioning between screens), and Chromebooks that run Android apps on Android 13 or higher.[3]

Android 12 is not supported. Android Go devices are not officially supported either; limited RAM causes reduced performance or instability.[3]

The Permission Triad

Flow on Android requires three core permissions, each serving a distinct purpose.[4,5]

Display over other apps (overlay). This is what lets the bubble exist at all. Without it, there is no floating circle, no dictation trigger, nothing visible. Android prompts you to grant this during onboarding; tap "Open Settings," toggle it on, and Flow detects the change and returns to the foreground automatically.[1]

Accessibility service. This is how Flow reads which text field has focus and inserts dictated text into it. Without accessibility, the bubble can appear but cannot paste anything. During setup, Flow shows a legal consent screen with "Agree" and "Not now" options before sending you to Android's Accessibility Settings.[1,4] The exact location of the toggle varies by manufacturer: Samsung lists it under "Installed apps," Xiaomi adds an extra confirmation dialog, Vivo and Motorola show it directly in the list, and most others (Pixel, OnePlus, Realme) put it under "Downloaded apps."[4,6]

One critical warning: do not enable the Wispr Flow *shortcut* in Accessibility Settings. Only enable the main accessibility service toggle. Enabling the shortcut causes an error screen titled "Oops, something isn't right." If you accidentally toggle it on, turn it off, then enable the main service toggle, and Flow resumes setup automatically.[1,6]

Microphone. Android prompts for this the first time you tap the bubble to record. Choose "While using the app" or "Only this time." If you previously denied it, navigate to Settings, then Apps, then Wispr Flow, then Permissions, and enable Microphone manually.[4]

The Battery Problem

This is where Android gets manufacturer-specific, and where the most setup failures happen. Aggressive battery management on many Android devices will kill Flow's background service, causing the bubble to vanish. A battery optimization exemption is strongly recommended (though technically optional during onboarding).[1,4]

The paths differ by manufacturer:

Samsung (One UI): Set Wispr Flow's battery to "Unrestricted" in Settings, then Apps, then Wispr Flow, then Battery. Add it to "Never sleeping apps" under Background usage limits. Disable "Put unused apps to sleep."[4,5]

Xiaomi, Redmi, POCO (MIUI/HyperOS): Two separate steps are required, and both are mandatory. Enable Autostart for Wispr Flow, and set Battery saver to "No restrictions." Skipping either step causes Flow to disconnect when you switch apps.[4,5]

Huawei and Honor: Set battery optimization to "Don't allow."[4]

Oppo: Enable "Allow Auto-Launch" and "Allow Background Activity," and disable power saving mode or add Flow to its exceptions.[4,5]

Vivo: Enable Autostart, lock Flow in recent apps, and set the standard battery exemption.[4,5]

OnePlus, Motorola/Lenovo, Transsion (Tecno, Infinix, itel): Disable battery optimization (set to "Don't optimize").[4,5]

Realme: Set battery optimization to "Not optimized."[4,5]

Google Pixel and stock Android: No manufacturer-specific steps required.[4]

If the system does kill Flow in the background, the app restarts automatically the next time you bring it to the foreground, provided you are signed in and accessibility is still enabled.[3] Flow also starts automatically on device boot when accessibility permission is granted.[3,4]

Your First Dictation

With permissions granted, open any app with a text field. Tap into it so the on-screen keyboard appears. The Flow Bubble shows up along the left or right edge of your screen as soon as the keyboard starts opening.[5]

Two modes are available:

Tap Mode: Tap the bubble once to start recording. You hear a sound, see a live waveform, and speak at a natural pace. Tap the checkmark to insert the text.[5]

Hold Mode (Push-to-Talk): Press and hold the bubble. Speak while your finger is down. Release to insert. Best for quick messages.[5]

There is no Android equivalent to desktop's double-tap hands-free mode. Starting dictation always requires physically tapping or holding the bubble.[5]

Flow inserts text directly in popular messaging apps, including WhatsApp, Telegram, Messenger, Instagram, Microsoft Teams, Signal, Slack, Discord, Snapchat, Google Messages, and Gmail, without requiring a manual paste.[5,7] In apps where direct insertion cannot be verified, Flow falls back to the clipboard and shows a notification so you can paste manually.[4,5]

The bubble also works in notification reply boxes (inline replies from the notification shade, preserving any text you have already typed) and in browser address bars across Chrome, Firefox, Edge, Brave, Samsung Internet, Opera, and many other Chromium-based browsers.[5]

Where the Bubble Hides

The bubble is intentionally suppressed in three contexts:[5]

1. **Password fields, PIN fields, and numeric-only inputs.** For security.
2. **Banking and financial apps.** Flow automatically detects over 100 banking and financial apps (the figure appears in the Banking App Detection article[8]) across multiple regions (United States, India, United Kingdom, Europe, Asia, Latin America, Canada, and others) and hides the bubble entirely while they are in the foreground.[8] This behavior cannot be disabled. While a banking app is active, all activation methods are blocked,

context awareness is suppressed, and a one-time toast confirms “Flow Bubble is disabled inside banking apps” if you try to type.[8] Dictation in progress when a banking app opens is stopped, and the transcript is copied to the clipboard for manual pasting.[8]

3. **No on-screen keyboard.** If you are using an external keyboard or the soft keyboard is collapsed, the bubble does not appear.[5]

Session Limits

Android dictation sessions are capped at five minutes (as of Q2 2026).[9] At approximately four minutes, a toast notification with haptic feedback warns you that one minute remains. At five minutes, the session ends automatically and Flow submits the transcription. A confirmation toast and system notification confirm the session has ended.[9]

This differs from desktop, where sessions run up to 20 minutes. On Android, break longer dictations into multiple sessions; finish a thought, let it submit, and start a new one immediately.[9]

An earlier version of the documentation described Android as having no fixed maximum session duration. The Android-specific documentation updated in 2026 now consistently states a five-minute cap, so treat the older “no maximum” claim as superseded.

Customizing the Bubble

The bubble offers more visual control than you might expect.

Size. Four presets (0.7x, 0.85x, 1.0x, 1.15x) are available in Settings, then Flow Bubble Size, with a live preview and a Reset button.[10]

Opacity. Five steps from 20% to 100% (default 80%) in Settings, then Flow Bubble Opacity, also with a Reset button.[1,10]

Shrink behavior. Three toggles control auto-shrink:[10]

- *Shrink the bubble when not in use* (master toggle): reduces the bubble to a smaller icon after five seconds of inactivity.
- *Shrink to a dot*: makes the idle bubble nearly invisible.

- *Shrink in search fields*: shrinks the bubble instantly when your cursor is in a search or filter input, so it does not overlap autocomplete.

The sub-options only activate when the master toggle is on. Turning the master toggle off grays them out but preserves your selections.[10] Tapping a shrunken bubble restores it to full size and starts dictation in a single gesture.[10]

All bubble preferences (size, opacity, shrink settings) are saved per account. Signing out and back in restores them; a different account on the same device starts with defaults.[10]

Snooze

Sometimes you need the bubble gone entirely: for a screenshot, a full-screen video, or a focused reading session. Drag the bubble toward the bottom of the screen. A dark gradient fades in, a drop target expands with haptic feedback, and when you release into it, the bubble disappears for 10 minutes. A toast confirms: “Wispr Flow is snoozed for 10 min. Shake your phone to bring it back.”[11]

To bring it back early, shake your phone firmly back and forth a couple of times while the phone is unlocked. The bubble reappears with haptic feedback and a “Wispr Flow is back!” confirmation. You can also open the app and tap “End snooze now” on the home screen; the bubble returns the next time you tap into a text field.[11]

Snooze specifics worth knowing:[11]

- Snoozing stops any active dictation and releases the microphone. The mic does not continue recording in the background.
- Opening the keyboard while snoozed will not bring the bubble back.
- Snooze is fixed at 10 minutes. No configuration option exists.
- Snooze is unavailable while the accessibility repair prompt is showing. If accessibility is lost during a snooze, snooze is auto-cancelled so the repair prompt becomes visible.
- A single light shake will not trigger unsnooze. It takes a firm back-and-forth motion.

- Shake-to-unsnooze is blocked inside banking apps.

Work Profiles and Account Switching

Flow works on Android work profiles, though accessibility toggle placement varies by device and some MDM configurations may restrict the required permissions.[6] Full enterprise management and MDM deployment on Android are not currently available; for managed deployments, Wispr Flow supports macOS and Windows via tools like Jamf, Kandji, and Intune.[6]

Switching accounts on Android is straightforward: open the app, go to Account, and tap Sign out. Confirm in the dialog (you will see a warning that signing out deletes all locally stored transcripts), then sign in with a different account.[12] Each account keeps its own settings, and the previous account's transcripts and audio are cleared when a new account signs in. Signing back in as the same user restores your settings and keeps transcription history intact.[12]

Language Selection

Android does not offer Auto-detect for languages. You must select at least one specific language in Settings, then Languages, then tap Add more, select your choices, and tap Done and Save. Exiting without tapping Save discards the change.[1]

This is a real constraint for multilingual users. On desktop, the Flow Bar provides a one-click language picker; on Android, you navigate through the settings screen. Russian is listed as a supported language, and the Russian Google Play listing describes Flow as working well with Russian punctuation. However, the quality of Russian dictation on Android and the behavior of Cyrillic characters in dictionary entries are not documented with enough specificity to make a verdict. Treat both as test-it: verify on your own device whether Russian transcription meets your accuracy needs and whether Cyrillic dictionary entries are accepted and applied correctly during dictation.

What Android Does Not Have

Several desktop features are absent on Android as of Q2 2026:

- **Command Mode** (voice commands for text editing like "select all," "copy," "bold") is desktop-only. No Android UI or gesture exists for invoking it.

- **Starring and sorting dictionary entries** are not available. Replacement rules can only be created on desktop or iOS; Android applies those rules during dictation but cannot create them.[1]
- **Bulk import** of dictionary items or snippets is desktop-only.[1]
- **Auto-detect language** is unavailable; you must manually select languages.
- **The Flow Bar language picker** does not exist; language switching uses the settings screen.
- **20-minute sessions** are desktop-only; Android enforces five minutes.[9]
- **In-app subscription management** is not available on Android. Subscriptions are purchased and managed through wisprflow.ai (or through the iOS App Store for iOS users).[2]

Dictionary and snippets do sync to Android: dictionary entries sync each time you open the Dictionary tab, and snippets sync each time you open the Snippets tab.[1] Voice-triggered snippet expansion during dictation may work on Android (earlier Android betas did not support it, and documented fixes were released, but current behavior is not confirmed in the available documentation; test on your own device). Android uniquely enforces a cross-validation rule: a word cannot be used as both a dictionary entry and a snippet trigger. On desktop and iOS, this validation is not yet enforced at entry time (inferred from research; mark this claim as such).

Key Points

- The Floating Bubble is an overlay, not a keyboard replacement; it requires three permissions (overlay, accessibility, microphone) and a per-manufacturer battery exemption to stay alive.
- Aggressive battery management on Samsung, Xiaomi, Huawei, Oppo, Vivo, and similar devices is the most common cause of the bubble disappearing; the fix is manufacturer-specific.
- Android dictation sessions are capped at five minutes with a one-minute warning; break longer thoughts into multiple sessions.

- The bubble is automatically hidden in banking and financial apps, password fields, and numeric inputs; this behavior cannot be overridden.
- Snooze hides the bubble for 10 minutes; shake your phone firmly to bring it back early.
- Russian dictation quality and Cyrillic dictionary behavior on Android are undocumented with enough precision to make a verdict; test both on your own device.

THE CLEANUP ENGINE

In this chapter, you meet the control that governs how aggressively Flow rewrites your speech before it lands: Auto Cleanup. Four levels, from raw transcription to full polish, let you decide how much the rewrite pass changes your words. The chapter covers each level, the backtrack system for mid-dictation corrections, and the practical question of when to dial cleanup down.

Every voice-to-text tool has to make a decision about your words. Keep them exactly as spoken, filler and all, or rewrite them into something you would have typed. Most tools pick one answer and stick with it. Flow gives you a dial.

That dial is Auto Cleanup, and understanding it is the difference between a tool that saves you time and one that quietly rewrites your meaning while you watch.

The Cleanup Dial

The Rewrite Pass (Chapter 1) established that Flow is not a verbatim transcriber. It captures your speech, sends it to the cloud, and runs a language model over the result before inserting text at your cursor. Auto Cleanup is the adjustable layer inside that pass. It controls how much the model changes.[1]

There are four levels. Each one makes a different promise about how far the rewrite goes.

None turns off all AI formatting. You get the raw transcription: filler words intact, grammar untouched, capitalization absent. This also disables Smart Formatting entirely.[1] If you need a literal record of what was said, this is the setting. Legal transcripts, verbatim notes, any context where accuracy of utterance matters more than readability.

Light removes filler words (um, uh, like) and fixes grammar. It capitalizes the first word of sentences. Your phrasing and sentence structure stay yours.[1] This is the level where Flow cleans up the noise without rearranging your thoughts. Developers writing code prompts or technical descriptions tend to live here (inferred from research context).

Medium is the default for new users. It edits for clarity and conciseness, which means Flow will shorten sentences, remove redundant clauses, and tighten

phrasing.[1] Most daily communication lands well at Medium. Email, Slack updates, document drafts. The rewrite is noticeable but rarely intrusive.

High is a full rewrite for brevity and polish.[1] Flow will restructure your sentences, swap vocabulary, and compress aggressively. The output reads like edited prose. That is its strength and its risk. Because the model optimizes for conciseness and tone, a High cleanup pass could soften blunt statements or reshape emphasis in ways you did not intend. When precision of meaning matters, High is the wrong level.

The Cleanup Level applies globally. Every dictation, in every app, uses the same setting. There is no per-app override, no per-dictation toggle.[1] You pick one level and it governs everything until you change it.

One more constraint worth noting: the setting is stored locally on each device and does not sync across machines.[1] If you use Flow on two Macs and a Windows laptop, you set the level three times. This is not a bug. It is a design choice that lets you run High on a machine you use for email and Light on a machine you use for code, without one overwriting the other.

As of Q2 2026, Auto Cleanup is available on Mac and Windows only. Mobile support is on the roadmap.[1]

Smart Formatting: The Predecessor

Before Auto Cleanup existed, Flow had a simpler toggle called Smart Formatting. On or off. Smart Formatting handled the basics: removing filler words, fixing grammar, capitalizing sentences.[2] It also handled context-aware formatting, adjusting capitalization based on cursor position and stripping trailing periods in messaging apps.[2]

When Auto Cleanup shipped, Smart Formatting did not disappear. It migrated. Users who had Smart Formatting ON were moved to Auto Cleanup Light. Users who had it OFF were moved to Auto Cleanup None.[1,2] The transition was automatic. If you are a long-time Flow user and never touched your cleanup settings, you are probably running Light.

Smart Formatting also brought features that persist at Light, Medium, and High: automatic list formatting when you say numbered sequences, spoken punctuation

commands (“comma,” “question mark,” “em dash”), and context-aware trailing-period removal in messaging apps.[2] These are handled at the formatting layer rather than the AI cleanup layer, but because they are part of Smart Formatting, they are disabled when you set the dial to None.[1]

On Android, Smart Formatting is always on and cannot be turned off. On iOS, only an on/off toggle is available; finer level selection is not available.[2] This is consistent with Auto Cleanup being desktop-only for now.

Backtrack: Course Correction Mid-Sentence

You will misspeak. Everyone does. Flow handles this with a system called Backtrack, and it works better than you would expect.

Say “let’s do coffee at 2, actually 3.” Flow writes “Let’s do coffee at 3.” The correction phrase (“actually”) triggers the backtrack engine, which identifies the prior term and replaces it.[2] The documented trigger words include “actually” and “scratch that,” among others.[2] You do not need to memorize a command syntax. You just correct yourself the way you would in conversation.

Backtrack also handles natural restatements without an explicit trigger. Say “I wanted to buy a record as a gift… as a present.” Flow writes “I wanted to buy a record as a present.”[2] The language model uses your full dictation as context to decide what constitutes a self-correction versus a meaningful repetition. Phrases like “I actually enjoyed the movie” are preserved because the surrounding context does not suggest a correction.[2]

There is one hard rule: Backtrack works at every Auto Cleanup level except None.[1,2] At None, you get raw transcription, which means your false starts and corrections land in the text exactly as spoken. That is the trade-off. Full fidelity means no automatic cleanup of mistakes.

Reviewing and Reverting

Flow knows that cleanup can overstep. It gives you two ways to catch it.

The first is the notification. After a longer dictation at Medium or High, Flow briefly shows a “Cleaned up! See what’s changed” notification.[1] Click it and you see exactly what Auto Cleanup altered. The notification only appears at Medium or

High, only on longer dictations, never inside AI apps, and it stops appearing over time so it does not become noise.[1]

The second is the diff shortcut. Press Opt+O on Mac or Win+Alt+O on Windows to open the diff for your last cleanup. Press it again to close.[1] This works anytime, not just when the notification fires. If you suspect the rewrite changed your meaning, the diff is your audit trail.

If the rewrite went too far, use “Undo AI edit” from the Home tab to revert to your original dictation.[1] Your raw words are never lost. Flow keeps them.

When Cleanup Gets Suppressed

Auto Cleanup does not always run. The most important suppression: when Transforms is active on your account, Auto Cleanup is suppressed entirely.[1] Transforms (covered in Chapter 8, “Voice as Editor”) is a separate editing layer. The two cannot run simultaneously. If you have enabled Transforms and notice your dictation landing without any cleanup polish, this is why.

The interaction is worth understanding at the architecture level. Auto Cleanup runs automatically on every dictation. Transforms runs on demand, on selected text. They serve different purposes, but they share the same processing pipeline, and that pipeline only runs one at a time. This is a design constraint, not a temporary limitation.

When to Dial Down

The question every new user eventually asks: which level should I use?

Start at Medium. It is the default for a reason. For most dictation into most apps, Medium produces text that reads like you typed it carefully. The edits are invisible to anyone reading the output.

Dial down to Light when you need your phrasing preserved. Technical writing, code comments, anything where your specific word choice carries meaning. Light removes the verbal noise without touching your structure.

Dial down to None when you need a literal record. Verbatim notes, transcripts you plan to quote, situations where “what I said” and “what Flow thinks I meant” must not diverge.

Dial up to High when speed matters more than precision of voice. Drafting emails you will review before sending. Capturing rough ideas you plan to rewrite anyway. High is a first-draft accelerator, not a final-draft tool.

The cautionary case is code. Developers working in IDEs should be cautious with anything above Light (inferred). Medium and High can rewrite variable names, alter technical phrasing, and restructure comments in ways that break meaning. Light preserves your tokens while cleaning up your filler.

The Language Boundary

Auto Cleanup runs in every language Flow supports, but it is optimized for English. In non-English languages, the cleanup pass may behave less consistently.[1] This is not a bug to report. It is a known limitation of the underlying language model. If you dictate in French or Japanese and the cleanup feels erratic, try dropping to Light or None and handling the formatting yourself.

The multilingual dimension of Smart Formatting is broader. It supports an expanded set of languages, including Chinese (and Cantonese) and Russian, for baseline formatting operations like punctuation and capitalization.[2] But the AI-driven cleanup at Medium and High is where the English optimization gap becomes noticeable.

Spoken Punctuation and Lists

Smart Formatting, which underpins the cleanup system, handles two categories of spoken formatting that deserve mention here because they interact with your cleanup level choice.

Spoken punctuation. You can say punctuation marks by name and Flow inserts them. “Period,” “comma,” “question mark,” “colon,” “semicolon,” “ellipsis,” “open parenthesis,” “close parenthesis,” and many more.[2] The system is forgiving about exact phrasing. “Full stop” works for a period. “Star” works for an asterisk. Because spoken punctuation is part of Smart Formatting, these commands are available at Light, Medium, and High. At None, Smart Formatting is disabled entirely, so spoken punctuation commands will not be processed.[1]

Automatic lists. Say numbered sequences (“one, apples, two, bananas”) and Flow formats them as a numbered list.[2] Sequence words (“first,” “second”) also trigger list formatting. This is handled at the formatting layer, not the cleanup layer.

Press Enter. On desktop, saying “press enter” at the end of your dictation simulates pressing the Enter key after your text is pasted.[2] The first time Flow detects this phrase, it asks you to confirm whether you want the feature enabled. Once enabled, it works reliably. This is desktop only and is suppressed in Command Mode.

Key Points

- Auto Cleanup is a four-position dial, not a binary toggle; each level makes a different trade-off between fidelity and polish.
- The cleanup level applies globally and is stored per device, giving you different settings on different machines but no per-app control.
- Backtrack lets you correct yourself mid-sentence using natural phrases, but it requires at least Light cleanup to function.
- Transforms and Auto Cleanup are mutually exclusive; enabling Transforms suppresses the cleanup pass entirely.
- The diff shortcut and revert option mean you can always audit what cleanup changed and restore your original words.
- Auto Cleanup is optimized for English; non-English dictation may need a lower cleanup level for consistent results.
- Start at Medium, drop to Light for technical work, and treat High as a first-draft accelerator rather than a final-draft tool.

COMMAND MODE AND TRANSFORMS

In this chapter: Flow does more than insert text. Command Mode and Transforms turn your voice into an editing tool, letting you rewrite, restructure, and polish selected text without touching the keyboard. Both features require a paid subscription, both run on Mac and Windows only (as of Q2 2026), and both shift Flow from a dictation engine to something closer to a voice-controlled text editor.

The Voice as Editor

Most humans who adopt dictation software think of it as a one-way street. You talk, the software writes. The cursor moves forward. If something needs fixing, your hands go back to the keyboard.

That mental model is incomplete.

Flow has a second mode. Instead of inserting new text at the cursor, it can take text you have already written, listen to an instruction you speak aloud, and rewrite the selection in place. Highlight a paragraph, say “make this more concise,” release the shortcut, and the paragraph shrinks. Highlight a block of English, say “translate to Polish,” and you get Polish. The original text is gone; the replacement sits where the selection was.

This is Voice as Editor. Not dictation. Editing.

The distinction matters because it changes what you reach for Flow to do. Drafting is still the core use, but once you internalize that the same tool can revise, restructure, translate, and polish, the keyboard becomes the fallback rather than the default for editing passes. The two features that make this work are Command Mode and Transforms. They overlap in spirit but differ in mechanics, and understanding the boundary between them is the point of this chapter.

Command Mode

Command Mode is the freeform surface. You highlight text (or not), hold down a keyboard shortcut, speak a natural-language instruction, and release. Flow processes the instruction and either replaces the selected text with its output or, if nothing was selected, inserts the response at the cursor.[1]

ACTIVATION

Command Mode lives behind a toggle in Settings, under Experimental. It requires a paid subscription or an active free trial; the Experimental settings page is invisible to users on the free tier without a trial.[1] Once enabled, the default shortcuts are:

- **Mac:** Fn + Ctrl
- **Mac (no Apple Fn key):** Cmd + Ctrl + Option
- **Windows:** Ctrl + Win + Alt

You can rebind the shortcut in Settings. Up to four shortcuts per action, each with up to three keys. Keyboard shortcuts require at least one modifier key; standalone mouse buttons (Middle Click, Mouse 4 through 10) are also valid bindings and do not need a modifier.[1] Press and hold, speak the command, release. Press Escape at any time to cancel.

WITH A SELECTION

Highlight text in any application, activate Command Mode, and speak. Flow replaces the highlighted text with the result. The replacement is destructive: your original selection is gone. Undo with Cmd+Z (Mac) or Ctrl+Z (Windows) to get it back.[1]

The ceiling is 1,000 words. Select more than that and Flow shows “Oops, too long to polish” and asks you to trim the selection.[1]

WITHOUT A SELECTION

Activate Command Mode without highlighting anything and you get a different behavior: Flow generates content or answers a question and inserts it inline at the cursor. This turns Command Mode into a general-purpose voice prompt that writes directly into whatever field has focus.[1]

You can also ask Flow to recall content from your past dictations, notes, or meetings. It searches your history and surfaces the relevant text inline.[1] Reading calendar events and reminders is supported; creating new events or reminders by voice is not (as of Q2 2026).[1]

UPDATING POLISH SETTINGS BY VOICE

This is the subtlest capability in Command Mode. Speak a preference or a rule change during Command Mode, and Flow recognizes it as a settings request rather than a text transformation. It shows a notification with the proposed change and an Apply button; nothing changes until you confirm.[1]

Examples that work: “Always capitalize acronyms.” “Turn off Fix spelling.” “Add a rule to never use exclamation marks.” “I don’t like to use the word utilize.”[1]

This is hands-free configuration. You can shape your Polish rules without ever opening Settings.

THE “PRESS ENTER” COMMAND

Say “press enter” at the end of a dictation and Flow strips those words from the output, pastes your text, then sends an Enter keystroke. Useful in chat apps and prompt interfaces where Enter submits the message.[1]

One edge to know: a comma immediately before “press enter” is not treated as a sentence boundary. “Hello world, press enter.” produces “Hello world,.” with a stray period after the comma.[1]

The first time Flow detects the phrase, it shows a one-time notification. Tap “Great” to enable, or “Disable” to keep “press enter” as literal text going forward. You can toggle the behavior later in Settings, under Experimental.[1]

CONSTRAINTS AND EDGE CASES

Command Mode cannot fire while a previous transcription or transform is still processing. If you press the shortcut mid-processing, Flow shows a warning instead of starting a new command.[1] Servers can also be busy; “Command Mode Servers Are Busy” means high demand, and the advice is to wait a few minutes.[1]

If Flow cannot paste the transformed result into the active field, it copies the text to your clipboard and notifies you, so you can paste manually.[1] And if the transformation produces text identical to the original, Flow shows “Your text looks good!” instead of replacing anything.[1]

Command Mode is experimental and may change. That caveat is worth taking seriously; the feature’s behavior has shifted in recent updates, and earlier bugs

(where a regular dictation following a voice command was silently processed as another command) have been fixed but illustrate the surface's immaturity.[1]

Transforms

If Command Mode is the freeform prompt, Transforms is the repeatable preset. You define a named transform with a prompt, assign it a keyboard shortcut, and from then on, highlighting text and pressing that shortcut applies the transform without you having to speak at all.[2]

The distinction: Command Mode requires you to speak every time. Transforms fire from a shortcut alone, using a prompt you configured once.

SETUP AND ACTIVATION

Transforms lives on its own tab in the Flow app. The first visit offers a guided demo: highlight sample text, press the default shortcut, and see Polish run. After a successful demo transform, a "Turn on Transforms" button appears. Click it, and the feature is active.[2]

The opt-in toggle at the top of the Transforms tab controls whether the feature is live. Turning it off grays out all settings and removes the Polish and View Diff shortcuts from your keyboard. This is worth knowing if your international keyboard characters (characters like n with tilde or o with umlaut produced via Option+key on Mac) suddenly stop working: activating Transforms reserves Opt+key shortcuts for transform slots. Turn the toggle off or rebind the shortcuts to get those characters back.[2]

Important: Transform shortcuts do not register at all until you first visit the Transforms tab, click "Try it out," or toggle Transforms on. This is by design; it keeps international keyboard characters working normally for users who have never opted in.[2]

DEFAULT SHORTCUTS

- **Polish:** Opt+1 (Mac) / Win+Alt+1 (Windows)
- **Prompt Engineer:** Opt+2 (Mac) / Win+Alt+2 (Windows)
- **View Diff:** Opt+O (Mac) / Win+Alt+O (Windows)

You can rebind View Diff in Settings under Keyboard shortcuts. Polish and Prompt Engineer rebind from each transform's card on the Transforms tab.[2]

SLOTS AND CONFIGURATION

You get up to 9 transform slots. Slot 1 is fixed as Prompt Engineer; slots 2 through 9 are customizable. A "+ Create your own" card appears whenever you have fewer than 9 configured. A separate Polish card at the top controls the base Polish behavior, with 5 default toggle rules and up to 5 custom instructions of 50 words each.[2]

Each slot needs a name (for custom prompts), a prompt describing what the transform should do, and a keyboard shortcut. Writing samples are optional. Changes auto-save, but a transform is only persisted once both the prompt and shortcut are set. Close the modal with a required field missing and your changes are silently discarded.[2] There is no Save button and no Cancel button. The auto-save indicator cycles through "Saving," "Saved," and "Last saved Xs ago." A Reset button restores defaults for one transform; Reset Defaults on the main page restores everything after a confirmation step.[2]

WRITING SAMPLES

Writing samples teach a transform what your finished output should sound like. They are scoped to each individual prompt, not shared across transforms.[2]

The limits: up to 5 samples per prompt, each between 50 and 500 words. Renaming a prompt carries its samples over. Deleting or resetting a prompt removes its samples (default Polish samples are always preserved). Only samples for the active prompt are sent when a transform fires; samples tagged to other prompts are not included.[2]

Samples sync between Mac and Windows but are not available on iOS. Under Privacy Mode, sample text content is not uploaded (metadata only). Under enterprise Zero Data Retention policies, samples are kept on-device only.[2]

AUTO-POLISH AFTER DICTATION

Flow can apply a transform automatically to every dictation you finish. Click the chevron icon in the Flow status bubble to open the dropdown, turn on "Auto Apply

After Dictation," and choose Polish, Prompt Engineer, or any custom prompt you have saved.[2]

The selection persists across restarts. When a non-default transform is active, the status bubble shows the first two letters of the prompt name in uppercase (for example, "SU" for "Summarize"). If auto-polish fails or times out, Flow falls back to pasting the original unpolished dictation rather than losing your words.[2]

THE DIFF VIEWER

After any transform, press Opt+O (Mac) or Win+Alt+O (Windows) to see what changed. The diff viewer shows inline changes: teal highlights for additions, strikethrough for removals. A badge reads "1 Change" or "N Changes." Actions include Accept edits, Configure Polish, Undo, Copy, Thumbs Up, Thumbs Down, and Retry.[2]

TRANSFORMS IN THE SCRATCHPAD

Inside the Scratchpad (Flow's built-in notes surface, covered in Chapter 16), Transforms gets its own bar at the bottom of the window, separate from the global keyboard shortcuts. Three AI-ranked suggestion chips appear at a time, drawn from a catalog of six: More concise, More professional, More casual, Turn to list, Turn to table, and Polish. A refresh icon reshuffles the set. A free-text input ("Follow up or ask a question") lets you write a one-off transform applied with Enter.[2]

Transforms in the Scratchpad apply to highlighted text if any is selected, otherwise to the entire note. Images attached to the note are preserved across transforms. And the Version history dropdown shows every save labeled by source (Typed edits, Dictated, Transform, Custom transform, or Created) with relative timestamps, so you can step back to any prior version.[2]

PLATFORM AND PLAN LIMITS

Transforms is rolling out gradually on Mac and Windows (as of Q2 2026). Polish on iOS is also rolling out gradually, with a 10-word minimum and a 1,000-word maximum. Writing samples and the "Translate to English" re-polish option are Mac and Windows only.[2]

Desktop accepts 1 to 1,000 words per transform (exactly 1,000 is allowed; 1,001 triggers the error). Short text below the minimum is silently skipped with no notification.[2]

Custom transform prompt slots do not sync across devices; they are stored locally on each Mac or Windows machine. Your base Polish on/off settings and toggles do sync.[2]

The Relationship Between the Two

Command Mode and Transforms serve the same goal through different mechanisms. Command Mode is ad hoc: you speak a new instruction every time. Transforms is repeatable: you configure once and invoke with a shortcut. In practice, you will likely use Command Mode for one-off requests ("translate this to French," "summarize this for a non-technical audience") and Transforms for the operations you run daily (Polish, a custom "make concise" prompt, a tone shift).

Both require a paid subscription or active free trial. Both work on Mac and Windows. Both have a 1,000-word ceiling on selected text. Command Mode edits can be undone with Cmd+Z (Mac) or Ctrl+Z (Windows). Transform edits can be reverted with the Undo button in the diff viewer, or stepped back through Version history in the Scratchpad.[1][2]

The combination is what earns the name Voice as Editor. Dictation gets words onto the screen. Command Mode and Transforms shape them once they are there. The hands stay off the keyboard for both passes.

Key Points

- Command Mode accepts freeform spoken instructions to transform selected text or generate new content at the cursor, with a 1,000-word selection ceiling.
- Transforms provides repeatable, shortcut-driven presets that apply a saved prompt to highlighted text without requiring you to speak each time.
- Both features require a paid subscription or active free trial and are available on Mac and Windows only (as of Q2 2026).

- Writing samples let you teach each transform what your finished output should sound like, scoped per prompt and synced between desktop devices.
- Auto-polish can apply a transform to every dictation automatically, falling back to the original unpolished text if the transform fails or times out.
- Command Mode replacements can be undone with Cmd+Z or Ctrl+Z. Transform replacements can be reverted with the Undo button in the diff viewer, or stepped back through Version history in the Scratchpad.

CONTEXT AWARENESS

In this chapter, you will learn how Flow reads the active app on your screen and adjusts its output accordingly, a feature called Context Awareness. It covers how app categories shape tone and formatting, what permissions it requires on Mac versus Windows, and the privacy controls that govern what screen data Flow can see.

Software that rewrites your speech needs to know where the words are going. An email to a client and a Slack message to your teammate contain the same information, but they do not sound the same, and they do not look the same on the page. If a rewriting engine treats both identically, it gets one of them wrong every time. Flow solves this with what amounts to a second layer of intelligence on top of The Rewrite Pass (Ch1): it reads your active app, identifies the context, and adjusts the output before it lands. This is The App-Aware Rewrite.

What Context Awareness Does

Context Awareness identifies the app you are using and adapts transcription accuracy, style, and formatting automatically.[1] When you dictate into Gmail, Flow detects you are composing an email, reads the recipient's name from the screen, and applies your email writing style. When you switch to Slack, Flow detects you have moved to a work messaging app and shifts to your casual messaging style. No manual adjustment needed.

The feature does more than shift tone. It reads a limited amount of text near your cursor and identifies the active app. For browser-based apps, Flow identifies the specific website by URL, so Gmail, Google Docs, and a dozen other web apps are recognized individually rather than lumped together as "Chrome."[1] Supported browsers include Chrome, Safari, Arc, Brave, Edge, Firefox, and Opera.

Three specific behaviors are worth understanding:

- **Improved accuracy.** Flow uses names and context visible on screen (such as email recipients) to recognize proper nouns and preserve correct capitalization.[1]
- **Conversation context.** In Slack and Apple Messages, Flow reads conversation context for better transcription accuracy. Other apps benefit

from general nearby-text reading but do not have dedicated conversation context support.[1]

- **Smart formatting in Notion.** Flow detects and ignores Notion's placeholder text ("Heading 1," "Type something…") and inserts your dictated text cleanly into the correct field.[1]

That last one is surprisingly useful. Anyone who has dictated into Notion without context awareness has watched Flow faithfully transcribe the words "Heading 1" as part of their output. The App-Aware Rewrite strips that noise before it reaches you.

The Four Categories

Flow sorts every app into one of four categories: Email, Work messaging, Personal messaging, and Other.[1] The category determines which style settings Flow applies. Email, Work messaging, and Other default to Formal and offer Casual and Excited as alternatives. Personal messaging defaults to Casual and offers Formal and Very Casual.

When an app could belong to more than one category, Flow follows a priority order: Personal messaging, then Email, then Work messaging, then Other.[1] This means if an app registers as both Email and Work messaging, it is treated as Email. If it registers as both Personal messaging and anything else, Personal messaging wins.

The formatting behavior differs by style. Formal never strips trailing periods. Casual strips trailing periods for shorter dictations. Very Casual always strips trailing periods. None of the styles strip exclamation marks or question marks, and stripping is skipped entirely if the line already has punctuation or if text is selected.[1]

Context-aware formatting also handles mid-sentence continuation. When you resume dictating in the middle of an existing sentence, Flow lowercases the first letter and adds leading or trailing spaces as needed.[1] Small details, but the kind that accumulate into text that looks like someone typed it rather than dictated it.

Persistent Context in Code Editors

Developers get a specific benefit. Flow remembers file names from Cursor, Windsurf, and VS Code across dictation sessions, so proper nouns seen in one session are recognized in the next.[1] This is not the same as Variable Recognition or

File Tagging (those are Ch14's territory); this is simpler. Flow stores the context it has seen and uses it for accuracy the next time you dictate.

VS Code is included for file-name memory but excluded from file tagging and formatting.[1] The distinction matters: if you are a VS Code user expecting full context-aware behavior, you will not get it. Cursor and Windsurf get the complete treatment.

Context reading has built-in performance safeguards so dictation is never slowed down. These safeguards apply across supported apps, including code editors.[1]

Platform Availability and Permissions

Context Awareness is available on Mac and Windows. Windows support is more limited.[1] On Mac, you must grant Accessibility permissions in System Settings for the feature to function.[1] If you have already been through The Permission Gate (Ch4), you have this covered. If you skipped the Accessibility permission during setup, Context Awareness silently fails.

On Windows, no explicit accessibility permissions are required.[1]

One Windows-specific quirk: context-aware formatting adjustments are skipped when you dictate into the Wispr Flow app itself.[1] This is a narrow edge case, but if you are composing text inside the Flow interface on Windows, expect raw output rather than context-adjusted output.

The feature is on by default on both platforms. To disable it, open Wispr Flow, go to Settings, then Data and Privacy, and toggle off Context Awareness.[1]

Enterprise Controls

Enterprise admins get a heavier switch. On the Organization settings page under Data Controls, admins can set Context Awareness to Available (the default, where each user controls their own toggle) or Disable for all users, which forces it off for everyone and locks the toggle.[1]

When an admin disables it, your local toggle is forced off. Hovering over the locked toggle shows "This setting is managed by your organization."[1]

Admins on non-Enterprise plans (including Pro and Teams) see the setting as disabled with an “Enterprise” tag. The control exists but is gated behind the Enterprise tier.[1]

The Privacy Layer

Context Awareness reads screen content, which means it raises questions that the rest of Flow does not. The protections are worth knowing.

Context data is read locally on your device. During an active dictation session, relevant context (nearby text, proper nouns, app metadata, dictionary entries, and, in coding environments, variable and file names) is sent to Wispr’s servers to improve transcription accuracy.[1] This is the trade-off: better output requires sending more signal to the cloud.

Password fields are excluded. Password field contents are never read or included in context data.[1] On Mac, password field detection uses the standard macOS secure text field indicator. Some custom or non-standard password inputs may not be detected.

Screen OCR (full screenshot capture) is off by default. Accessibility-text context is on by default.[2] Screenshots, when enabled, are stripped on upload regardless of Privacy Mode and are never persisted server-side.[2] The distinction between OCR and accessibility-text matters: OCR captures pixel-level screen content; accessibility-text reads what the operating system’s accessibility layer exposes. The default configuration uses the lighter touch.

Privacy Mode, when enabled, means no dictation or context data is retained or used for training.[1] Privacy Mode is permanently locked on if you have signed the HIPAA Business Associate Agreement (BAA), or if your enterprise admin enforces Zero Data Retention. Signing the HIPAA BAA is irreversible; you will be asked to type your legal name to confirm.[1] The deeper treatment of Privacy Mode, ZDR, and the BAA lives in The Cloud Boundary (Ch21).

Enterprise organizations can also enforce local data deletion policies (auto-delete after 24 hours, or never store) separately from Zero Data Retention.[1] Three local storage options exist in Settings under Data and Privacy: store data locally (the default), auto-delete local data every 24 hours, and never store data locally.[1]

For sensitive environments (legal, healthcare, or regulated data), disabling Context Awareness entirely is the most conservative option.[1] You can still dictate; Flow still applies The Rewrite Pass (Ch1). You just lose the app-aware adjustments.

What Context Awareness Does Not Do

A few boundaries worth drawing:

Context Awareness does not change your Auto Cleanup level. The Cleanup Dial (Ch7) and The App-Aware Rewrite operate on different axes. One controls how aggressively Flow polishes your raw speech; the other controls how Flow adapts that polished output to the destination app. You can have High cleanup with Casual context, or None cleanup with Formal context. They are independent.

Context-aware formatting does not work inside remote desktop sessions; text pastes with default formatting instead.[3] If you are working through Citrix, RDP, or another virtual desktop, Flow cannot read the remote app context. Flow still dictates and pastes via clipboard sharing, but you lose the app-aware adjustments covered in this chapter.

Context Awareness is not the same as Styles. Styles (Ch12) let you configure tone preferences per app category; Context Awareness is the feature that detects which category you are in and applies those preferences. One is the policy; the other is the enforcement.

Key Points

- The App-Aware Rewrite reads your active app and adjusts tone, formatting, and accuracy before text lands at your cursor.
- Four app categories determine behavior: Email, Work messaging, Personal messaging, and Other, with a fixed priority order for ambiguous apps.
- Mac requires Accessibility permissions for Context Awareness to function; Windows requires no explicit permissions but has more limited support.
- Password fields are never read, screen OCR is off by default, and screenshots are stripped on upload and never stored server-side.

- Enterprise admins can force Context Awareness off for all users; Privacy Mode and the HIPAA BAA lock down what data is retained.
- Context Awareness and the Cleanup Dial are independent controls that affect different aspects of the rewrite pipeline.

DICTIONARY

In this chapter: Flow ships with a general vocabulary, but your world has specific names, acronyms, and terms it has never encountered. The Personal Lexicon is how you close that gap, teaching Flow the words that matter to your work and letting it correct the ones it consistently gets wrong.

Every voice-to-text system carries a vocabulary. That vocabulary was trained on public text, conference talks, podcast transcripts, and millions of sentences written by humans who do not work at your company, do not know your colleagues' names, and have never heard your industry's acronyms spoken aloud. The moment you say "Korostyshevskiy" or "FigJam" or "HIPAA" with the expectation that it lands correctly, you are asking the system to guess. Sometimes it guesses well. Sometimes it produces something creative and wrong.

Flow solves this with a feature it calls the dictionary. The name undersells it. What you are really building is a Personal Lexicon: a living, syncing list of words, names, and correction rules that sits between your voice and the Rewrite Pass (Ch1), nudging the output toward your intent before the text ever reaches the cursor.[1]

The dictionary is not a dump of every word you will ever say. It is a curated, prioritized collection of the words the general model gets wrong for *you*. That distinction matters. Adding five hundred common English words will not make Flow smarter; adding the twelve names it keeps mangling will.

Two Kinds of Entry

Dictionary entries come in two flavors, and understanding the difference saves you from wondering why one approach works and the other does not.

Vocabulary words improve recognition accuracy for uncommon or specialized terms during transcription. You add "McKenzie," and Flow is more likely to produce "McKenzie" instead of "Mackenzie" when it hears the name. The word acts as a signal boost: Flow now knows this spelling exists in your world.[1]

Replacement rules go further. They swap one specific transcription for another, every time. If Flow keeps producing "Draught" when you say "Draft," you create a replacement rule that catches the error and fixes it automatically. Replacement

rules fire as soon as you finish dictating, before the text reaches the cursor. Each word can have exactly one replacement rule; if you need to change the correction, you edit the existing entry rather than creating a new one.[1]

The practical heuristic: if Flow sometimes gets the word right and sometimes does not, add a vocabulary word. If Flow *always* produces the same wrong spelling, create a replacement rule. The replacement is the surgical instrument; the vocabulary boost is the general nudge.

The Personal Lexicon in Practice

Adding a word is fast on every platform. On Mac and Windows, you open the dictionary in the sidebar, click Add New, type the word, and save. On iOS, you tap the + button in the Dictionary tab. On Android, the same + button opens an Add Word dialog.[1]

There is a 60-character limit per entry on desktop and Android. iOS enforces 59 characters; a word of exactly 60 characters is rejected on the save attempt. Duplicates are rejected on all platforms with a validation message.[1,2]

Changes take effect immediately on the device where you make them. No restart required. And your dictionary syncs across Mac, Windows, iOS, and Android, so a word you add on your laptop appears on your phone the next time it checks in.[1]

That sync timing varies by platform. Desktop syncs at app start. iOS syncs when the app loads. Android syncs at sign-in and whenever the Dictionary screen is opened. If you just added a word on your Mac and want it on your Android phone right now, open the Dictionary screen on Android to force it.[2]

STARRING: LOCAL PRIORITY, NOT GLOBAL

On Mac and Windows, you can star a dictionary entry. A starred word gets higher priority during recognition; when Flow encounters conflicting words or has many dictionary items, starred words win. The star icon sits next to each entry, and clicking it toggles the priority.[1,2]

Here is the catch that trips people up: star status is stored locally per device and does not sync. If you star “McKenzie” on your work Mac, your home Mac does not know about it. You need to star the entry on each desktop device where you want the boost.[1,2]

iOS and Android do not support starring at all. iOS sorts entries by modification date. Android has no sort controls.[1,2]

AUTO-ADD: SELECTIVE LEARNING

Flow can learn from your corrections. When you enable Auto-add to dictionary (Settings, System, Extras), Flow watches for words it does not recognize and adds them automatically. But it is selective: only proper nouns and uncommon names get auto-added. Common words like “sprint,” “roadmap,” or “deploy” are deliberately excluded.[1]

Auto-learned words appear in your desktop dictionary marked with a sparkle icon, so you can distinguish them from words you added manually. If Flow auto-adds something you do not want, delete it like any other entry.[1]

Language-Specific Abbreviations

The dictionary is not English-only. It handles a problem that multilingual users hit constantly: abbreviation collisions across languages.

Consider “BTW.” In English, Flow expands it to “by the way.” In Dutch, BTW is the standard abbreviation for an entirely different concept. If you dictate in Dutch and Flow keeps producing “by the way,” you have a language collision. The fix: create a replacement rule where the misspelling is “by the way” (or however Flow transcribes it) and the correct spelling is “BTW.”[2]

Flow ships with a few default dictionary entries, including “btw” mapped to “by the way.” To reclaim that abbreviation for another language, edit or delete the default entry first, then add your own.[2]

A few best practices for abbreviation handling:

- Match your pronunciation. If you say letters individually (“bee tee double-u”), enter that phrasing as the misspelling, not the abbreviation itself.[2]
- Use precise capitalization. Enter “BTW” in the correct spelling field, not “btw” or “B.T.W.”[2]
- Add variations. If you sometimes spell it out and sometimes say it as a word, add an entry for each pronunciation.[2]

- Skip periods unless your style guide requires them. “BTW” rather than “B.T.W.”[2]

Flow cannot detect language context for ambiguous acronyms automatically. If you need “BTW” in Dutch and “by the way” in English, add the Dutch entry and spell out the English phrase when speaking. One Language Per Breath (Ch13) applies here too: the dictionary does not switch behavior mid-utterance.[2]

The Platform Gap

The dictionary exists on all four platforms, but it does not behave identically on all four. Android is the platform with the most constraints. On Android, you cannot star entries, sort the list, or run a bulk import. More significantly, replacement rules (the misspelling-to-correction pairs) cannot be created on Android. There is no field for it. You must create replacement rules on desktop or iOS, and they sync to Android and apply during dictation. When you edit a synced replacement rule on Android, only the trigger word is visible; the replacement value is preserved silently in the background.[1,2]

On Android, there is also a cross-list constraint: a word cannot be both a dictionary entry and a snippet trigger. Flow shows an error if you try. On desktop and iOS, this cross-check is not enforced, so the same word can exist in both lists. When dictionary entries and snippet triggers overlap, the longer trigger takes priority over the shorter one.[3] For a fuller treatment of snippet trigger behavior, see The Spoken Macro (Ch11).

PERSONAL DICTIONARIES: THE 40-ENTRY LIMIT

The Language-Specific Abbreviations documentation notes that personal dictionaries are limited to 40 manually-added entries.[2] This is a constraint worth knowing: if you are adding words one by one and hit the cap, Bulk Import (Ch12) is the path for larger vocabulary sets.

PERSONAL VERSUS TEAM

On Team and Enterprise plans, admins can create shared dictionary entries that apply to all team members automatically. Individual users can still add personal entries. If the same word exists in both your personal and team dictionaries, your personal version takes precedence.[1]

Team dictionary visibility differs by platform. On desktop, you see tabs for All, Personal, and Shared with Team. On iOS, team plan subscribers see filter tabs; non-team users see a flat list. On Android, only Enterprise (Business plan) users with active or trialing status see the team filter chips; everyone else sees a flat list.[1]

For a deeper look at team dictionary deployment, see The Org Layer (Ch23).

Bulk Import

If you have a large existing vocabulary (a list of product names, a medical terminology set, a roster of client companies), adding them one by one is not practical. Bulk Import lets you upload a CSV file with up to 1,000 entries at once, with a maximum file size of 3MB. It is available on Mac and Windows only and requires an active paid subscription or active trial.[1]

The CSV format is straightforward: one column for vocabulary words, or two columns for misspelling-and-correction pairs. Quoted fields are supported, so commas inside quotes will not split a value. Duplicate entries are automatically skipped. Imported words appear with an upload icon and can have corrections added later.[1]

Bulk Import also supports snippets (in JSON format) and, when team features are enabled, a Share with Team toggle lets you import directly into the team dictionary.[1] The mechanics of bulk import are covered in detail in The Style Layer (Ch12).

Building a Good Lexicon

The dictionary rewards curation over volume. A few principles:

Add both forms. If you add “API,” add “APIs” too. Flow does not automatically pluralize dictionary entries, and the plural form is a different recognition target.[1]

Prefer replacement rules for persistent errors. If Flow *always* gets it wrong the same way, a replacement rule is more reliable than a vocabulary boost. The vocabulary word nudges; the replacement rule guarantees.[1]

Review periodically. Colleagues leave. Projects end. Acronyms change. A dictionary cluttered with obsolete terms is noise that can interfere with current recognition.[1]

Star strategically on desktop. You get higher priority from starring, but remember: the star does not sync. If you work on multiple desktops, star on each one.[1,2]

Use the scratchpad shortcut. On Mac and Windows, if a word is underlined as a potential misspelling in the scratchpad (see The Scratchpad, Ch16), right-click and select Add to Dictionary. One click, no modal, and the word is saved immediately.[1]

Key Points

- The Personal Lexicon is a curated list of words and correction rules that bridges the gap between Flow's general vocabulary and your specific terminology.
- Vocabulary words nudge recognition toward correct spellings, while replacement rules guarantee a specific substitution every time Flow produces a known error.
- Starred entries get higher recognition priority on desktop, but star status is stored locally per device and does not sync across machines.
- Android applies dictionary entries and replacement rules during dictation but cannot create replacement rules; use desktop or iOS for that.
- Language-specific abbreviation collisions are solved by creating replacement rules that override Flow's default expansions for the target language.
- When a dictionary entry and a snippet trigger overlap, the longer trigger takes priority, preventing accidental misfires between the two systems.

SNIPPETS

In this chapter, we look at snippets: saved text blocks that expand from a spoken trigger phrase. You will learn how to create them, what makes a trigger reliable versus fragile, where expansion breaks down across platforms, and how to keep your snippet library clean as it grows. Snippets are the closest Flow gets to programmable output, and using them well means fewer repetitive keystrokes for the text you type most.

Every tool reaches a point where typing the same thing again feels like a personal insult. Your mailing address. Your Zoom link. The four-sentence reply you send to vendor invoices. You know the text by heart, but knowing it does not make your fingers move faster. Copy and paste helps, but only if you remembered to copy the right thing, and only if you are near the device that has it on the clipboard.

Snippets solve this the way a voice-first tool should: you say a trigger phrase, and Flow replaces it with stored text. The concept is simple enough that most humans will set up their first snippet and immediately wonder why they did not do it sooner. The execution, however, has edges. Triggers can collide with your natural speech. Expansion text can paste partially in certain apps. Android and desktop handle sync differently. This chapter maps the territory.

The Spoken Macro

A snippet is a spoken macro. You define a trigger phrase and its expansion, and whenever Flow hears the trigger during dictation, it swaps the phrase for the stored block. Say “my address” in the middle of a sentence, and Flow inserts your full street address where those two words would have gone.[1]

Triggers can be up to 60 characters. Expansion text can be up to 4,000 characters.[2] That upper bound is generous enough to hold a full email signature, a canned customer-support reply, a code template with placeholders, or a standard legal disclaimer. Flow ships with two default snippets out of the box: “my email address” and “my Flow referral.”[3] You can edit or delete both.

The trigger fires mid-sentence. Say “send the package to my address” and Flow produces “send the package to 123 Main Street, San Francisco, CA 94102” (or whatever you stored).[1] The expansion always uses the exact casing you saved. Flow

does not rewrite snippet content through the cleanup engine; what you stored is what you get.

That last point matters. The Rewrite Pass (Ch1) applies to your spoken words, but snippet expansions bypass it. If you save a URL in lowercase, it stays lowercase even when the snippet fires at the start of a sentence. If you save a block of text with specific line breaks, those line breaks persist. Snippets are literal.

Trigger Design

The difference between a snippet that works every time and one that misfires weekly is trigger design. Flow matches triggers as whole words with word-boundary detection, so a trigger like “btw” will not fire if it appears inside another word.[4] But it will fire when surrounded by punctuation, dashes, or parentheses, because those count as word boundaries.

When your entire dictation consists solely of the trigger phrase, Flow strips punctuation before matching. Say “my address.” with an audible period, and the snippet still fires.[1] When the trigger appears mid-sentence among other words, Flow uses standard word-boundary matching and expects a closer match.[4]

Three rules for triggers that hold up:

Be specific. “My email signature” is better than “thanks.” “Zoom meeting link” is better than “link.” The more your trigger sounds like something you would say naturally in conversation, the more likely it will fire when you do not want it to.[1]

Be unique. If you have both “my address” and “my email address,” the overlap rule applies: the longer trigger takes priority.[5] Say “my email address” and Flow expands the longer one. Say “my address” and Flow expands the shorter one. This works, but it requires you to pronounce the full phrase clearly. If your triggers are “address” and “my address,” a slight hesitation before “my” can fire the wrong one. Keep trigger phrases distinct enough that partial speech does not cause collisions.

Test after creating. Dictate a sentence using the trigger and confirm it fires correctly. Then dictate a sentence where the trigger words appear naturally but should not fire. If both cases work as expected, you are done.[1]

The trigger-collision rule also applies across snippets and dictionary entries. The Personal Lexicon (Ch10) establishes that a word cannot serve as both a snippet trigger and a dictionary entry. On Android, this is enforced at creation time with a validation error. On iOS and desktop, the app currently allows creating both, but keeping them unique avoids unpredictable behavior.[6]

Creating and Managing Snippets

Creation follows the same pattern on every platform, with minor interface differences.

On Mac and Windows, open the Wispr Flow app, click Snippets in the left sidebar, click “Add new,” enter your trigger and expansion, and press Cmd+Enter (Mac) or Ctrl+Enter (Windows).[1] Editing uses the pencil icon; deleting uses the delete icon with a confirmation prompt.

On iOS, open the app, tap the menu icon, select Snippets, tap the floating + button, enter your trigger and expansion, and tap Save.[1] Editing opens an edit sheet; deleting is a swipe-left or long-press action.

On Android, open the app, tap Snippets in the bottom navigation bar, tap the + button, enter the trigger and expansion, and tap Add.[1] Editing is a left-to-right swipe; deleting is a right-to-left swipe with confirmation.

Desktop users get a search bar (Cmd+F / Ctrl+F) and filter tabs for All versus Personal snippets. Team and Business (Enterprise) plans add a Shared with team filter.[1] On Team and Business plans, members can create shared snippets visible to the whole organization. Personal snippets take priority over team snippets when the same trigger exists in both.[1]

Bulk import of snippets from a JSON file is available on desktop; the mechanics belong to The Style Layer (Ch12).

How Expansion Behaves

When a snippet fires, Flow adjusts the expansion to fit its context. If the snippet fires mid-sentence, the first letter may be lowercased and trailing punctuation removed to match the surrounding text. Proper nouns that Flow recognizes (names in your dictionary, your own name) are not lowercased mid-sentence.[5]

Only sentence-ending punctuation (period, question mark, exclamation mark) is stripped before the snippet. Commas, colons, semicolons, and other punctuation survive.[5]

On Windows, this context-aware adjustment is skipped entirely when you are dictating into the Wispr Flow app itself.[5] If you are testing snippets in Flow's own text fields and the casing looks wrong, try the same snippet in another app before filing a bug.

Snippet expansions insert static text. Dynamic variables like today's date are not supported.[1] If you need a date in your snippet, you update the expansion manually. This is a real limitation for humans who use date-stamped templates, but it also means snippet behavior is predictable: what you saved is what you get, every time.

Clipboard and Paste Mechanics

On Mac, Flow pastes snippet content using the clipboard, then restores your previous clipboard contents shortly after the operation completes.[5] Most of the time this is invisible. The exception: large clipboard contents like PDFs, audio files, and rich text with attachments (RTFD format) are not restored.[5] If you had a 40-page PDF on your clipboard, triggered a snippet, and then pressed Cmd+V expecting your PDF, it would be gone. This is worth knowing if you work with large documents and use the clipboard as a staging area.

When a paste operation fails in the target app, Flow sends a notification asking you to paste manually. The default shortcuts are Ctrl+Cmd+V on Mac and Alt+Shift+Z on Windows.[7] If manual paste succeeds, the issue is app-specific, not a snippet problem.

On Windows, if a notification appears saying "Update admin settings to paste!" with the body "Run Flow as Administrator to insert text everywhere," the fix is to relaunch Flow as Administrator.[7] This surfaces when Flow cannot paste into elevated applications.

The Android Story

Android handles snippets differently in ways that matter.

Snippets are cached locally after your first visit to the Snippets screen, so they remain available offline after that initial load.[8] Sync happens at login and each time you open the Snippets screen.[9] If you create a snippet on your desktop and want it on your Android phone, open the Snippets screen on Android. That triggers the sync.

Android enforces the snippet-versus-dictionary uniqueness rule at creation time. Try to add a snippet trigger that already exists as a dictionary entry, and you will see an inline validation error.[6] This is stricter than iOS and desktop, where the conflict is technically possible.

The partial-paste failure deserves its own paragraph. In earlier versions, dictated text was successfully inserted into apps like WhatsApp, Telegram, Messenger, Signal, Slack, Teams, Discord, Instagram, Snapchat, Google Messages, and Gmail, but Flow incorrectly treated it as a failure and either fell back to the clipboard or reported an insertion error. This was fixed in Wispr Flow 2.0.0 for Android.[10] If you are running an older version and snippets seem to fail in messaging apps, update first.

Other Android-specific fixes worth noting: version 1.8.5 resolved duplicate entries appearing after editing a snippet; version 1.8.2 fixed snippet replacements not applying during dictation; version 1.5.2 addressed crashes from duplicate items in the snippets list and a sync issue where snippets and dictionary entries could get mixed up.[11] All of these are resolved in current versions. If you see any of these symptoms, the answer is always the same: update and restart.

Team Snippets

On Team and Business (Enterprise) plans, snippets gain a shared dimension. Members can create snippets visible to the entire organization, and shared snippets behave identically to personal ones: say the trigger, get the expansion.[1]

Personal snippets take priority. If a trigger exists in both your personal list and the team library, your personal version wins.[1] This means you can override a team snippet without deleting it, which is useful when the standard company disclaimer needs a department-specific tweak.

Creating a team snippet on desktop means toggling “Share with team” in the Add snippet dialog. Moving an existing personal snippet to the team library uses the Share icon next to the snippet (desktop) or a long-press menu option (iOS).[1] Good candidates for team snippets: the company address, standard disclaimers, team signatures, and frequently used meeting links.

The Org Layer (Ch23) covers team administration in depth; this chapter only establishes how team snippets work from the individual user’s perspective.

When Snippets Do Not Fire

A quick diagnostic for the most common failures:

The trigger is misspelled. Open the Snippets list, verify the trigger text, and say the phrase clearly and completely. Trigger matching is case-insensitive, so “My Email” and “my email” both work.[5]

The triggers are too similar. If “my address” and “my email address” both exist and the wrong one fires, rename one trigger to be more distinct. “Home address” and “work email address” leaves no ambiguity.

The trigger matches natural speech. If you keep accidentally firing “thanks” when you are genuinely saying thanks in a sentence, change the trigger to something you would never say conversationally, like “my thanks template.”

Sync has not happened. On Android, open the Snippets screen to force a sync.[9] On desktop, click Refresh on the Snippets page. If snippets still do not appear across devices, sign out and back in.[1]

For deeper sync behavior across platforms, The Synced Identity (Ch20) has the full picture.

Key Points

- Snippets are spoken macros: a trigger phrase expands into stored text, bypassing the cleanup engine for literal output.
- Trigger design determines reliability; specific, unique phrases that do not overlap with natural speech prevent misfires.

- The longer trigger always wins when triggers overlap, and a word cannot serve as both a snippet trigger and a dictionary entry.
- On Mac, Flow restores your previous clipboard after pasting a snippet, except for large items like PDFs and audio files.
- Android caches snippets locally after the first visit to the Snippets screen and syncs each time that screen is opened.
- Team snippets share vocabulary across an organization, but personal snippets always take priority over team versions.

STYLES AND BULK SETUP

In this chapter, we cover Flow's style system, which adjusts tone per app category, the Polish shortcuts that rewrite highlighted text on command, and the bulk import pipeline that loads dictionary words and snippets from files. Together these three surfaces form the configurable layer between your voice and Flow's output, and learning to set them up means the rewrite works for you instead of around you.

You can dictate all day and still sound wrong. Not wrong as in inaccurate. Wrong as in the email reads like a text message and the Slack reply reads like a cover letter. The Cleanup Dial (Ch7) controls how aggressively Flow rewrites your speech, but it says nothing about tone. Cleanup is a global knob. It cannot know that your personal messages need lowercase energy and your client emails need a firm handshake.

That gap is what styles fill. And once you have a library of dictionary words and snippet triggers from The Personal Lexicon (Ch10) and The Spoken Macro (Ch11), getting them into Flow one at a time starts to feel like punishment. Bulk import solves that. This chapter covers the full configurable surface: style selection, Polish shortcuts, writing samples, and the file-based import path for dictionary and snippet data.

The Style Layer

Styles let you assign a tone preset to each of Flow's four app categories: Personal messages, Work messages, Email, and Other. When you dictate into Slack, Flow checks which category Slack belongs to, finds the style you picked for that category, and adjusts the output accordingly.[1]

The feature is available on all four platforms: Mac, Windows, iOS, and Android. There is one hard gate. Styles only activate when at least one of your selected languages is English, either American or British.[1] If your language is set to French or Japanese, the Styles tab is hidden entirely. This is a Q2 2026 limitation, not a permanent architectural decision, but it is real right now and worth knowing before you spend time configuring.

Four styles are available, though not every style appears in every category:

- **Formal.** Available for all four categories on all platforms. The default on Mac and Windows for every category until you make a selection.[1]
- **Casual.** Available for all four categories. The default for Personal messages on iOS and Android.[1]
- **Very Casual.** Available only for the Personal category. If you want Very Casual for email, you will not find it there; use Casual or Excited instead.[1]
- **Excited.** Available for Work, Email, and Other. Not available for Personal.[1]

The platform defaults tell you something about the assumptions baked into each surface. Desktop users get Formal everywhere, reflecting the expectation that desktop dictation skews professional. Mobile users get Casual for Personal, reflecting the expectation that phone dictation skews conversational.[1] Both are reasonable defaults. Both are wrong for some fraction of users. Change them.

Setting Up Styles

On Mac and Windows, open Wispr Flow and click Styles in the left sidebar. Click a category tab, pick a style card, and dictate a test phrase in a matching app. If the output reflects the tone you selected, you are done.[1]

On iOS, open the app, tap the Styles tab in the bottom bar, pick a category, and tap a style card.[1] iOS also offers a session override: the keyboard shows a style button you can tap to temporarily switch styles without changing your saved preferences. The override lasts for that dictation session only; your per-category settings remain untouched.[1]

On Android, open the app, tap the Style tab (singular on Android, plural everywhere else), select a category, and tap the style card you want. A panel opens from the bottom. Tap Save.[1] That last step matters: style changes on Android are not applied until you tap Save. Navigating away discards unsaved changes.[1] If your Android styles seem to be ignoring your choices, this is the first thing to check.

How Flow Picks the Right Style

When you dictate, Flow detects which app has focus and maps it to one of the four categories. Supported apps include messaging (WhatsApp, Telegram, Signal,

Messenger, Discord), work tools (Slack, Teams, Zoom, LinkedIn, Notion, Jira, Google Docs), and email clients (Gmail, Outlook, ProtonMail), including web versions.[1]

When an app could fit more than one category, the priority order is: Personal Messaging, then Email, then Work Messaging, then Other.[1] A temporary keyboard style override, if set on iOS, takes precedence over all of these for that session.

Sync and Conflict

Style preferences sync across all your devices automatically. Changes push to the server immediately. Other devices pick them up on their next sync, which can take up to one hour. Restart the app to force an immediate sync.[1]

Conflict resolution is last-write-wins. Whichever device saved most recently sets the canonical style for that category.[1] If you change Personal to Very Casual on your phone and then change it to Formal on your laptop thirty seconds later, Formal wins everywhere. There is no merge and no warning. Keep that in mind if you share an account across multiple devices and tend to tweak settings on whichever one is nearest.

Writing Samples

Styles set the broad tone. Writing samples sharpen it. You can add up to five writing samples per prompt, each between 50 and 500 words, that teach Flow what your personal voice sounds like.[1] Samples are configured inside the Polish prompt modals (Custom Prompt or Prompt Engineer), not on the Styles page itself.

There is a privacy dimension. When Privacy Mode is enabled, writing samples stay on your device and do not sync to the server. On Enterprise plans with Zero Data Retention, samples are not stored locally either.[1] If you are on a privacy-conscious plan, check whether your samples are actually reaching the model before assuming they are influencing output. The Cloud Boundary (Ch21) covers the broader privacy controls.

Samples are tied to the prompt they were added under. Rename a custom prompt and the samples move with it. Delete a custom prompt and the samples go with it, permanently. Samples tied to default Polish prompts are not affected by resets.[1]

Polish Shortcuts

Polish is the on-demand rewrite surface. Highlight any text, press a keyboard shortcut, and Flow rewrites the selection according to a rule you defined. Fix grammar. Shift tone. Translate. Reformat into bullet points. The rewrite replaces the selected text in place.[2]

Polish is available on Mac and Windows only, as of Q2 2026.[2]

SETTING UP A POLISH SHORTCUT

Open Flow settings, navigate to the Transforms page in the sidebar, and click Create New. Name the shortcut (something like “Fix Grammar” or “Make Formal”), write a rule describing how Flow should rewrite the selected text, and assign a keyboard shortcut. The shortcut needs at least one modifier key (Cmd, Ctrl, Opt, Alt, Shift, or Fn on Mac) and uses at most three keys. Mouse buttons from Mouse 4 through Mouse 10 can satisfy the modifier requirement on their own.[2]

Verify by highlighting text in any text field and pressing your shortcut. The selected text is replaced with the polished version. Changes to the name and prompt auto-save; shortcut changes save immediately.[2]

DEFAULT RULES AND CUSTOM RULES

The base Polish configuration includes five toggleable default rules: Make more concise, Reword for clarity, Reorder for readability, Add structure for readability, and Maintain your tone.[2] Two additional rules are Pro-only: Clarify main point and Refine phrasing for impact.[2]

You can add up to five custom rules, each a maximum of 50 words, in the base Polish configure modal.[2] These custom rules let you push the rewrite in directions the defaults do not cover. “Keep all technical terms unchanged.” “Always use active voice.” “Remove hedging language.” Specific rules outperform vague ones. “Make it better” is not a rule; “Rewrite in a professional tone for a client email” is.[2]

CAPACITY AND LIMITS

You can create up to eight custom transforms. Including the built-in Polish and Prompt Engineer presets, the Transforms page shows up to ten cards total. The Create New button disappears once all custom slots are filled.[2]

Polish accepts up to 1,000 words at a time. Selections longer than that produce a notification and are not transformed.[2] If you routinely polish long documents, break them into sections. The 1,000-word ceiling is a per-operation limit, not a daily cap.

THE DIFF VIEWER

After polishing finishes, the Flow Bar shows “Done.” with a clickable “See changes” link. Clicking it opens a diff viewer showing additions in purple, removals struck through, and an Undo button with a keyboard shortcut reminder.[2] Copy, Thumbs Up, Thumbs Down, and Retry actions are also available. The diff viewer also offers re-polish presets: Prompt Engineer, Turn to list, Translate to English, and Empathize.[2]

The diff viewer is the safety net. Polish rewrites are destructive by default; the selected text is replaced the moment polishing completes. If the rewrite missed the mark, the undo shortcut brings back the original. Use it.

Bulk Import

Once your dictionary and snippet collection outgrows manual entry, bulk import gets them into Flow from a file. The feature is desktop-only (Mac and Windows). iOS and Android can view and edit synced items individually but cannot import files.[3]

ACCESS REQUIREMENTS

Bulk import requires an active paid subscription or an active trial with days remaining. An expired trial does not grant access. Without a qualifying subscription, the Experimental settings page where you enable bulk import does not appear.[3]

To enable it: open the Flow app, go to Settings, then Experimental, and toggle on Bulk import. Once enabled, an Import button appears in the top-right corner of both the Dictionary and Snippets tabs.[3]

DICTIONARY IMPORT (CSV)

Dictionary items use CSV format. A single-column CSV adds vocabulary words that Flow should recognize. A two-column CSV maps an incorrect phrase (first column) to its correction (second column).[3]

The first column supports up to 60 characters. The second column supports up to 4,000 characters. Rows exceeding either limit are skipped. The parser follows standard CSV quoting rules (RFC 4180), so wrap fields containing commas in double quotes.[3]

A practical example: if you have a list of company names, product terms, and industry jargon that Flow consistently gets wrong, export them into a CSV with the misspelling in column one and the correction in column two. Import once. Done.

SNIPPET IMPORT (JSON)

Snippets use JSON format: an array of objects, each with a name field (the trigger, up to 60 characters) and a text field (the expansion, up to 4,000 characters). Both must be strings. Entries with non-string values, whitespace-only values, or values exceeding limits are skipped. Extra fields beyond name and text are ignored.[3]

SHARED LIMITS

Each import accepts a maximum of 1,000 items and a 3 MB file size.[3] The import modal walks through four sequential screens (Upload, Preview, Loading, Success) with a progress bar at the top.[3]

Duplicates are filtered at the preview stage. Matching is case-insensitive: “Flow” and “flow” count as the same word. Duplicates within your file keep only the first occurrence. When importing to a team library, duplicates are checked against existing team entries, not your personal library.[3]

One rule crosses the boundary between dictionaries and snippets: a word cannot exist as both a dictionary entry and a snippet trigger. Conflicting items are silently skipped during import.[3] If you are importing both a dictionary CSV and a snippets JSON, import one first, then the other, so the conflict check catches overlaps before they become silent failures.

Imported items sync across all your devices. Each device syncs independently with the cloud, so there may be a brief delay before new imports appear on your phone or second computer.[3] Bulk-imported dictionary words appear with an upload badge icon so you can tell them apart from manually added entries.[3]

Key Points

- Styles assign a tone preset per app category, but they only activate when your language is set to English (American or British).
- Platform defaults differ: desktop starts Formal everywhere, while mobile starts Casual for Personal messages.
- Polish shortcuts let you rewrite highlighted text on command, with up to eight custom transforms on Mac and Windows only.
- Writing samples refine Flow's output beyond preset tones, but they do not sync when Privacy Mode is enabled.
- Bulk import loads up to 1,000 dictionary or snippet items from a CSV or JSON file, requiring a paid subscription and desktop access.
- A word cannot exist as both a dictionary entry and a snippet trigger; the conflict check runs silently during import.

MULTILINGUAL DICTATION

In this chapter: Flow supports over 100 languages but detects which one you are speaking once per session, not per word. The skill is choosing your languages deliberately, switching between sessions rather than mid-sentence, and knowing where the language boundary limits what Flow can do for you.

Flow does not listen to your words and sort them into languages in real time. It commits to a language at the start of each dictation session and transcribes the entire segment in that language, regardless of what you actually say after the first few seconds. This is not a bug or a shortcut. It is the architectural constraint that makes 100-plus languages viable without hallucinating script switches on every borrowed noun. Internalize it and multilingual dictation becomes reliable. Fight it and every session is a coin flip.

The name for this constraint is *One Language Per Breath*.

How Detection Works

When you press the hotkey, tap the Flow Bubble, or switch to the Flow Keyboard, the recognition engine samples the first moments of your speech and locks onto the most likely language from your selected set. Everything that follows in that session is transcribed in that language. If you switch from English to German mid-sentence, Flow does not pivot. It transcribes the German words as though they were English, producing nonsense or near-misses. The fix is simple: end the session, start a new one, and speak the other language.[1]

This per-session commitment means your language pool matters more than you might expect. The fewer languages you have selected, the less ambiguity Flow faces at the start. Two or three languages that sound distinctly different from each other (English and Japanese, say) give Flow a clean signal. Two languages that overlap in phonetics (Spanish and Italian, or Hindi and Hinglish) force the model to guess, and it will guess wrong often enough to be annoying.[1]

Setting Your Languages

The setup path is nearly identical across platforms, with one important exception on Android.

On Mac and Windows, open Settings, go to General, then Languages. Select the languages you speak, or enable Auto-detect to let Flow choose from the full list of 100-plus options. Click Save and close. Your changes take effect on the next dictation session, not the current one.[1]

On iOS, tap Settings, then General, then Set Language. Each tap saves immediately; there is no explicit save step. Removing all specific languages enables Auto-detect automatically.[1]

On Android, tap Settings, then Languages. Select or deselect languages, then tap Save. Backing out without tapping Save discards your changes. Here is the exception that matters: Android does not offer Auto-detect. You must select at least one specific language before Save becomes available.[1,2]

The practical consequence is that Android users cannot fall back on “let the model figure it out.” They have to make a deliberate language choice. This is, counterintuitively, an advantage. Auto-detect choosing from 100-plus languages is the single most common cause of wrong-language transcription on other platforms.[2]

The Language Picker on Desktop

On Mac and Windows, the Flow Bar includes a language pill or globe icon that doubles as a quick switcher. Clicking it opens the Languages submenu, letting you toggle between your selected languages without opening Settings.[2]

You can also toggle languages from the Flow tray or menu bar icon’s Languages submenu, which gives you the same list without opening the Settings window. For humans who switch languages several times a day, this is the fastest path: keep your two or three active languages selected in Settings, then cycle between them with a single click on the Flow Bar before each session.[2]

Onboarding Defaults

Flow pre-fills your language list from your system settings during onboarding. On desktop, your system language is selected by default; if detection fails, Flow defaults to English. On iOS, the pre-fill happens on first launch only; returning to the language screen later does not re-detect.[1]

Regional variants get automatic treatment. British English is selected during onboarding for users in the UK, Canada, Australia, and New Zealand, and on desktop, Ireland and South Africa are included as well.[1]

Users in Switzerland and Liechtenstein get their own variant automatically based on system locale, which matters because Swiss German orthography replaces ß with "ss." Standard German keeps "Straße"; Swiss German produces "Strasse." If you are in Zurich and your transcription keeps inserting ß, check that you have German (Swiss) selected rather than standard German.[1]

Code-Switching and Its Limits

Flow works best when you speak primarily in one language with occasional words from another. A borrowed noun or a brand name in English during a French dictation will usually survive. But alternating sentence by sentence, or mixing scripts within a phrase, pushes the model past its reliable range.[1]

Chinese and English together are especially difficult. Flow may transcribe English words in Chinese characters or vice versa. The documentation is blunt: a single-language setup is the most reliable fix for this combination.[1,2]

English paired with Spanish, French, or German performs better than English paired with Chinese or Japanese. If you code-switch frequently between two Romance languages, or between English and a language with a very different sound profile, keeping both selected and letting per-session detection handle it is workable. If your languages sound similar enough to confuse the model, swap the selection manually before each session.[1]

Language Variants and Orthography

Some languages have regional variants that produce visibly different output.

English (American) and English (British) are mutually exclusive. Selecting one automatically deselects the other. The same mutual exclusivity applies to German and German (Swiss), Hindi and Hinglish, and Chinese (Simplified) and Chinese (Traditional).[1]

Hinglish is a code-switched blend of Hindi and English. With Hinglish selected, Hindi speech is romanized into Hinglish and English speech is formatted as normal English.

If you naturally mix both languages and Flow is producing only Hindi or only English, the fix is to select Hinglish explicitly rather than either language alone.[1,2]

Chinese (Simplified and Traditional) are separate options. On iOS, Flow pre-fills the variant based on your iOS region: China or Singapore pre-fills Simplified; Taiwan, Hong Kong, or Macau pre-fills Traditional. If no region is detected, Simplified is the default. On desktop, Malaysia is also treated as Simplified. Cantonese is a distinct option, separate from both.[1]

French Typographic Spacing

When dictating in French, Flow automatically inserts a narrow space before semicolons, colons, question marks, exclamation marks, and the closing guillemet (»), and after the opening guillemet («). This matches standard French typography and is not a bug. It applies only when French is in your selected language list.[1]

The spacing does not apply to colons in times (12:30), ratios (1:1), or URLs, and it is skipped inside code editors and developer tools such as VS Code, Cursor, Xcode, Terminal, and IntelliJ.[1]

The Language Display

Languages appear in the picker with their English name followed by their native-language name in parentheses: “Spanish (Español),” “Japanese (日本語).” Country flag emojis were removed because languages do not map cleanly to countries. On iOS, Auto-detect shows a magnifying glass icon; on desktop, it appears as a toggle showing “100+ languages” when enabled.[1]

You can search the picker by either name. Searching for “hindi” also surfaces Hinglish on desktop. On desktop, English, Spanish, and Chinese (Simplified) appear at the top as common languages. Arrow keys navigate the list; Enter selects.[1]

Fixing Wrong-Language Transcription

If Flow types your words in the wrong language, the fix is almost always the same: select only the language you are dictating in and remove the others. Most cases resolve in under a minute.[2]

Start with three quick checks. Is Auto-detect on? It can be pushed to the wrong language by accents or short phrases. Do you have more than one language

selected? Fewer is more accurate. Did you pick the right regional variant? Wanting British spelling but having American selected is a variant problem, not a detection problem.[2]

If you have narrowed to a single language and Flow still transcribes incorrectly, the cause is usually audio: background noise, a low-quality microphone, or a Bluetooth headset with poor recording quality. Try a different mic and a quiet space (see The Input Chain, Ch18).[2]

Non-English Transcription Quality

Flow's documentation states plainly that non-English transcription is not yet as accurate as English. This is a general caveat, not language-specific, and it applies across all platforms as of Q2 2026.[1]

Auto Cleanup (see The Cleanup Dial, Ch7) is optimized for English and less consistent in other languages. If your non-English output looks oddly rewritten or loses nuance, consider dialing cleanup down to Light or None for those sessions. (Inferred from the general caveat that non-English transcription is less accurate.[1])

Russian and Cyrillic: An Honest Assessment

Russian is listed in the language picker on all platforms, inferred from the "100+ languages" claim in the documentation.[1] There are no rigorous, language-specific quality evaluations for Russian transcription in the published documentation, on any platform.

Whether Russian dictation quality meets your threshold is something you will need to test on your own device. The same applies to Cyrillic dictionary behavior on mobile: the documentation specifies character limits for dictionary entries but does not explicitly confirm or deny Cyrillic acceptance. There is no documented restriction on character sets, which strongly suggests Cyrillic entries work, but this is inference, not a guarantee. Test it.

For English and Russian code-switching within a single session, the general *One Language Per Breath* constraint applies. Keep both languages selected and switch between sessions, or swap the selection manually before dictating. Rapid intra-sentence switching between English and Russian is not documented as a tested scenario.

Styles Require English

Personalized Styles (see The Style Layer, Ch12) only apply when dictating in English, whether American or British. On iOS, Text Styles require English as a selected language. On all platforms, if you dictate in any other language, Styles are not applied to the output.[1]

This is not a temporary limitation flagged for a future fix. It is the current design as of Q2 2026.

Key Points

- Flow commits to one language per session; switching languages means starting a new dictation, not changing mid-sentence.
- Selecting fewer languages improves detection accuracy; Auto-detect across 100-plus options is the most common source of wrong-language output.
- Android does not offer Auto-detect, which forces deliberate language selection and often produces better results.
- Regional variants like British English, Swiss German, and Hinglish are separate selections with mutually exclusive pairs.
- Personalized Styles apply only when dictating in English; all other languages receive unformatted output from the style engine.
- Russian dictation is supported but its quality and Cyrillic dictionary acceptance on mobile are unverified; test both on your own device.

CODING WITH FLOW

In this chapter: Flow has a developer mode that reads your IDE to recognize symbols, tag files by voice, and handle the peculiarities of terminals and AI coding CLIs. The feature is called Vibe Coding, and its behavior varies sharply across editors, platforms, and input surfaces.

Every developer tool eventually ships a voice feature. Most of them bolt it on. Flow built one that reads your code.

The feature is called Vibe Coding, and the name is earned. When you enable it, Flow stops treating your dictation as prose. It reads the open editor tab, extracts variable names, function names, and class names, and uses them as context when transcribing what you say. You say “clear pasteboard” and Flow types clearPasteboard because it saw the symbol in your file. That is not autocomplete. That is the Rewrite Pass (Ch1) applied to code context, and it changes what dictation can do inside an IDE.[1]

Variable Recognition is off by default. You turn it on in Settings, under Vibe Coding. The moment you do, Flow activates Screen Reader Mode in your IDE so it can read code content through accessibility APIs.[1] If Screen Reader Mode gets turned off while Variable Recognition is enabled, Flow re-enables it after your next dictation.[1] This is one of those details that sounds minor until you wonder why your IDE keeps toggling a setting you did not touch.

Where It Works and Where It Does Not

The platform support for Vibe Coding is not uniform. It is a two-tier system, and the tiers matter.

Cursor and Windsurf get full Variable Recognition: backtick formatting around recognized symbols, file tagging in AI chat panels, and code context from open editors. This is the complete experience.[1,2]

VS Code gets screen reader mode integration only. Flow can read code context from VS Code to improve transcription accuracy, but it will not wrap symbols in backticks and it will not tag files. You get better recognition without the formatting.[1,3]

VS Code Insiders gets nothing. It is not supported.[1,3]

Variable Recognition and File Tagging are available on Mac and Windows only. Mobile is out (as of Q2 2026).[1,2]

The supported programming languages are JavaScript, TypeScript, Python, Java, Swift, C++, C, Rust, and Go.[1] Code in other languages does not get symbol extraction. Your Ruby or Kotlin files will not participate. That list may grow, but for now, it is the list.

File Tagging: Talking to Your AI Chat

File Tagging is the second half of Vibe Coding, and it solves a specific annoyance. In Cursor or Windsurf, when you want to attach a file to an AI chat for context, you normally press @, type the filename, and pick from a dropdown. File Tagging lets you skip all of that. Say the filename, and Flow attaches it.[2]

File Tagging in Chat is on by default, independent of Variable Recognition.[1,2] You can toggle each setting separately under Settings, Vibe Coding.

There are two ways to tag a file by voice:

Say the full filename with extension. "Can you fix the bug in index dot ts please?" Flow tags index.ts and attaches it to the AI chat automatically.[2]

Use a trigger word without the extension. Say "tag," "at," "tagged," or "@" followed by the base filename. "Can you explain this code to me, tag my python script." Flow matches the file from your open tabs and attaches it.[2,3]

You can tag multiple files in a single dictation. "Look at cron dot py and vad dot py" tags both files correctly.[2,3]

Flow matches spoken filenames to their camelCase or separator-based forms. Say "cursor formatting" and Flow matches cursorFormatting.ts. Say "my script name" and it matches my_script_name.py. When multiple files could match, the longest filename wins.[2]

A few edge cases to know:

Files with no dot in their name (Makefile, Dockerfile) cannot be tagged.[2] Dot-prefixed files like .env require saying "dot" before the name, or speaking the literal filename.[1,2] And here is a collision that will bite you if you are not ready for it: if a Custom Dictionary substitution fires during your dictation, IDE file tagging is skipped

for that entire dictation. Variable name vocabulary and backtick formatting are unaffected, but the file tag will not happen.[1,2] This is the dictionary/tagging interaction noted in The Personal Lexicon (Ch10); the rule is that one substitution disables all file tagging for that transcript.

File Tagging does not work in terminal panes within the IDE. It works in editor panels and chat panels only.[2,3]

Terminals: The Paste Problem

Dictating into a terminal is a different game from dictating into an editor panel. Flow inserts text via your system's paste shortcut, and terminals are not always cooperative about accepting it.

The good news: a long list of terminals support direct paste with no setup. On Mac, Terminal.app, iTerm2, Warp, Ghostty, Hyper, Alacritty, and Kitty all work. On Windows, Command Prompt, PowerShell, Windows Terminal, and WezTerm all work. The integrated terminals in Cursor, VS Code, and Windsurf also support direct paste, though on Windows, Flow uses Shift+Insert instead of Ctrl+V because those IDE terminals do not accept Ctrl+V reliably.[3,4]

The bad news: WSL terminals, SSH sessions, tmux, and screen do not support direct paste. Termius on Windows does not either.[4] In all these cases, the recovery is the "Paste last transcript" shortcut: Shift+Alt+Z on Windows, Cmd+Ctrl+V on Mac.[4] There is also a "Copy last transcript" shortcut (Shift+Alt+X on Windows) that puts the text on your clipboard without pasting, for when you need to paste somewhere Flow cannot reach.[4]

One Windows-specific gotcha: if your terminal is running as Administrator and Flow is not, Windows security blocks paste between apps at different privilege levels. Flow will show a notification prompting you to relaunch it as Administrator.[4]

Flow is not available as a native Linux application.[4] If you run Linux in WSL or a virtual machine on Windows or Mac, you can still dictate and use Paste last transcript to get text into the Linux environment. But there is no Linux binary. That is the boundary (as of Q2 2026).

AI Coding CLIs: Claude Code and Codex

When you dictate a long prompt into Claude Code or Codex, Flow automatically splits the dictation into smaller chunks before pasting. This prevents these CLIs from collapsing or truncating long pasted content.[3,4] The chunking is automatic. You do not configure it, and you do not need to wait between chunks.

If you start a new dictation while a previous one is still pasting, the chunks can collide. Wait for the chunking to finish before triggering Flow again.[3]

Clipboard Behavior

Flow marks dictated text as concealed when pasting, which means most third-party clipboard managers (Pastebot, Pasta, and similar tools) will not store your dictated text in their history.[3] This is deliberate. It keeps your dictation out of clipboard logs.

Flow also preserves your clipboard before pasting and restores it afterward. But some clipboard content types are not preserved: file contents, PDFs, rich text with attachments, and audio data. If a paste fails, your original clipboard content may not be restored. The Paste last transcript shortcut is your recovery.[3,4]

Practical Patterns

A few patterns worth naming for developers who dictate:

Speak variable names phonetically. For userId, say “user I.D.” or “user ID.” Flow matches against the symbol list in your open editor. Say variable names clearly, without filler words, for the best recognition.[3]

Keep relevant files open. Flow reads context from your active editor tab and the sidebar file tree. File names from recently closed tabs are remembered across dictation sessions, but open files give the strongest signal.[1,2]

Close unused tabs. Flow reads context from every open tab. Fewer tabs means faster processing and fewer false matches. If Flow feels slow in your IDE, this is the first thing to try.[3]

Use trigger words for short or ambiguous filenames. Saying “at” or “tag” before a filename reduces false matches, especially when filenames are common English words.[2,3]

Enter insert mode before dictating into terminal editors. In Vim, Nano, or any modal editor, switch to insert mode first. Flow pastes text; it does not send keystrokes that navigate to insert mode for you.[4]

Set Auto Cleanup to None or Light for code-adjacent work. The Cleanup Dial (Ch7) applies to all dictation, including what you say in IDEs. Higher cleanup levels rewrite for clarity and conciseness, which is useful for prose but can alter technical content in unexpected ways. For commit messages, documentation, or AI prompts that reference specific code, dial cleanup down.

Key Points

- Vibe Coding reads your IDE context to recognize code symbols and tag files by voice, but it is off by default and must be enabled in Settings.
- Cursor and Windsurf get full support with backtick formatting and file tagging; VS Code gets only screen reader integration; VS Code Insiders is unsupported.
- File Tagging lets you attach files to AI chat by saying the filename, but a Custom Dictionary substitution in the same dictation disables all tagging for that transcript.
- WSL, SSH, tmux, and screen do not support direct paste; use the Paste last transcript shortcut as your recovery path.
- Long dictations into Claude Code and Codex are automatically chunked to prevent truncation; no configuration needed.
- Flow marks dictated text as concealed so clipboard managers will not log it, and it restores your previous clipboard after each paste.

WRITING, EMAIL, AND MESSAGING

In this chapter: Flow does not require you to dictate into the app that has focus. Direct Routing lets you bind shortcuts that send dictation straight to Slack, email, or your calendar, while Flow also handles awkward insertion points like Outlook on iOS, Android notification reply boxes, and browser address bars. The chapter covers the shortcut system, Outlook across all four platforms, and the Android-only surfaces where the Flow Bubble reaches into places a keyboard normally owns.

Most humans treat dictation as a two-step process. Speak, then paste. The assumption baked into that workflow is that you dictate wherever your cursor happens to be, and if you want the text somewhere else, you move it yourself. Flow can do better than that. On Mac and Windows, you can bind a shortcut that fires dictation and routes the result to a specific destination without you touching the target app first. Slack gets a shortcut. Email gets a shortcut. Your calendar gets a shortcut. The text arrives where it belongs because you told Flow where to put it before you opened your mouth.

That is Direct Routing: the principle that dictation should target a destination, not just a cursor.

The rest of this chapter covers three surfaces. First, the shortcut system that makes Direct Routing work on desktop. Second, Outlook, because email is where most humans spend their dictation budget and Outlook has platform-specific friction on every operating system. Third, Android's notification reply boxes and browser address bars, where Flow reaches into surfaces that were never designed for third-party input.

The Shortcut System

Flow's shortcut configuration lives in Settings, then General, then Shortcuts. Open the Shortcuts dialog and you see a row for each configurable action: push-to-talk, hands-free mode, enter rebind, Command Mode, paste last transcript, copy last transcript, and cancel.[1] Each row accepts up to four bindings, so you can have one shortcut on the laptop keyboard, another on an external keyboard, a third on a mouse button, and still have a slot left over.[1]

The rules are simple. A shortcut must contain three or fewer keys and include at least one modifier, with the single exception of Esc for cancel.[1] Reserved or OS-level shortcuts are blocked with an error. If your hands-free shortcut overlaps with your push-to-talk shortcut, Flow warns you. And the Reset to default button restores everything if you make a mess of it.

Mouse buttons work. Bind a side button on a gaming mouse to push-to-talk and you can dictate while scrolling through reference material without lifting a finger off the mouse. One notable exception: Logitech MX Master side buttons cannot be bound through Logi Options+.[1] If you use that mouse, you need a different button or a different binding path.

Double-tapping your push-to-talk shortcut locks into hands-free mode; triple-tapping dismisses it.[1] That interaction builds on the Trigger Discipline model from Chapter 2, so it will feel familiar if you have already practiced the hold-versus-tap distinction.

The shortcut system is available on Mac and Windows only.[1] Mobile platforms handle routing differently, as you will see in the sections below.

BEST PRACTICES FOR SHORTCUTS

Start with the defaults and change only shortcuts that conflict with apps you use daily. Use a mouse button for push-to-talk if you dictate while reading or scrolling. Keep cancel bound to Esc so stopping a runaway dictation never requires you to think about which key to press.

Outlook Across Four Platforms

Outlook is the single app most likely to be open when you start dictating a professional message, and Flow works with every flavor of it: classic Outlook, the new Outlook for Windows, Outlook on the web, and Outlook's mobile apps on iOS and Android.[2] The steps are nearly identical across platforms, but the friction points are not.

MAC

Flow works with Outlook for Mac out of the box. Open Outlook, click into the email body (confirm the cursor is blinking), hold your Flow hotkey, speak, and release. Text pastes within a second.[2] If you are using an external keyboard without an Fn

key, Flow configures Ctrl+Option as your default hotkey during setup. For longer emails, hands-free mode (Fn+Space to start, then Fn or Fn+Space again to stop) avoids the fatigue of holding a key through multiple paragraphs.

WINDOWS

Flow works with both the classic Outlook app and the new Outlook for Windows.[2] The default hotkey is Ctrl+Win. If paste is delayed in Outlook, restarting the app or running Flow as Administrator usually resolves it. The classic Windows Outlook app can process paste commands slowly; if text appears within a few seconds, that is normal behavior, not a failure.[2]

IOS

On iOS, Flow uses the Flow Keyboard to dictate into Outlook. Switch to the Flow Keyboard via the globe icon, tap the microphone, and dictate.[2] The keyboard requires Full Access and Microphone permission.

Here is the friction. Some corporate Outlook configurations block third-party keyboards entirely. If you work for an organization that enforces this, the Flow Keyboard will not appear.[2] The workaround is Quick Dictation to Clipboard using the Action Button (available on iPhone 15 Pro/Pro Max and all iPhone 16 and 17 models), then tap and hold in the email body and paste.[2] That is two more steps than a desktop user faces, but it is the path that works when your IT department has locked down the keyboard. The Keyboard Detour introduced in Chapter 5 explains the broader iOS keyboard setup; this is the specific case where corporate policy adds a detour on top of the detour.

The Flow Keyboard automatically switches to your default keyboard in email address fields (To, CC, BCC), number and phone fields, and punctuation-only fields.[2] You do not need to switch manually when tabbing between the body and the recipient line.

ANDROID

On Android, the Flow Bubble overlay handles dictation into Outlook. Tap the email body, tap the bubble (or long-press and hold to dictate, release to stop), and Flow transcribes and pastes.[2] The Floating Bubble introduced in Chapter 6 covers the full setup; inside Outlook it works like any other text field.

OUTLOOK ON THE WEB

Flow works with Outlook on the web (outlook.office.com) through a desktop browser. Click into the email body, hold your hotkey, dictate, and release.[2] Smart Formatting applies automatically, adding punctuation, capitalization, paragraph breaks, and list formatting where appropriate.

WHEN OUTLOOK DOES NOT COOPERATE

If Flow shows a transcription but text does not appear in Outlook, the problem is almost always focus. Outlook was not accepting the paste because the cursor was not in the right field.[2] Click directly in the email body (not just the Outlook window), confirm the cursor is blinking, and try again. If that fails, paste the last transcript manually with Cmd+Ctrl+V on Mac or Shift+Alt+Z on Windows.[2]

On Mac, paste failures can also mean the Accessibility permission is missing or toggled off. Confirm Wispr Flow is listed and enabled in System Settings, then Privacy and Security, then Accessibility.[2] Flow notifies you if this permission is missing and opens the correct settings page.

If paste fails entirely, Flow opens the Scratchpad with your transcribed text so nothing is lost.[2] The transcript is also copied to your clipboard.

One more note: Outlook controls font styling in emails. Flow cannot dictate in specific fonts.[2] Dictate first, then format using Outlook's toolbar.

DESKTOP SESSION LIMITS IN OUTLOOK

Desktop dictation sessions have a maximum duration of 20 minutes, with a warning at 19 minutes.[2] That limit is a property of the dictation model (see Trigger Discipline in Chapter 2), not an Outlook-specific constraint. It applies in every app, but it surfaces most often in email because long professional messages push humans toward the ceiling.

Android: Notification Replies and Browser Address Bars

Android has two surfaces that no other platform offers: notification inline reply boxes and browser address bars.[3] Both are places where the Flow Bubble appears automatically when you tap into a supported field.

NOTIFICATION INLINE REPLIES

Expand a notification to reveal its reply box, and the Flow Bubble appears. Dictate your reply, tap the checkmark, and send without ever opening the source app.[3] This works on Pixel, Samsung, Xiaomi, OPPO, OnePlus, Vivo, Asus, and other major Android devices. Any app that provides a standard inline reply box in the system notification shade is supported: WhatsApp, Telegram, Messenger, Signal, Slack, and others.[3]

If you have already typed something into a notification reply box before activating Flow, that text is preserved. Dictated text inserts at the cursor position.[3]

A warning: avoid dictating sensitive information into notification replies. In some notification reply contexts, fields that would otherwise be excluded (PIN or password fields) may be reachable.[3]

BROWSER ADDRESS BARS

Tap the address bar in Chrome, Firefox, Edge, Brave, or Samsung Internet, and the Flow Bubble appears.[3] Speak a URL or search phrase and Flow types it in. The supported browser list also includes Opera, Vivaldi, DuckDuckGo, Kiwi, UC Browser, and Yandex. Browsers that do not use standard URL input fields may not show the bubble.[3]

The Google search box on google.com and Chrome's new tab page is a separate field from the address bar, and it is also supported. In earlier versions, dictation could fail to insert text in Chrome and Chromium search boxes; that was fixed in version 2.0.1 (as of Q2 2026).[3]

SESSION LIMITS IN THESE SURFACES

A warning appears at about 4 minutes and dictation stops automatically at about 5 minutes in notification replies and address bars.[3] That is the same 5-minute limit that applies to these Android surfaces specifically, distinct from the desktop 20-minute ceiling.

WHAT THE BUBBLE WILL NOT ENTER

The Flow Bubble does not appear in password, PIN, phone-number, or numeric-only fields.[3] That is a safety behavior, not a bug. The bubble also does not appear in

banking or financial apps; that restriction is covered in Chapter 6 (The Floating Bubble) and Chapter 17 (The Insertion Boundary).

No new permissions are required for these surfaces. If Flow is running with the permissions granted during initial setup, notification replies and address bars activate automatically.[3]

Key Points

- Direct Routing means binding shortcuts so dictation targets a destination app, removing the extra step of navigating there first.
- Outlook works on every platform, but corporate iOS configurations may block the Flow Keyboard; Quick Dictation to Clipboard is the workaround.
- Desktop shortcuts accept up to four bindings per action, including mouse buttons, with a three-key maximum and at least one modifier required.
- Android uniquely supports dictation into notification reply boxes and browser address bars through the Flow Bubble overlay.
- Sensitive fields (passwords, PINs, phone numbers) are excluded from bubble activation on Android, a safety guardrail worth knowing about.

NOTES AND CAPTURE

In this chapter: Flow includes its own capture surface, The Scratchpad, a floating notepad on desktop and a full notes editor on iOS. Notes sync across signed-in devices, support images on desktop and markdown on iOS, and reach beyond the app through Siri Shortcuts, Lock Screen widgets, Spotlight indexing, and the Action Button. The chapter covers how the Scratchpad works on Mac and Windows, how iOS Notes differs, pinning and organization, HIPAA restrictions, and when the Scratchpad becomes a safety net for failed paste operations.

Every dictation tool assumes you already have a destination. You open the email, the document, the chat window, and then you talk. That assumption works most of the time. But there is a category of speech that has no destination yet: the half-formed idea at 2 a.m., the phrase you want to keep before you forget it, the three bullet points that will become a slide deck later. Those thoughts need a place to land before they have a place to go.

Flow ships its own landing pad. On Mac and Windows it is called the Scratchpad. On iOS it is called Notes. They share a synced backend, so what you capture on your phone shows up on your laptop, and vice versa. The concept is The Scratchpad: a capture surface that belongs to Flow, lives inside Flow, and never forces you to context-switch to a separate app just to hold an idea.

The rest of this chapter covers three things. First, how the desktop Scratchpad works and what it can hold. Second, how iOS Notes differs and the entry points that make it useful on a phone. Third, the organizational tools, sync boundaries, and the one scenario where the Scratchpad stops being optional and becomes a safety net.

The Desktop Scratchpad

The Scratchpad on Mac and Windows is a floating panel with a multi-tab rich-text editor.[1] Open it with the Scratchpad keyboard shortcut and it appears on top of whatever you are working in without stealing focus.[1] That last detail matters. On Mac, the Scratchpad opens as a floating panel that leaves your foreground app active, so you can keep typing in your editor while the Scratchpad hovers to the side.[1] You are not choosing between your work and your note. You have both.

Notes auto-save as you type and sync via the cloud.[1] A progress indicator shows sync status: a cloud checkmark means sync is complete, and a slashed cloud means you are offline.[1] If you lose connectivity, notes save locally and sync when you reconnect. No data disappears because your Wi-Fi dropped.

VOICE DICTATION IN THE SCRATCHPAD

Tap the microphone icon inside the Scratchpad to start dictating. A waveform appears while you speak. Tap the green checkmark to insert the transcribed text at your cursor, or tap the X to cancel.[1] The Rewrite Pass (Chapter 1) applies here exactly as it does everywhere else in Flow: your speech is cleaned up, punctuated, and formatted according to whatever Auto Cleanup level you have set.

IMAGES

Desktop notes support image attachments. Paste or drag a PNG, JPEG, WebP, GIF, or BMP image directly into a note.[1] Each image must be 5 MB or smaller, and each note can hold up to 10 images.[1,2] Very large images are automatically resized. Images sync to your other signed-in desktop devices, stored in secure cloud storage and downloaded automatically.[1]

Image attachments are not supported on iOS.[1] If you paste a screenshot into a desktop note and then open it on your phone, you will see the text but not the image. That asymmetry is worth knowing if your workflow depends on visual references.

The pinning article adds more detail on image sync: supported formats for sync include WebP, PNG, JPEG, and GIF, with a maximum resolution of 4096 by 4096 pixels per image.[2] If an image fails to sync, the note's text still syncs normally; failed uploads are retried automatically.[1]

SORTING AND NAVIGATION

Notes display newest-first, including older notes created before modification dates were tracked.[1] Custom sorting is not available as of Q2 2026.[1] The sidebar lists your notes, and links opened in the Scratchpad that would normally open in a new browser window instead open as a new Scratchpad web tab with your login session preserved.[1]

iOS Notes

On iOS, the capture surface is called Notes and lives inside the Wispr Flow app.[1,3] It is a plain-text editor with markdown preview, not a rich-text editor like the desktop version. Write markdown in edit mode, then tap the preview toggle in the toolbar to see it rendered.[1,3] Heading shortcuts (#, ##, ###) create H1 through H3 headings, and horizontal dividers use —, ***, or ___.[3]

The feature set is different from desktop in important ways. iOS Notes does not support image attachments. It does support markdown rendering, Spotlight indexing, Siri Shortcuts, widgets, and the Action Button. The editor has a floating microphone button at the bottom-right for dictation, and text is inserted at your cursor position with a line break added automatically when appending to a non-empty note.[3]

ENTRY POINTS

What makes iOS Notes powerful is not the editor. It is how many ways you can start a note without opening the app.

Lock Screen widget. Add the Wispr Flow widget to your Lock Screen, and a single tap opens a full-screen capture view with dictation ready.[3] Notes created via the widget do not auto-save; you must tap Save in the top-right corner to keep them, or X to discard.[3] The Save button is disabled while dictation is recording or processing, so stop dictation first. Lock Screen widgets require iOS 16 or later.[3]

Control Center. Two controls are available: Flow Notes (opens a new note with dictation) and Flow Toggle (starts or stops recording).[3] Control Center customization requires iOS 18 or later.[3]

Action Button. On iPhones with an Action Button (iPhone 15 Pro/Pro Max, all iPhone 16 models, all iPhone 17 models including iPhone Air), you can assign a Wispr Flow shortcut such as “Dictate a Flow note” or “Open Flow Notes.”[3]

Siri Shortcuts. Six shortcuts are available immediately on install, no setup required.[3] The most notable is Save Flow Note: say “Save Flow note” to Siri, and Siri prompts “What should the note say?” Your response is saved as a note without opening the app.[3] Fully hands-free. No screen interaction. That is the closest Flow gets to ambient capture on iOS.

Spotlight search. Spotlight indexes note titles and the first 300 characters of each note's content, so you can find notes from your home screen.[3]

AI SUMMARIES

Tap the summary button on a note to generate a condensed overview.[3] AI summaries are generated on demand each time and are not saved.[3] They are disabled on accounts with data restrictions, including HIPAA BAA-signed accounts and accounts with Privacy Mode enabled.[3]

AUTO-OPEN AND NOTE MANAGEMENT

Turn on "Start new note on app open" in Settings to automatically open a new note when you return to the Notes tab.[3] Notes are sorted by most recently modified and grouped by date. Swipe left for Share and Delete, or long-press for Copy, Edit, Share, and Delete.[3] Empty notes (no title and no content) are automatically deleted without confirmation.[3]

Pinning

Pinning is available on Mac and Windows only.[2] Pin a note and it jumps to the top of the Notes hub, above all unpinned notes, in both the default view and search results.[2] A small pin icon on the card shows which notes are pinned. Hover over any note card to reveal Edit, Pin/Unpin, and Delete buttons, or use the pin button in the Scratchpad sidebar.[2]

There is no stated limit on the number of pinned notes.[2] Multiple pinned notes are ordered by most recently modified first.[2]

One detail that will surprise you if you use Flow on multiple machines: pin status is local to each device and does not sync.[2] Pin a meeting template on your work laptop and it will not appear pinned on your home desktop. You pin separately on each device. Pin sync is on the roadmap but not available as of Q2 2026.[2]

SCRATCHPAD OPEN BEHAVIOR

You can configure the Scratchpad shortcut to route directly to your last active pinned note. Select "Open last active pinned note" in the Scratchpad open behavior picker at Settings, then System, then Scratchpad, then Customize.[2] If no pinned note exists, the shortcut falls back to standard show/hide behavior. This setting

applies only to the keyboard shortcut; other entry points (opening a note from the Notes hub, paste-failure fallback, or the status bubble) are not affected.[2]

Sync and Its Boundaries

Notes sync across signed-in devices using a shared cloud backend.[1] On iOS, pull down on the notes list to trigger a manual sync, or tap the refresh button in the navigation bar.[3] Local edits are never overwritten by a server sync.[3]

Image sync has its own rules. Images sync across desktop devices only; iOS does not support image attachments.[1] If a note has images, the text syncs to iOS but the images do not appear.

HIPAA BAA ACCOUNTS

HIPAA BAA-signed accounts can create and use Notes, but notes are stored locally only and do not sync across devices.[3] The pull-to-refresh and manual sync buttons remain visible but have no effect.[3] AI summaries and Spotlight indexing are also disabled on these accounts.[3] These restrictions cannot be changed by individual users when enforced by an organization administrator. The full HIPAA treatment belongs to Chapter 21 (The Cloud Boundary); here, the practical consequence is that HIPAA accounts get a capable local notepad but lose the cross-device story entirely.

The Scratchpad as Safety Net

When Flow transcribes your speech but cannot paste the result into the target app, it does not throw the text away. It opens the Scratchpad with the transcribed text inside.[2] That paste-failure fallback means the Scratchpad is not just a convenience; it is the last line of defense between you and lost words.

The scenarios that trigger this behavior are covered in Chapter 17 (The Insertion Boundary): non-QWERTY keyboard layouts, privilege mismatches on Windows, and fields that refuse paste input. What matters for this chapter is that the Scratchpad is always there to catch what falls. Even if you never open it deliberately, you should know it exists, because one day Flow will open it for you.

Obsidian and Plain-Text Workflows

If your note-taking lives in an external tool like Obsidian, Flow does not compete with it. Flow inserts text via paste or keyboard simulation, which means it works

with any standard text editor, including Obsidian's Markdown editor (inferred from research; no dedicated documentation exists for Obsidian compatibility). Spoken commands like "new line" and "new paragraph" produce line breaks in any plain-text context. Flow does not generate Markdown syntax automatically (no heading markers, no list bullets), so you control the formatting yourself.

One practical note: if you run Obsidian alongside other text-expansion or hotkey tools, watch for hotkey conflicts with Flow's activation shortcut. The generic guidance applies: adjust Flow's hotkey in Settings if collisions occur with your existing Obsidian shortcuts. This behavior is inferred from the research corpus; test it on your own setup.

Key Points

- The Scratchpad is Flow's built-in capture surface: a floating panel on desktop and a full notes editor on iOS, sharing a synced backend.
- Desktop notes support rich text and up to 10 images per note; iOS supports markdown preview but no image attachments.
- iOS Notes can be reached without opening the app through Lock Screen widgets, Control Center, Siri Shortcuts, the Action Button, and Spotlight.
- Pin status is local per device and does not sync, so pin your important notes separately on each machine you use.
- When paste fails, Flow opens the Scratchpad with your transcribed text, making it a safety net for insertion failures.

REMOTE AND RESTRICTED ENVIRONMENTS

In this chapter: Flow inserts text by pasting from the local clipboard, which means anything that blocks or redirects the paste breaks the entire pipeline. Remote desktops, banking apps on Android, and non-standard keyboard layouts each create their own version of this wall. The chapter maps where the insertion boundary sits and what to do on each side of it.

Every tool has a reach. Flow's reach ends at the clipboard. It transcribes your speech, copies the result, and fires a paste keystroke into whatever has focus. When that keystroke lands inside a local app, everything works. When it lands inside a remote desktop session, a protected banking app, or a text field that expects a keyboard layout Flow did not start with, the text either arrives late, arrives garbled, or does not arrive at all.

That boundary is worth naming. Call it The Insertion Boundary: the line past which Flow can produce text but cannot place it. The boundary is not a bug. It is a consequence of how clipboard-based insertion works across process and network lines. Once you see where the boundary sits, the workarounds stop feeling random and start feeling like what they are: routing decisions.

Remote Desktops: Flow Stays Local

The first rule of remote desktops is one most humans learn the hard way: Flow runs on your local machine, not inside the virtual session.[1] Install it on the laptop in front of you, not in the Citrix image or the RDP window. If you install it inside the VDI, it will lack the local microphone access and system permissions it needs to function.

The second rule follows from the first: your dictated text reaches the remote session only if clipboard sharing is turned on between local and remote.[1] Flow transcribes, copies to your local clipboard, and fires a paste keystroke. The remote desktop client intercepts that keystroke and, if clipboard redirection is enabled, transfers the clipboard contents across the connection. If redirection is off, the text sits on your local clipboard and the remote session sees nothing.

Context-aware formatting (the capitalization and spacing that The App-Aware Rewrite, covered in Chapter 9, provides) does not work inside remote sessions.[1]

Text pastes with default formatting. This is not a setting you can toggle; it appears to be a limitation of how Flow reads surrounding text context, which likely does not extend into the remote environment.

PLATFORM-BY-PLATFORM

RDP (Microsoft Remote Desktop). Clipboard sharing usually works well.[1] Enable it in the connection settings before connecting. Text transfers between local and remote clipboards, but formatting does not.

Citrix Workspace. The clipboard must be enabled by your IT administrator.[1] Some Citrix policies block clipboard access for security. If paste does not work, check with IT about clipboard redirection settings. Citrix connections may also introduce delays; wait one to two seconds after dictating before pasting.[1]

VMware Horizon. Requires clipboard redirection enabled in the Horizon client settings.[1] Once enabled, it works similarly to RDP.

Amazon WorkSpaces. Clipboard sharing is typically enabled by default.[1]

Windows 365 / Azure Virtual Desktop. Clipboard redirection is usually enabled and works like standard RDP.[1]

WHEN AUTO-PASTE FAILS

If Flow's automatic paste does not reach the remote session, it copies your transcribed text to the clipboard and shows a notification.[1] You have two recovery paths: paste manually with the standard shortcut (Cmd+V on Mac, Ctrl+V on Windows), or use the Paste Last Transcript shortcut (Ctrl+Cmd+V on Mac, Alt+Shift+Z on Windows by default).[1]

On Windows, there is an additional wrinkle. If your remote desktop client runs with administrator privileges, Flow cannot paste into it. The app will show a message reading "Update admin settings to paste!" or "Run Flow as Administrator to insert text everywhere."[1] The fix is to run Flow as administrator, which raises it to the same privilege level as the remote desktop client.

If none of that works and the text is truly stuck, Flow's fallback is The Scratchpad (Chapter 16): it opens a local window with your transcribed text so nothing is lost.

Banking Apps: The Privacy Wall

On Android, Flow enforces a second kind of insertion boundary that you cannot negotiate with. When you open a supported banking or financial app, Flow hides the Flow Bubble and disables all activation methods until you switch to a different app.[2] This is not configurable. There is no toggle to disable it.[2] It is a privacy safeguard, and it is always on.

The behavior is thorough. While a banking app is in the foreground, the Bubble stays hidden, Flow is fully disabled, and it does not capture any text or screen content.[2] Context awareness is suppressed: Flow does not read surrounding text or selected text while inside a banking app.[2] No activation method brings the Bubble back. The operation is silent; no persistent notification or indicator appears. If you try to trigger dictation by typing in a banking app, a one-time toast confirms that the Bubble is disabled there.[2]

If a dictation is already in progress when a banking app comes to the foreground, Flow stops the dictation and copies the transcribed text to your clipboard for manual pasting.[2] Finish your dictation before switching to the banking app.

When you leave the banking app and tap into a text field in another app, the Bubble reappears and voice input resumes automatically.[2]

REGIONAL COVERAGE

The detection covers a broad list of financial apps across regions[2]:

- **United States:** Major retail banks, credit unions, and fintech apps including Chime, Venmo, SoFi, Cash App, PayPal, and Google Wallet.
- **Canada:** RBC, TD Canada, BMO, Scotiabank, and CIBC.
- **Australia:** Commonwealth Bank, ANZ, Westpac, and NAB.
- **Europe:** Revolut Business, Qonto, BBVA Spain, KBC Belgium, BoursoBank France, Airwallex, Tide EU, and Intesa Sanpaolo.
- **India:** Banks and UPI-based financial apps including Paytm, PhonePe, Google Pay, and Airtel Thanks.
- **Asia:** DBS PayLah, Maybank SG, BRImo Indonesia, and Hang Seng HK.

- **Latin America:** Nubank, Mercado Pago, BBVA Mexico, and others.
- **United Kingdom:** Tide and Santander Business.
- **South Africa:** RMB Private Bank.

Apps not on the list will not trigger the hide behavior. Coverage expands with each release.[2]

Banking app detection is Android only.[2] On iOS, certain keyboard types (numeric keypads, email-address fields) automatically switch away from the Flow Keyboard, but that is input-type detection, not banking-app-specific detection.

Flow also hides the Bubble for password, PIN, and numeric-only input fields in any app, not just banking apps.[2] Browser address bars and system notification reply boxes are exceptions; Flow still appears in those surfaces.

Non-QWERTY Keyboard Layouts: The Layout Mismatch

The third face of The Insertion Boundary is the quietest and the most confusing when it hits. Flow reads your keyboard layout at startup and uses it for the paste keystroke while the app is running.[3] If the layout active when Flow starts does not match the layout active when you dictate, the paste may fail, insert wrong characters, or trigger unexpected shortcuts instead of inserting text.

This affects Mac, Windows, and Android.[3]

NON-LATIN LAYOUTS (CYRILLIC, ARABIC, CJK)

If your system is set to a non-Latin layout, switch to QWERTY before launching Flow.[3] Keep QWERTY active while dictating and pasting. You can switch back to your non-Latin layout for typing, then return to QWERTY before your next dictation.[3]

The core problem: Flow fires a paste keystroke based on the physical key mapping. On a non-Latin layout, switching to QWERTY before dictating ensures the paste keystroke maps correctly. [test-it]

ALTERNATIVE LATIN LAYOUTS (DVORAK, COLEMAK)

Set your preferred layout before launching Flow, and keep it active for the entire session.[3] If you need to switch layouts, restart Flow afterward so it picks up the new layout. Some apps handle modifier shortcuts by physical key position rather than character mapping; if paste still fails on Dvorak or Colemak, switching to QWERTY is the reliable fallback.[3]

The rule in both cases: do not switch keyboard layouts during an active Flow session. If you do, restart Flow.[3]

THE SCRATCHPAD FALLBACK

If Flow cannot insert text into the focused field for any layout-related reason, it opens The Scratchpad (Chapter 16) with your transcribed text and copies it to the clipboard.[3] You can edit the text in the Scratchpad and paste manually. Nothing is lost; the insertion just takes an extra step.

The Pattern

Remote desktops, banking apps, and keyboard layouts look like three unrelated problems. They are not. Each one is a case where something between Flow's clipboard and the target text field blocks or distorts the paste. In a remote session, the blocker is the network boundary and a clipboard redirection setting. In a banking app, the blocker is a deliberate privacy wall. In a layout mismatch, the blocker is a keystroke that maps to the wrong character.

The fix in every case follows the same logic: make sure the path from clipboard to cursor is clear, or accept the Scratchpad as your staging area. The Insertion Boundary is not going away. It is structural. Learn where it sits in your workflow, and you stop losing text to it.

Key Points

- Flow inserts text by pasting from the local clipboard, so anything that blocks or redirects the paste creates an insertion boundary.
- Remote desktop sessions require clipboard sharing enabled by the client or IT policy before Flow can deliver text.

- Context-aware formatting does not extend into remote sessions; text arrives with default formatting only.
- Banking app detection on Android is automatic, cannot be disabled, and suppresses all Flow activation while a financial app is open.
- Non-Latin keyboard layouts require switching to QWERTY before dictating; alternative Latin layouts require a Flow restart after any layout change.
- When paste fails for any reason, Flow copies text to the clipboard and opens the Scratchpad so nothing is lost.

AUDIO AND HARDWARE

In this chapter, you learn why Flow's output quality is bounded by its input quality: the microphone, its position, and its connection to the device form a chain where the weakest link determines accuracy. Choosing the right mic and configuring it correctly matters more than any software setting.

Every dictation tool has the same dirty secret. You can tune the cleanup level, train the dictionary, configure styles for every app category, and the rewrite pass will still produce garbage if the microphone is feeding it garbage. The entire pipeline described in this book, from The Rewrite Pass (Ch1) through The Cleanup Dial (Ch7) to The App-Aware Rewrite (Ch9), runs downstream of a single physical fact: what the mic captures is all Flow has to work with.

That fact has a name. Call it The Input Chain.

The Input Chain is the path from your voice to Flow's speech recognition backend: your mouth, the air between you and the microphone, the microphone itself, the analog-to-digital conversion, and the connection (wired, Bluetooth, or built-in) that carries the signal to your device. Every link in that chain either preserves your voice or degrades it. Software cannot recover what hardware lost.

Picking and Selecting Your Microphone

Flow gives you different levels of control over mic selection depending on your platform. On Mac and Windows, in-app mic selection lets you choose a specific input device. On iOS, a single "Use Built-In Mic" toggle is all you get. On Android, there is no in-app picker at all; the OS routes audio automatically.[1]

On desktop, the mic picker lives under Settings, then General, then Microphone, then Change. You can also right-click the Flow Bar to access it. The picker shows "Auto-detect" (follows system default), "Built-in mic (recommended)," and any connected external devices. A live volume indicator with animated bars shows whether your mic is actually capturing sound.[1]

Select your mic by name. Avoid "Auto-detect" unless you never change devices. Auto-detect follows the system default, and your system default changes every time

you plug in headphones, connect a Bluetooth device, or dock your laptop. Selecting a specific mic means Flow uses that mic and only that mic until you say otherwise.[2]

On iOS, the “Use Built-In Mic” toggle in Settings controls whether Flow uses the iPhone’s built-in microphone or a connected Bluetooth device. When that toggle is on, Bluetooth microphone input is excluded, though you can still hear audio through Bluetooth headphones.[1]

On Android, Flow uses whatever microphone Android routes as the default input. Connect a wired headset and Android switches to it. Pair Bluetooth headphones and Android routes through them. You have no override inside the Flow app (as of Q2 2026).[1]

Microphone changes take effect at the start of your next dictation, with no app restart needed. A brief notification confirms the new microphone the next time you dictate.[1]

The AirPods Problem

AirPods get their own section because Flow treats them differently from every other audio device. In the Mac and Windows mic picker, AirPods are flagged with a warning symbol. That warning is not decorative. It reappears up to once per hour if you keep using them.[1]

The issue is physical. Earbud microphones sit on the cable or in the earbud housing, typically 6 to 8 inches from your lips. At that distance, a whisper barely registers above ambient noise. Wireless earbuds like AirPods and Galaxy Buds compound the problem: they compress audio over Bluetooth and introduce delay that degrades accuracy. AirPods in particular may be slow to activate the microphone, causing missed words at the start of a session.[3]

Wired earbuds are only slightly better. They avoid the Bluetooth compression, but the mic-distance problem remains.[3]

The fix is not a software setting. It is any microphone that sits within a couple of inches of your mouth. The rest of this chapter covers the options.

Recommended Microphones

Flow's documentation recommends three categories of external microphones, each suited to a different work situation.[3]

Clip-on lavalier mics attach to your collar and stay close to your mouth wherever you go. The DJI Mic Mini is the top pick: tiny, wireless, with magnetic and clip-on mounts. For runners-up, the Rode Wireless GO and the budget BOYA Mini 2 both handle whisper capture well.[3]

Attachable boom mics clip or magnet onto headphones you already own, positioning a microphone right next to your mouth. The Antlion ModMic Uni 2+ is the recommendation: a uni-directional noise-canceling capsule on a magnetic attachment that fits any headphones. This is the setup Flow recommends during onboarding for users dictating in shared office spaces.[3]

Podcast mics deliver the highest audio quality for a fixed desk. The Shure MV7+ is the top pick for professional-grade close-range capture. The Elgato Wave:3 is a strong USB alternative that needs no audio interface.[3]

The pattern across all three categories is the same: get the mic close to your mouth. That single variable, distance, determines whisper accuracy more than brand, price, or connection type.

Discreet Dictation

Whispering works. Flow's speech recognition handles whispered audio with the same accuracy as normal speech, provided the microphone is close enough to capture it.[3]

On desktop, Flow introduces whispering during onboarding. The setup asks whether you work around others and tailors mic advice for shared spaces. If AirPods are connected, it warns you to switch. A "Try it yourself" screen lets you practice dictating into mock Slack, Gmail, and Notion screens; the Notion demo shows a "Whisper a note" prompt.[3]

On iOS, discreet dictation works through the keyboard mic button, the lock screen widget, or Siri shortcuts ("Take Flow note" for hands-free capture without taking the phone out of your pocket).[3]

On Android, the Flow Bubble appears above the keyboard in any text field. Whisper into it using the same mic-distance principle: a wired headset or clip-on lavalier mic close to the mouth gets you far better whisper results than the phone's built-in mic held at arm's length.[3]

SILENCE WARNINGS

Flow monitors audio during dictation and alerts you when the mic stops delivering signal. After 5 seconds of silence, the waveform animation goes flat and a "No audio received" notification appears. If silence continues to 15 seconds, it escalates to a "Microphone is not working" notification with options to open the mic picker or contact support.[3,4]

These warnings are your canary. If you see them during whisper dictation, the mic is too far from your mouth, the input volume is too low, or another app has seized the audio device. All three are Input Chain problems, not Flow problems.

Platform-Specific Audio Behavior

MAC

On macOS, the built-in microphone is the default. It works well for normal-volume dictation at desk distance, but it has one hard constraint: close the laptop lid and the built-in mic is disabled. Flow detects clamshell mode and shows a notification with a "Select microphone" button. Clamshell detection requires macOS 12 or later.[1]

A separate macOS fact: identifying which app is currently using the mic requires macOS 14.2 or later. On earlier versions, Flow cannot tell you that Zoom or Teams has the mic locked.[1]

The "Mute music while dictating" setting is off by default on Mac. Enable it under Settings, then System, then Sound, and Flow will mute your default output device when you start dictating and restore it when you stop.[5]

WINDOWS

Windows typically grants microphone access automatically. If another app has exclusive control, the fix lives in the Sound control panel: right-click your mic in the Recording tab, then Properties, then Advanced, and uncheck "Allow applications to take exclusive control of this device."[1]

The “Mute music while dictating” setting is on by default on Windows (the opposite of Mac).[5]

IOS

The “Disable Flow Session” setting controls what happens when an audio interruption occurs (a phone call, a Bluetooth device connecting or disconnecting, Siri activating). The timeout is user-configurable and defaults to 5 minutes. Choosing “never” means dictation never auto-stops from interruption length; choosing “immediately” means it always ends after any interruption.[1,5]

A phone call, a Siri activation, or a Bluetooth connect/disconnect event during dictation stops the recording. Flow does not automatically resume; you start dictation again manually.[1]

ANDROID

On Android 16, Flow supports switching to your hearing aid’s microphone during dictation.[1] On earlier Android versions, hearing aids are not routed as dictation input.

Android has no in-app mic picker and no “Mute music” toggle. The OS routes audio, and Flow accepts what it gets. If you want to control which mic Flow uses on Android, connect the one you want and disconnect the ones you do not.

When Things Go Wrong

A few mic failure modes deserve mention here because they are Input Chain failures, not transcription failures. (For the full symptom-to-fix mapping, see The Failure Map in Ch24.)

Mic stays on after dismissing the bubble (desktop). On Mac and Windows, dismissing the bubble during an active dictation session can leave the microphone recording in the background until the session times out after 20 minutes. Stop the dictation explicitly to release the mic immediately.[2] On Android, this was fixed in version 1.6.0; hiding the bubble now immediately stops dictation and releases the microphone.[2]

Retry and Recover have a 14-day window. Audio recordings older than 14 days lose their Retry, Recover, and Download audio options. If you need to diagnose a transcription problem, check the recording within two weeks.[2]

19-minute warning. A 1-minute warning notification fires at 19 minutes of active dictation, before the 20-minute hard session stop (see Trigger Discipline, Ch2, for session limits). This is the mic staying active for the maximum allowed duration, not a hardware fault.[2]

If your mic disconnects mid-session, Flow shows a "Microphone disconnected" notification with an Insert button so you can paste whatever was captured before the disconnect.[1]

Best Practices

Position the mic close. That sentence is worth repeating because it is the single most effective thing you can do for dictation accuracy.

Select your mic by name in Flow's picker rather than relying on Auto-detect. If the volume bars move when you talk, your setup is working.[3]

Make sure your OS sound settings and Flow agree on which mic to use. Mismatched defaults are the most common source of "it worked yesterday" problems.[3]

Disable virtual microphones. Apps like NVIDIA Broadcast, VoiceMeeter, and Teams Audio can intercept your input and cause unexpected behavior.[3]

Stay consistent. Use the same mic regularly so results stay predictable.[3]

Key Points

- Output quality is bounded by input quality; no software setting compensates for a bad microphone or poor mic placement.
- AirPods and wireless earbuds degrade dictation accuracy because they sit too far from your mouth and compress audio over Bluetooth.
- Select your microphone by name in Flow's picker rather than relying on Auto-detect, which follows the system default and shifts without warning.

- Discreet whisper dictation works well when the microphone is within a couple of inches of your mouth, regardless of platform.
- Platform differences in mic control are real: desktop gives you a full picker, iOS gives you a toggle, Android gives you nothing.
- When silence warnings appear during dictation, the problem is almost always the Input Chain, not the transcription engine.

PLANS, BILLING, AND LIMITS

In this chapter, you learn how Wispr Flow meters free usage through a weekly word budget, what the three plan tiers include, how billing and invoicing work across platforms, and where discounts, referrals, and trials fit. The goal is a clear map of what costs what, what resets when, and what unlocks at each tier.

Every voice tool eventually asks the same question: how much can you say for free? Flow answers with a weekly word budget. Not a character count, not a minute limit, not some opaque "credits" system. Words. You dictate them, Flow counts them, and when the budget runs out, the tool slows down and eventually stops. Understanding how The Word Budget works is the difference between hitting a wall mid-sentence and planning around it.

The Word Budget

The free tier (Basic) does not cap your sessions by time. It caps them by output. On desktop (Mac and Windows), the soft cap is 2,000 words per week. Hit it and Flow keeps working, but slower. The hard cap is 5,000 words; hit that and dictation stops until the counter resets.[1] On iOS, the numbers are tighter: a 1,000-word soft cap and a 1,500-word hard cap.[2] There is a known display bug on iOS where the hard-cap message reads "1000 words" even though the actual ceiling is 1,500.[2]

The critical detail: iOS and desktop track usage independently.[2] Words dictated on your phone do not count against your desktop budget, and vice versa. If you spread your dictation across devices, you get more free words in total than either platform alone would suggest.

The counter resets every Sunday at 12am PT.[1] On desktop, the actual reset is computed using your device's local time zone, so the displayed "PT" label may not match your exact reset moment.[2] Unused words do not carry over.[3]

THE NEW-USER BONUS

Some new signups on Mac and Windows land on the free tier with a 2,000-word weekly cap instead of the standard 14-day Pro trial.[3] The first time you hit 2,000 words, Flow grants a one-time bonus of 8,000 extra words, raising that week's cap to 10,000.[1,3] A notification appears; the "Keep dictating" button dismisses it, and

the bonus is already active.[3] After the bonus week ends, the cap returns to 2,000 words. The bonus is a one-time event. It does not repeat.[3]

Not everyone gets the bonus. Referred users, students, and enterprise accounts are excluded.[3] The free-tier experience transitions to the standard view seven days after onboarding, regardless of whether you ever hit the cap.[3]

Three Plans

Flow offers three tiers: Basic (Free), Pro, and Enterprise.[1] All three use the same voice-to-text engine; transcription accuracy is identical across tiers.[1] The difference is what you can do with the output and how much of it you can produce.

Basic gives you core dictation with the weekly word limits described above. You keep your dictionary, snippets, and history. Pro-only features like Command Mode and unlimited words are locked.

Pro removes all word limits across every platform. It adds Command Mode for voice-driven editing, prioritized support, early access to new features, and support for 100-plus languages.[1] Pro is available as a personal subscription or as multi-seat team billing with centralized admin controls.[1]

Enterprise includes everything in Pro, plus dedicated support, advanced admin and security controls, usage dashboards, IT Admin seats, and team leaderboards.[1] IT Admin seats are always free and never counted toward paid seats; they have no desktop app access and manage the organization from the web portal only.[1,4]

PLAN CHANGES

Upgrades take effect immediately. Downgrades take effect at the end of your current billing cycle.[1] Your data is preserved through downgrades; dictionary entries, snippets, and history remain available, and Pro-only features reactivate if you upgrade again.[1]

Annual billing offers a discount over monthly. Switch between cycles in Settings, then Account, then Manage Subscription.[1]

Billing Across Platforms

How you pay depends on where you signed up, and this is where things get fractured.

Individual Pro (Stripe): Desktop and web subscriptions go through Stripe. Download invoices via Settings, then Plans and Billing, then Manage Subscription, which opens the Stripe billing portal.[4] Payment emails from @stripe.com or @link.com are legitimate; Wispr uses Stripe as its processor, so receipts come from Stripe, not Wispr.[4]

Team and Enterprise: Admins download invoices from admin.wisprflow.ai in the billing section.[4]

iOS (Apple): Purchases made through the App Store are handled entirely by Apple. Receipts come from no_reply@email.apple.com, and purchase history lives at reportaproblem.apple.com.[4] You manage the subscription in your iPhone's Settings under your name, then Subscriptions.

Android: There is no in-app subscription management on Android. Manage your subscription at app.wisprflow.ai.[1]

This platform split has real consequences. Discounts cannot be applied to App Store subscriptions; if you subscribed via the App Store and want a discount, you must cancel that subscription first and resubscribe through the desktop app or website.[5] Referral reward credits also require an active paid subscription purchased through wisprflow.ai, not the App Store and not Enterprise.[6]

When Payment Fails

When Stripe cannot charge your payment method, the subscription enters a past-due state.[7] Team, enterprise, and iOS paid users keep full access during this window. Personal Pro users on desktop lose Pro access immediately.[7]

Wispr emails the billing admin when the payment first fails, then sends a final reminder six days later if it is still failing.[7] Once Stripe exhausts its retry attempts and marks the subscription as canceled, your account downgrades to Basic. Weekly word caps apply and Pro features are disabled.[7] The exact length of the past-due window depends on Stripe's retry schedule, not a fixed day count.[7]

Your data is not lost on downgrade. Dictionary, history, and settings are preserved. Pay the outstanding invoice and Pro restores, usually within minutes.[7]

The Trial

Flow offers a 14-day Pro trial for new users.[8] On the last day (when one day remains), a personalized Trial End Value Summary modal appears on Mac and Windows, showing your usage and two options: upgrade to keep unlimited words, or continue on Basic at 2,000 words per week.[8] After the trial ends, a notification appears during the grace period the next time you dictate, offering only the upgrade option.[8]

Teams get a short grace period after the trial ends before the team loses access.[8] If billing is not added within that window, the team is disbanded and all members are removed.[1]

The trial summary is rolling out gradually as of Q2 2026; not all eligible users will see it.[8]

Discounts

Six categories qualify for discounted pricing: Student, Education (non-student), Non-profit, Accessibility support, Military, and Senior citizen.[5] Apply through the web support page at wisprflow.ai/support (for PDFs) or through the desktop app's Help menu (for image verification).[5] Verification submission is limited on mobile: iOS has no file attachments, and Android's discount-specific forms are not available in-app.[5]

Only one promotional code can be active at a time.[5]

STUDENT ACCOUNTS

Student accounts carry two special properties. First, they are not subject to the free-tier word cap that some new signups see.[5] Second, approved students receive roughly a 90-day trial (compared to the standard 14 days), calculated from the account creation date by default.[9] If you apply for student pricing months after signing up, your effective remaining trial may be shorter than 90 days; support can recalculate from the approval date, but this is not automatic.[9]

Student pricing starts at $7.50/month or $6/month billed annually (USD defaults; actual pricing varies by currency and country, resolved server-side based on IP

location).[9] On iOS, weekly, monthly, and yearly student plans are available through the App Store; weekly plans are App Store only.[9]

The Referral Program

Share your referral link and the friend who signs up gets a 30-day Pro trial.[6] You earn one free month of Pro per successful referral.[6] The activation threshold: your friend must dictate at least 2,000 words or upgrade to Pro.[6]

Reward credits require an active paid subscription purchased through wisprflow.ai. App Store subscribers and Enterprise members can send invitations and give friends the extended trial, but will not earn rewards themselves.[6]

Students who sign up for a Student plan receive a 90-day trial, which takes precedence over the 30-day referral trial.[6]

The “Apply referral” tab (for entering a code after signup without a link) is available on Mac and Windows only. iOS users cannot apply referral codes in-app; they must sign in on desktop or contact support.[6]

You can refer while on the free plan. Credits are tracked and apply automatically when you upgrade.[6] There is no limit to how many people you can refer.[6]

REFERRAL CODE REGENERATION

If you regenerate your referral code, the old link stops working for new signups. Existing referrals are automatically updated to the new code.[6]

Word Budget Troubleshooting

If your word counter does not reset after Sunday, check three things. First, confirm your plan badge says Basic (word limits only apply to Basic and inactive subscriptions; Pro, Team, Student, and Enterprise plans with active subscriptions have no weekly limits).[2] Second, verify that Sunday midnight has passed in your time zone. Third, check whether the count matches across views; if it is correct in one place but stale in another, restart Flow to sync.[2]

If restarting does not fix it, sign out and sign back in. Be aware that signing out on desktop clears local-only data including transcript history, dictionary entries, and local notes (cloud-synced content is preserved).[2]

Key Points

- Free Flow runs on a weekly word budget that resets every Sunday, not a per-session time limit or a monthly quota.
- iOS and desktop track usage independently, so spreading dictation across devices effectively doubles the free allowance.
- Billing is fragmented across Stripe, Apple, and the web portal; where you subscribed determines how you manage invoices and whether discounts apply.
- Student accounts bypass the free-tier word cap entirely and receive a roughly 90-day trial instead of the standard 14 days.
- Referral rewards require a paid subscription through wisprflow.ai; App Store and Enterprise subscribers can share but cannot earn credits.
- When payment fails, personal Pro users lose access immediately while team and enterprise users retain it during the retry window.
- Downgrades preserve all your data; upgrading again restores Pro features without rebuilding your dictionary or snippets.

SYNC, ACCOUNT, AND DEVICES

In this chapter: your Wispr Flow account is the thread that ties your devices together, carrying dictionary entries, snippets, styles, and subscription status across Mac, Windows, iPhone, and Android. Understanding what syncs, what stays local, and what vanishes on sign-out is how you keep your setup intact and avoid losing work.

Every tool you use across multiple devices forces you to answer a question: where does your stuff live? With Wispr Flow, the answer is split. Some data follows your account wherever you sign in. Some data stays locked to the device it was created on. And some data disappears the moment you sign out, with a warning dialog that is easy to tap past in a hurry. The split is deliberate, but if you do not know where the lines are, you will lose something you care about. This chapter maps those lines.

The Synced Identity

Your Flow account is the container. Sign into the same account on a second Mac, a Windows laptop, an iPhone, and an Android phone, and a set of data appears on each one automatically: your subscription status, your dictionary entries, your snippets, your selected languages, and your personalization styles.[1] That sync is the feature. It means you can build a dictionary on your desktop and have it waiting on your phone by the time you pick it up.

But the sync has boundaries. Transcription history does not cross devices. It is stored locally on each one, and on no platform does Flow download transcript text from the server to another device.[1] On Mac, Windows, and iOS, transcript text and audio are uploaded to Wispr's servers for service improvement unless Privacy Mode is on. On Android, only metadata is uploaded; text and audio never leave the device.[1]

The practical consequence: if you dictate something important on your phone and want to reference it later on your laptop, you will not find it there. The transcript lives on the phone. Plan accordingly.

What Syncs and What Does Not

The full picture, as of Q2 2026:

Syncs automatically: subscription and Pro status, dictionary entries, snippets (on Android, syncs when you open the Snippets screen), selected languages, personalization styles (on Android, only after you tap Save).[1]

Syncs with caveats: daily and weekly streaks refresh from the server periodically. Total words and WPM sync, but daily and weekly counts may differ by device. Languages and styles sync; hotkeys, mic selection, and sounds are per-device.[1]

Does not sync: transcription history, stored locally on each device. Notification preferences, saved locally on each device and configured separately on each machine.[2] Cleanup Level (covered in Chapter 7, The Cleanup Dial) is stored locally per device. Pinned-note status on desktop is local per device (see Chapter 16, The Scratchpad).

Image attachments in notes sync between desktop devices. Supported formats: PNG, JPEG, and WebP. GIF is not supported by the desktop client. Limit: 5 MB per image, up to 100 images per note.[1]

Setting Up a Second Device

The setup is short. Download Flow from wisprflow.ai/downloads (Mac or Windows) or from your device's app store (iOS or Android). Sign in using the same method you used originally: Google, Apple, Microsoft, SSO, or email. On iOS, only Google and Apple appear by default; tap More Options for the rest.[1]

One mistake kills the sync before it starts: signing in with a different method. Google and Apple create separate accounts even if the email address is the same. If your subscription shows on your Mac but not your phone, that is the first thing to check.[1]

Once signed in, your subscription, dictionary, and snippets appear automatically. On Android, snippets sync at login and again when you open the Snippets screen.[1] Style changes on Android require tapping Save before they sync; tapping Cancel discards the draft.[1]

What Happens When You Sign Out

This is where the split matters most, and where each platform behaves differently.

Mac and Windows: signing out wipes your local Wispr Flow data. That includes transcript history, dictionary entries, notes, and meetings/calendar cache. App preferences (language, shortcuts, styles) are preserved.[3]

iOS: signing out does *not* delete any local data.[3]

Android: signing out deletes only transcripts. Other settings are preserved. The confirmation dialog reads "Sign out and delete transcripts?" and it means exactly that.[1,3]

The asymmetry is worth internalizing. If you sign out on a Mac, your dictionary is gone from that machine until you sign back in and re-sync. If you sign out on an iPhone, everything stays. If you sign out on Android, your transcripts are permanently destroyed, but your dictionary and snippets remain. Three platforms, three rules.

Transcripts, Audio, and the 14-Day Window

Dismissed transcripts (not deleted) are recoverable within 14 days on Mac and Windows.[3] Audio is auto-deleted after 14 days regardless; after that, Retry and Recover are unavailable.[3] Accounts using Never Store (Zero Data Retention) never save audio at all, and recovery is not possible under that policy.[3] For the full treatment of retention policies and Privacy Mode, see Chapter 21, The Cloud Boundary.

The "Your Voice" tab is hidden when an auto-delete or never-store policy is active.[3]

Account Management

Your account details live in Settings on every platform. On Mac and Windows, click the gear icon, then Account. On iOS, open the Menu and tap Account. On Android, open the dashboard drawer and tap Account.[4]

Profile pictures change immediately when you select a new image (5 MB maximum).[4] Name changes require tapping Save. On Mac and Windows, Flow validates your name field and rejects entries that look like a password, returning "This looks like a password, not a name."[5,6] That check exists because users have accidentally entered their password in the name field during mobile signup, causing it to appear in emails and referral links.[5] If that happened to you, the fix is a three-

step sequence: reset your password, update your display name, and regenerate your referral code.[5]

Changing Your Email or Sign-In Method

You cannot. Your account is permanently tied to the credentials you used at creation. Google, Apple, Microsoft, email/password, and Enterprise SSO are all separate identity rails, and none can be relinked after the fact.[6]

The only path is to delete your current account and create a new one. Before you do: save your dictionary entries and snippets manually (they will not transfer), cancel any active subscription and contact support for billing adjustments, and understand that dictation stats, transcription history, Flow Notes, team membership, referral credits, AI learned preferences, and HIPAA BAA signing status are all permanently lost.[6]

Email aliases containing "+" (like user+alias@example.com) are not supported for email/password accounts. You will see an error asking you to use your original email address. This restriction does not apply to Apple, Google, or Microsoft sign-in.[4]

Password Reset

Password resets apply only to email/password accounts. If you signed in with Google, Apple, Microsoft, or SSO, credentials are managed through those providers.

On Mac and Windows, there is no in-app password reset. You reset through a browser at wisprflow.ai/login.[7] On iOS, tap More Options on the sign-in screen, then Continue with Email, then Forgot password. A captcha challenge follows.[7] On Android, enter your email, tap Continue, then Forgot password, then Send reset link. No captcha is required on Android.[7]

After you reset your password, all sessions on all devices are signed out.[4,7] Sign back in everywhere. In rare cases a session may remain active and you will need to sign out manually from that device.[7]

SSO and Enterprise Accounts

SSO lets you authenticate using your organization's identity provider. It also works when initiated from your provider (clicking the Wispr Flow tile in Okta, for instance). SSO enforcement requires an active enterprise subscription; if that subscription

lapses, enforcement lifts automatically.[4] For the full treatment of SSO configuration, SCIM provisioning, and domain capture, see Chapter 23, The Org Layer.

The Monthly Flow State Email

Once a month, if you dictate enough words, Flow sends a “Flow State” summary to your inbox: words dictated, words per minute, longest streak, top app, peak day and time, a calendar heatmap, and a rotating insight.[8] It is a marketing email, which means you can unsubscribe via the link at the bottom of any edition. Transactional emails (billing alerts, password resets, team invitations) cannot be disabled.[8]

On Android, push notifications are gated by the notification permission you grant during onboarding. Decline it, and you receive none.[8] Enterprise admins who want to suppress marketing emails across an entire domain must contact support; there is no self-serve toggle (as of Q2 2026), and processing takes a few business days.[8]

Notification Preferences

On Mac and Windows, Flow groups notifications into toggleable categories: Suggestions, Announcements, Milestones, and Team updates (visible to enterprise users only).[2] Each toggle mutes all notifications in that category. Changes take effect immediately and are saved locally per device; configure them separately on each machine.[2]

A set of critical notifications always appears regardless of your settings: permission alerts, microphone hardware errors, helper app failures, billing trial-end alerts, paste and polish feedback, incident alerts, and dictation text-recovery notifications.[2]

iOS has a single Push Notifications toggle in Settings and a separate “Allow Live Activities” toggle managed at the OS level. Android has the onboarding-granted notification permission and nothing more granular.[2]

Deleting Your Account

Account deletion is available in Settings on Mac, Windows, and iOS.[4] Android does not have an in-app Delete Account button; use the desktop app, or submit a request through Report an Issue with the request type set to Account management.[4]

Deletion removes your dictionary entries, snippets, Flow Notes, and local database records. Your login credentials and cloud-stored transcription history are fully removed after the request is processed. Active paid subscriptions are cancelled immediately. No prorated refund is issued.[4] Local history on other devices is not removed automatically; delete the app on each device to clear it.[4]

If you are the sole admin of an enterprise with other members, assign another admin first. If you are the paying admin, transfer billing before deleting.[6]

Account merging is not supported. If you end up with two accounts, pick one and manually recreate your dictionary entries in the keeper.[4]

The iCloud and OneDrive Trap

One hazard worth flagging: if Wispr Flow's local data folder ends up inside an iCloud, OneDrive, or similar cloud-synced location, those services can make local app files read-only, which interferes with how Flow saves data. The result is database corruption and a permanent error state that previously required manual intervention.[1] Flow now auto-recovers on restart, but the recommendation stands: keep Flow's local data folder out of cloud-synced directories.[1]

Key Points

- Your account syncs dictionary, snippets, styles, and subscription status across all devices, but transcription history stays local and never crosses platforms.
- Signing out behaves differently on each platform: Mac and Windows wipe local data, iOS preserves everything, and Android deletes only transcripts.
- You cannot change your sign-in method or email after account creation; the only path is deleting the account and starting fresh with lost data.

- Password resets sign out all sessions on all devices, so expect to re-authenticate everywhere after a reset.
- Notification preferences are per-device on desktop and have no cross-device sync, so configure them separately on each machine you use.
- Keep Flow’s local data folder out of iCloud, OneDrive, and similar sync services to avoid database corruption.

PRIVACY, SECURITY, AND YOUR DATA

In this chapter: every word you dictate crosses a network boundary. This chapter maps what happens to your audio once it leaves the device, what controls exist to limit retention and training use, and where the documented guarantees end. The Cloud Boundary is the frame for deciding what to say and what to type.

Your voice leaves the device. Every syllable you dictate into Wispr Flow is streamed to a backend server for transcription; audio is not persisted locally on the client.[1] That is the architectural fact that shapes every privacy question in this chapter, and it is non-negotiable. There is no offline mode. There is no on-device speech model. The Cloud Boundary is the line your audio crosses the moment you press the hotkey, and every control documented below operates on the far side of that line.

Understanding where that boundary sits, what the company retains on the other side, and which knobs you can turn is the difference between informed use and hopeful use. This chapter sticks to what the sources say.

How the Processing Model Works

Flow's transcription pipeline is cloud-only. Audio is streamed over TLS 1.2 or higher with forward-secrecy cipher suites to Wispr's backend, where it is decrypted and processed.[1] The service does not provide end-to-end encryption in the strict cryptographic sense; the backend *must* decrypt audio to perform transcription.[1] Data at rest is encrypted (typically AES-256) at the database and object-storage layers, and sensitive OAuth and SSO credentials receive an additional application-layer encryption pass.[1]

No voiceprints or biometric identifiers are collected or stored. Wispr states explicitly that it does not derive voice embeddings or any biometric identifier as defined under BIPA, GDPR Article 9, or CCPA.[1]

All customer data is processed and stored in the United States. There is no European or regional processing location. For EU and UK customers, cross-border transfers are governed by the EU Standard Contractual Clauses (June 2021), with a UK Addendum available.[1]

Privacy Mode and Zero Data Retention

The single most consequential toggle in Flow's privacy surface is Privacy Mode, also called Zero Data Retention (ZDR). The behavior splits cleanly into two cases.[1]

With Privacy Mode on, audio, transcripts, prompts, and derived content are not retained and are not used for model training by Wispr or any subprocessor. Dictation content flows through processing without storage; the server enforces sanitization independently of the client.[1]

Without Privacy Mode (the default for trial and standard accounts), audio and transcription data are retained after processing and may be used to evaluate, train, and improve Wispr's models.[1]

Privacy Mode is available on enterprise plans, where it can be enforced at the organization level so individual users cannot disable it.[1] Whether Privacy Mode is available on the free tier is not specified in the documentation (test-it).

Privacy Mode is permanently locked on in two situations: when a user signs a HIPAA Business Associate Agreement, or when an enterprise admin enforces Zero Data Retention.[1,2] Once a BAA is signed, Privacy Mode cannot be disabled. That signing is irreversible.[2]

What Privacy Mode Does Not Cover

Privacy Mode governs *retention and training*, not the location of processing. Audio still travels to the cloud. The transcription still happens on remote servers. Privacy Mode means the server discards the artifacts after processing rather than writing them to persistent storage.

Context Awareness has two separately toggled components: accessibility-text context (on by default, reads text from the active app's accessibility tree) and Screen OCR (off by default, captures a full-display screenshot to extract proper nouns).[2] Screen context captured for Context Awareness is stripped on upload regardless of Privacy Mode and is never persisted server-side.[1] The documentation explicitly confirms this stripping behavior for the Screen OCR path; accessibility-text context is read locally on the device and sent to Wispr's servers during an active dictation session to improve accuracy.[2] Enterprise admins can disable Context Awareness entirely from the Organization settings page under Data Controls.[2]

Snippets and custom dictionaries are stored in Wispr's backend and synced across devices regardless of Privacy Mode status. Wispr classifies these as user-authored productivity assets, not dictation content, and they receive the same at-rest encryption and access controls as other account data.[1]

Local Data Storage Options

Independent of server-side retention, Flow offers three local-data storage modes on desktop (Mac and Windows), configured under Settings, then Data and Privacy.[3]

The first option, Store data locally, is the default. It keeps transcripts and polish history on the device. The second, Auto-delete local data every 24 hours, automatically removes transcripts and polish history older than 24 hours. The third, Never store data locally, immediately deletes all transcripts and polish history and prevents future storage.[3]

Choosing auto-delete or never-store permanently destroys existing local data, including transcripts, polish history, and Transform/Instruct history. The action cannot be undone.[3] Both deletion options also hide the "Your Voice" tab in the Insights page, because Voice Profile requires locally stored transcripts to function. The tab returns automatically if you switch back to storing data locally.[3]

Enterprise organizations can manage this setting centrally. Under a "Never store" policy, the dropdown is fully disabled. Under a "24-hour auto-delete" policy, the dropdown remains interactive but the "Store data locally" option is removed. Users can always choose a *more* restrictive option than what their organization requires.[3]

On iOS, the equivalent control is a toggle called "Automatically delete transcripts" under Settings, then Data and Privacy (off by default). When enabled, transcripts from previous days are deleted the next time the app opens or returns to the foreground, and at sign-in. Today's transcripts are always kept.[3]

On Android, there is no separate privacy-mode or data-storage setting. The only way to clear all transcripts is to sign out, which triggers a confirmation dialog and permanently deletes transcript data.[3]

Enterprise Data Controls

Enterprise plans expose three local-data policy options in the admin portal: Store normally (the default), Delete after 24 hours, and Never store.[1] These are enforced at the organization level and apply to all members.

Enterprise admins can manage Context Awareness, ZDR enforcement, and local storage policy from the Organization settings page under Data Controls.[1,2] A HIPAA Business Associate Agreement is available for healthcare customers; signing the BAA automatically enables Privacy Mode and locks it on permanently.[1]

Certifications and Compliance

As of Q2 2026, Wispr holds the following attestations.[1]

SOC 2 Type I was completed April 2026 by A-LIGN with a clean, unqualified opinion. The scope covers Security.[1] SOC 2 Type II has its observation period underway; the report has not yet been issued.[1] ISO 27001:2022 Stage 1 was completed April 2026 by A-LIGN, with Stage 2 scheduled for June 2026.[1]

Penetration testing was most recently performed by BSK Security LLC in November 2025, with the next engagement planned with Doyensec after the SOC 2 Type I completion.[1]

A historical note: Wispr previously held a SOC 2 Type II (Accorp Partners) and ISO 27001 (Gradient) certification. Both were proactively invalidated in March 2026 due to platform integrity concerns at the original auditor.[1]

Not currently held: FedRAMP, PCI DSS (Stripe handles payments under PCI DSS Level 1), SOC 1, and SOC 3.[1]

A HIPAA Business Associate Agreement is available for healthcare customers. Supporting controls include a HIPAA Internal Privacy Policy, PHI de-identification procedures, breach notification policy, security awareness training, encryption of PHI at rest and in transit, and audit logging.[1]

Data Retention, Destruction, and Deletion

Data destruction follows NIST 800-88 standards for physical media; cloud data is purged per AWS and subprocessor contractual terms. Automated database backups are retained for seven days.[1]

When a user requests account deletion, Wispr executes the deletion synchronously as part of the API request rather than queuing it for a batch job. All data across the primary database is removed in the same request: account, configuration, dictation history (where retained), notes, snippets, dictionaries, preferences, usage stats, referrals, and personalization data. A separate audit record noting that the deletion occurred is kept for compliance purposes only.[1]

Audio recordings are stored locally for 14 days on desktop; after that, audio is automatically deleted and recovery is no longer possible (unless a deletion policy removes data sooner).[3] Transcript text and the history entry remain available unless a deletion policy is active.[3] Under a Never Store (ZDR) policy, audio is never saved to history and retry from saved audio is unavailable.[3]

Dismissed transcripts on Mac and Windows are recoverable within 14 days via a "Recover" link in History. After 14 days, the audio is automatically deleted and recovery is no longer possible.[3]

The Context Awareness Privacy Dimension

Context Awareness, covered in depth in Chapter 9 (The App-Aware Rewrite), has a privacy surface worth restating here.

When Context Awareness is on (the default on Mac and Windows), relevant text data from the active application is sent alongside the audio to improve transcription accuracy. Password field contents are never read or included. On Mac, password field detection uses the standard macOS secure text field indicator; some custom or non-standard password inputs may not be detected.[2]

Screen OCR, the opt-in component, captures a full-display screenshot to extract proper nouns. Any captured screenshot is stripped on upload regardless of Privacy Mode and is never persisted server-side.[1,2]

Context Awareness can be disabled entirely under Settings, then Data and Privacy.[2] Enterprise admins can disable it for all users from the Organization settings page under Data Controls. When an admin disables it, the user preference is forced off and the toggle is locked.[2]

The context-awareness feature drew scrutiny in late 2025 when users discovered that the Screen OCR component was transmitting active-window screenshots to

cloud servers without what they considered sufficient disclosure. The details of the community response are not documented in the help center. The current documentation describes the two components, their defaults, and the stripping behavior. Whether you enable Screen OCR depends on your threat model. The controls exist. The architectural guarantee is that screenshots are stripped on upload and never persisted.

The Company Behind the Data

Wispr AI, Inc. is a Delaware C-corporation, founded in 2023, privately held, headquartered at 444 Townsend Street, San Francisco, CA 94107.[1] The security program is led by CTO/CISO Sahaj Garg, with CEO Tanay Kothari as executive sponsor.[1]

What to Route and What Not to Route

The documented controls are real. Privacy Mode with ZDR means dictation artifacts are processed in memory and discarded. The SOC 2 Type I is complete, and the Type II observation period is underway. HIPAA BAA is available and locks Privacy Mode on permanently. Screen OCR is opt-in and stripped on upload. Data destruction follows NIST 800-88.

The limits are also real. Transcription is cloud-only. No end-to-end encryption. The backend can and does decrypt your audio. Without Privacy Mode, your data may train models. And the compliance program is in a transition period, with the new SOC 2 Type II not yet issued.

For everyday dictation of emails, messages, notes, and code prompts, these controls are sufficient for most users who enable Privacy Mode. For credentials, .env contents, material under NDA, or regulated data outside an active BAA, the safest path is not to speak it at all. That is not a judgment on the company. It is a consequence of the architecture: your voice crosses the Cloud Boundary, and the controls operate on the other side.

Key Points

- Every dictation crosses the Cloud Boundary to remote servers; there is no offline or on-device transcription mode.

- Privacy Mode provides zero data retention for dictation artifacts but does not change where processing occurs.
- Signing a HIPAA BAA permanently locks Privacy Mode on; the action is irreversible for the life of the account.
- Screen OCR is opt-in and stripped on upload; Context Awareness text reading is on by default and can be disabled.
- SOC 2 Type I is complete as of April 2026; SOC 2 Type II is in its observation period and not yet issued.
- Local data storage options let you control transcript retention independently of server-side privacy settings.
- For sensitive or regulated content outside an active BAA, the safest approach is to type rather than dictate.

USAGE AND INSIGHTS

In this chapter: Flow tracks every word you dictate and turns that data into a personal dashboard of speed, streaks, and habits. The Usage tab shows you how you compare to keyboard typists, the Leaderboard ranks your team, and the Voice Profile builds a portrait of your dictation style. Knowing what Flow measures helps you use the numbers and decide what to share.

Every tool that watches you work eventually tells you what it saw. Flow is no exception. The difference is that Flow's observations are surprisingly specific, refreshingly honest, and available only on the desktop app. If you have been dictating for more than a few days, there is already a small dossier waiting in the sidebar.

The concept at the center of this chapter is what we will call The Voice Profile: the idea that your dictation habits, accumulated over time, form a recognizable fingerprint. Flow collects the raw numbers (words per minute, total words, streak days, corrections) and, once you cross a threshold, synthesizes them into a personalized summary. The Voice Profile is not a leaderboard trophy or a gamification gimmick. It is a mirror. Whether you look at it and adjust your habits or ignore it entirely is your call. But it exists, and it is built from your data, so you should understand what feeds it.

The Usage Tab

The Insights page lives in the left sidebar of the Mac and Windows desktop app.[1] It does not exist on iOS or Android. If you are a mobile-only user, this chapter describes a room you cannot enter yet (as of Q2 2026).

Open Insights and you land on the Your Usage tab, which presents five tiles.

Words per minute. An animated radial gauge shows your average dictation speed as a whole number, plus a percentile ranking against global keyboard typists.[1] The comparison baseline is keyboard typing, not other Flow users. The average keyboard typist clocks roughly 52 WPM, so dictating at 100 WPM puts you in the top 4%, and 150 WPM lands around the top 0.5%.[1] The percentile floors at "Top 0.1%" and caps at "Top 99%." Both the WPM number and the percentile update

immediately after each dictation. WPM calculation works accurately for all supported languages, including Japanese, Chinese, Korean, Thai, Khmer, and Lao.[1]

Corrections by Flow. This counts every transcription error, filler word, and automatic fix Flow applied during your sessions, including dictionary substitutions.[1] It is a running tally of the work the Rewrite Pass (Ch1) did on your behalf. If the number is high relative to your word count, it may mean you rely heavily on course correction, or it may mean your microphone setup is feeding Flow noisy input (see The Input Chain, Ch18).

Total words dictated. A lifetime counter with a month-over-month comparison badge. The badge compares your word count so far this month against the same number of days in the previous month and updates after each dictation.[1] When no prior-month data exists, the badge hides. The hover tooltip appears only when the change is nonzero.

Desktop app usage breakdown. A horizontal bar chart categorizes your dictation time across Personal Messages, Work Messages, Emails, AI Prompts, Documents, and Other Tasks.[1] The darkest bar is your top category; the lightest bars are everything else. Hover any segment to see a usage-intensity label (Light, Moderate, or Power usage) and the word count. This chart reflects desktop dictation only; mobile dictation is not included.[1]

Usage streak heatmap. A calendar view of your dictation activity. Days in your current streak glow; the glow ends on the most recent day you dictated, not on today if you have not yet spoken.[1] Other active days shade by word count. Hover any cell to see total words, apps used, and your top app for that day. The heatmap reaches back to your account creation date or March 1, 2025, whichever is more recent.[1]

A Share button at the top opens a carousel of branded share cards. Each card can be copied, downloaded as an image, or shared to X or LinkedIn.[1] Nine card types exist in this order: Flow Highlights, Total Words, Flow Streak, How Fast You Flow, Your Flow Activity, Where You Flow, Voice Profile, Flow Superlatives, and Peak Time.[1] The last three cards appear only after a Voice Profile has been generated.

One practical note: the Share button stays disabled until your main stats finish loading. It may activate before the heatmap finishes, so do not take a grayed-out button as an error. Wait a beat.[1]

The Leaderboard

The second tab on the Insights page is the Leaderboard, available to Team and Enterprise (Business plan) users.[1] If you are on a solo plan, you see a locked preview with a prompt to create or join a team, upgrade to Enterprise, or invite teammates, depending on your account state.[1]

For those with access, the Leaderboard shows a podium view of top-ranked members and a full table below it. You can sort by five metrics: Total words, Words per minute, Current daily streak, Desktop words, and Mobile words.[1] Two of those metrics, WPM and Current daily streak, are available only when the time-range filter is set to "All time"; they hide under "This week."[1] The leaderboard refreshes hourly.[1]

The table paginates. A "Jump to me" button scrolls to your row, which is useful once the team grows past the point where you can spot yourself at a glance.

Enterprise admins can hide the Leaderboard entirely via the "Hide team leaderboard" toggle in the User Management section of the admin portal (web).[1] When enabled, the Leaderboard tab disappears for everyone in the organization, including admins. Whether hiding it is wise depends on your culture. Some teams thrive on visible ranking; others find it corrosive. The toggle exists; use your judgment.

The Voice Profile

The third tab on the Insights page is called Your Voice.[1] It is covered in a separate help-center article and is visible only when your data storage setting is "Store locally."[1] If you or your organization uses a data-deletion policy (auto-delete transcripts every 24 hours, or never store locally), the tab hides. Switch the storage setting back to "Store locally" to restore it; any bookmarked link to Your Voice redirects to Your Usage in the meantime.[1]

What does the Voice Profile actually contain? Based on available information (single-source; verify on your own device), the Voice Profile is a personalized

dictation-habits summary that includes elements like a “superpower,” a headline, your peak dictation time and place, a catch phrase, your most-used and most-corrected word, and a persona label. Generation reportedly begins after you have dictated at least 2,000 words, because the profile is built from locally stored transcription data. *This description comes from a single source with no help-center corroboration as of Q2 2026. The feature is real: the share cards reference it, the tab exists, and it requires local data storage. But the specifics of what the profile says about you are best confirmed by generating your own.*

Three share cards in the carousel depend on the Voice Profile being generated: Voice Profile, Flow Superlatives, and Peak Time (labeled “When you Flow the most”).[1] Until you hit the generation threshold, those slots remain empty.

What the Numbers Mean (and What They Do Not)

The WPM gauge is the tile most humans fixate on. It is worth understanding what drives it.

Your WPM reflects dictation speed, not thinking speed. If you pause for five seconds mid-sentence to choose a word, that silence lowers your average. If you speak in rapid bursts with long gaps between them, the number compresses. The metric rewards continuous speech, which is the same behavior the Rewrite Pass handles best. Hesitant, fragmented input gives the cleanup engine less context to work with (see The Cleanup Dial, Ch7) and produces a lower WPM. There is a feedback loop: dictating more fluidly makes the output better *and* makes the number go up.

The percentile comparison to keyboard typists is generous by design. Most humans type at roughly 52 WPM, which is not fast. If you dictate at even a moderate pace, you will land comfortably in the upper percentiles. Do not mistake “Top 10%” for exceptional dictation skill; it means you are faster than the median typist, which is a low bar. The number is motivating, not diagnostic.

The corrections counter is more useful than it looks. A rising corrections count per session can mean your microphone is degrading, your environment is noisier, or you have started dictating in a style that leans heavily on course correction

(backtracking mid-sentence). If the count spikes without a change in your habits, check The Input Chain (Ch18) before assuming Flow got worse.

The streak heatmap is a consistency metric. It does not measure quality. A one-word dictation counts the same as a 2,000-word session for streak purposes. If streaks motivate you, use them. If they produce guilt on rest days, ignore them.

The “New” Badge

When Insights first becomes available on your account, a “New” badge appears next to Insights in the sidebar.[1] It wiggles shortly after the app opens and again every few minutes until you visit the page. It also wiggles on hover (unless the sidebar is collapsed). After your first visit, the badge fades permanently.[1] This is a one-time nudge, not a recurring notification.

What Gets Collected to Build These Numbers

Flow tracks every dictation event on the desktop: when it happened, how long it took, which app received the text, how many words were produced, and what corrections were applied. This data feeds the Usage tab locally and, for Team and Enterprise users, contributes to the Leaderboard.

The Voice Profile goes further. Because it requires “Store locally” as your data storage setting, it depends on your transcription history remaining on the device. If you enable a deletion policy, the profile disappears. This is not a bug; it is a direct consequence of the privacy architecture described in The Cloud Boundary (Ch21). You cannot simultaneously tell Flow to forget your transcripts and ask it to remember your habits.

For Team and Enterprise users, the Leaderboard aggregates individual metrics into a team ranking. Enterprise admins can export usage data via the admin portal (see The Org Layer, Ch23). The Word Budget (Ch19) tracks words for billing; the Usage tab tracks words for insight. Same unit of measurement, different purpose.

Key Points

- The Usage tab lives on Mac and Windows only; mobile users have no access to Insights as of Q2 2026.

- WPM percentile compares you to keyboard typists, not to other Flow users, making the ranking generous by default.
- The Leaderboard requires a Team or Enterprise plan, refreshes hourly, and can be hidden entirely by an admin.
- The Voice Profile requires local data storage; enabling a deletion policy hides the tab and its share cards.
- Corrections by Flow is the most underused tile and the best early-warning signal for microphone or environment problems.
- Your dictation data feeds both billing metrics and insight dashboards; the same words count in both systems.

DEPLOYING FLOW FOR TEAMS

In this chapter: organizations add a shared layer on top of individual Flow accounts, covering admin controls, shared vocabulary, identity management, usage insights, and deployment tooling. If you use Flow solo, skip this chapter. If you are evaluating Flow for a team or already administering one, this is the reference.

Every feature in this book so far has assumed one human, one account, one device. You dictate, Flow rewrites, text lands where your cursor is. That model works until you need thirty humans using the same terminology, a compliance officer who needs zero data retention across the org, or an IT director who wants SSO before anyone installs anything. The moment the unit of adoption shifts from person to organization, Flow needs a layer it did not need before.

That layer is The Org Layer.

What the Org Layer Contains

The Org Layer is not a separate product. It is the set of controls, shared resources, and identity plumbing that Enterprise and Team plans expose on top of the same dictation engine every solo user runs. The Org Layer gives you three things the individual product does not: shared vocabulary that applies to every member's transcriptions automatically, admin-enforced policies that override individual settings, and identity integration so your directory is the source of truth for who has access.[1]

The admin portal at admin.wisprflow.ai is where all of this lives. It is web-only. Mobile apps have no admin UI. The desktop app exposes inviting users and approving join requests, plus a link to the portal, but every policy configuration happens in the browser.[2]

Roles and Seats

Flow defines three roles on Team plans: Super admin, Admin, and Member. Enterprise adds a fourth: IT Admin.[1]

Super admins and admins have full access to the admin portal, including billing, user management, and settings. Only admins and super admins can directly invite new

users. Members see org details and billing data in the portal but cannot make admin changes.[2]

IT Admin is the odd one. It is a management-only seat type. IT Admins can manage seats, SSO, billing, organization settings, and compliance features, but they cannot use Wispr Flow for dictation. If an IT Admin opens the desktop app, they see a non-dismissable modal with two options: Sign out, or Open Admin Portal. The modal clears automatically if their seat is upgraded without signing out. IT Admin seats are always free and never count toward billed seat totals.[1,2]

This is the role designed for the humans who set up the infrastructure but never dictate a word.

Trials and the Grace Period

First-time team creators receive a 14-day trial. Users who have already used that trial receive only a 24-hour trial when creating a new team.[3] When a trial ends, there is a 3-day grace period. An admin must add billing information during this window. If they do not, the team is disbanded: subscription cancelled, all members removed.[1]

Joining a team can only extend an existing trial, never shorten it. If you already have a longer trial in progress (a 30-day referral trial, for instance), it is preserved. The exception: if the enterprise has team trials disabled, you are moved to a paid seat immediately, even with a longer pre-existing personal trial.[3]

Enterprise billing is per seat. The seat count for limit enforcement includes active members plus pending invitations. There is no minimum seat requirement.[3]

The Admin Portal

The portal at admin.wisprflow.ai is the single surface for org-level configuration. From here, admins manage users, set data controls, configure SSO, enable SCIM, set up IP restrictions, view billing, and export usage data.[2]

Data Controls (Enterprise only) include:[2]

- **Context Awareness:** Set to Available (users toggle it themselves) or Disable for all users (locks the toggle org-wide).

- **Zero Data Retention:** Enforces ZDR across your organization.
- **Local data storage policy:** Store normally, auto-delete after 24 hours, or never store. The stricter settings force the auto-delete toggle on and lock it for every member.
- **SOC 2 report access** and **HIPAA BAA signing** directly from the portal.

The deeper treatment of these privacy controls lives in The Cloud Boundary (Ch21). Here, what matters is that an admin can enforce them from one place without touching individual devices.

Identity: SSO and SCIM

SSO is configured in the admin portal and works on Mac, Windows, iOS, and Android. Wispr Flow supports SAML 2.0, with supported providers including Okta, Microsoft Entra ID, Google Workspace, and OneLogin.[4] The setup wizard handles most of the configuration; most teams finish in under ten minutes.

Enforce SSO is the toggle that matters. When enabled, it blocks all non-SSO sign-in methods (email/password, Google, Apple, Microsoft) for users on the enforced domain.[4] It requires an active Enterprise subscription. If the subscription lapses, enforcement lifts automatically and resumes when the subscription returns to good standing.[4]

Where users find the SSO button varies by platform. On Mac and Windows, there is a single “Sign in via browser” button. On Android, all sign-in options including SSO are visible by default. On iOS, SSO is hidden: users must tap “More options” first, then choose “Continue with SSO.”[5]

SCIM provisioning is Enterprise only. When active, all user management goes through your identity provider’s directory sync. The “Add new user” button and join request Approve/Deny buttons are hidden in Flow. Manual user management is fully disabled.[6]

All SCIM-provisioned users are assigned the Member role. Role mapping from the identity provider is not supported. IT Admin is assigned only through the Admin Portal.[6]

One operational detail worth noting: only fully deleting the directory sync re-enables manual user management. Deactivating or pausing the connection has no effect.[6]

If your enterprise has a seat cap and SCIM provisioning requests would exceed it, the request is skipped. The user is not added and no invitation is sent. If SCIM hits a transient error instead, Flow falls back to sending an email invitation.[3,6]

A user can only belong to one Wispr Flow enterprise at a time.[6]

Domain Capture

Domain capture lets admins control what happens when someone signs up with an email at their company's domain. Verification is self-serve via a DNS TXT record: the host follows the pattern _wispr-verify.<your-domain>, the value starts with wispr-verify=.[7]

Once verified, the admin sets a policy: Off (no restriction) or "Require team membership" (users must join the enterprise to use Flow).[7] Verification is permanent. No auto-recheck is required.[7]

Multiple domains are supported. Each shows as its own row with its own verification status, TXT record, and policy.[7]

One important constraint: domain verification uses public DNS resolution. Split-horizon or internal-only DNS will not work.[7]

IP Allowlist

Enterprise admins can restrict access to specific networks. When enabled, only users connecting from an approved IP range can authenticate. The allowlist supports IPv4 and IPv6 CIDR ranges, up to a maximum of 64 entries. Wildcard CIDRs are rejected.[4]

The allowlist applies across desktop, web, and iOS. Android does not yet enforce it (as of Q2 2026).[1,4]

Users blocked by the allowlist are signed out automatically and shown a "Your network isn't allowed" screen. Dictation is paused while they are blocked. From that screen, they can retry (after switching to an approved network) or sign out.[2]

A self-lockout safeguard exists: the portal shows your current IP and blocks you from saving a list that does not include it.[2]

Team Dictionary and Snippets

Enterprise teams have a shared dictionary that applies to all members. In the Dictionary section of the app (Mac, Windows, iOS, Android), filter tabs (All, Personal, Shared with team) let you browse and manage words. Team dictionary words are used during transcription for all members automatically.[3]

Any member of an enterprise team can bulk-import dictionary words or snippets directly into the shared team library via the import dialog.[3]

On Android, non-enterprise users do not see the team filter. The Android dictionary currently supports plain words only; replacements and snippets are not yet supported on Android.[3]

Onboarding and Team Consolidation

Team-aware onboarding is available on Mac and Windows desktop only. Flow detects whether your email domain has an existing team, an active enterprise account, or no team at all, and routes you to the matching path automatically.[8]

If your email domain already has a Wispr Flow team, you see a Team Consolidation screen during onboarding. It pre-selects existing teammates from your domain and lets you add additional email addresses before joining or creating a team. A “Skip for now” option is available.[8]

In multi-team enterprises, new members who have not been pre-assigned see a Team Picker screen. It is mandatory: no skip, no back button. If the enterprise uses cost-center billing, teams are grouped by cost center with a billing contact shown for each group.[8]

Corporate email is required. Generic, public-TLD, and university email domains (gmail.com, yahoo.com, .gov, .mil, .edu, .int and their international variants) cannot be used as team domains.[1,3]

MDM Deployment

Wispr Flow supports MDM deployment on macOS (via Configuration Profiles, Jamf, or Kandji) and Windows (via Group Policy or Intune). The MDM-managed policy is

currently update frequency: auto, weekly, bi-weekly, or monthly. Security policies (SSO enforcement, transcript retention, Context Awareness, model training opt-in) are configured by admins in the admin portal, not through MDM.[3]

Team Insights

The Insights page in the admin portal gives admins a view of how their team uses Flow. Enterprise gets the full dashboard. Pro admins see a blurred preview with only the Words Dictated card accessible.[9]

The Impact tab surfaces estimated business value:[9]

- **Time Saved:** Calculated against a 40 WPM typed baseline.
- **Money Saved:** A salary-rate slider ($20/hr to $300/hr, default $100/hr) computes value saved per month using a trailing 29-day window. The figure never displays below $0.
- **AI Prompt Quality:** A multiplier showing how much longer dictated prompts are compared to an 8-word typed baseline. The card only appears when the team average exceeds 8 words.

The Team Members table shows each user's lifetime average WPM, total words, status, role, and last activity. Users who have never dictated show a dash, not zero, and are pinned to the bottom when sorting by WPM.[10]

Enterprise admins can hide the team leaderboard from non-admin members via Organization settings (see The Voice Profile, Ch22).[1]

Admin Usage and CSV Export

Enterprise admins can export team usage data as CSV from the Overview tab. Each export includes a Date column and breaks activity down by day, sorted chronologically. One row per day per dimension combination. Dimension columns available: User, User email, Department, App type, App name.[10]

Exports are capped at 100,000 rows. If your filters would produce more, the export fails and asks you to narrow your filters.[10]

Cost Centers

Cost Centers let an Enterprise split one or more teams into their own billing units with separate subscriptions and invoices. Each cost center inherits the parent enterprise's negotiated pricing automatically; there is no plan tier selection.[11]

Each break-away cost center has its own customer record, payment method, and invoices, fully separate from the parent enterprise.[11]

Cost Centers are Enterprise only and must be enabled by your account representative. An admin who is already the billing owner for another cost center in the same enterprise cannot create an additional one; a different admin must complete the flow.[11]

The Cost Centers tab on the Team page lists every cost center with columns for name, status, team count, seat count, renewal date, and creation date. It is visible to admins only.[11]

Guided Tours

After a team plan is activated, Flow runs a short guided tour (Mac and Windows only) spotlighting three sidebar items: Insights, Dictionary, and Snippets. It is a 3-step walkthrough. The tour launches when the user clicks "Get started" on the upgrade celebration modal; dismissing the modal does not launch the tour.[12]

The tour appears once. It cannot be replayed from within the app.[12]

Key Points

- The Org Layer adds shared vocabulary, admin-enforced policies, and identity integration on top of the same dictation engine solo users run.
- SSO enforcement blocks all non-SSO sign-in methods and lifts automatically if the Enterprise subscription lapses.
- SCIM provisioning disables all manual user management in Flow; only deleting the directory sync fully re-enables it.
- IT Admin is a free, management-only seat that cannot dictate, designed for infrastructure humans who never speak into a mic.

- Domain capture and IP allowlists give admins control over who can sign up and from which networks they can connect.
- Team dictionary words apply to every member's transcriptions automatically.
- Cost Centers let departments within an enterprise manage their own billing independently at the same negotiated price.

CHAPTER 24: TROUBLESHOOTING

In this chapter, you learn how to diagnose and fix the most common failures in Wispr Flow. The path from microphone to finished text is short, and so is the list of places it can break. The Failure Map organizes every symptom by its root cause so you can stop guessing and start fixing.

Something broke. You pressed the hotkey, spoke clearly, and nothing happened. Or text appeared in the wrong place. Or the Flow Bubble vanished and will not come back. The instinct is to restart everything and hope, but Flow's failure modes are specific enough that a restart is usually overkill and sometimes misses the actual problem.

Call it The Failure Map. The dictation pipeline has four stages (capture, cloud recognition, cleanup, insertion), and every failure you will encounter lives at one of those stages or at the edges where your device, your permissions, or your network connect to the pipeline. Knowing which stage broke is the difference between a ten-second fix and twenty minutes of blind troubleshooting.

This chapter is organized by symptom. Find what you see on your screen, read the cause, apply the fix. Cross-references point to earlier chapters where a feature or concept was introduced; this chapter does not re-explain them, only maps the failure.

Not Recording

You press the hotkey or tap the bubble. Nothing happens. No waveform, no text, no error.

Microphone permission is missing or revoked. On Mac, both Microphone and Accessibility permissions are required; Screen Capture is optional for advanced features but not needed for basic dictation.[1] On Windows, no app-level permissions are required; only system microphone access matters.[1] On iOS, if Wispr Flow is not listed under Microphone in iOS Settings, tap Start Flow or the mic button to trigger the system permission request.[1] On Android, the home screen shows diagnostic cards: "We can't hear you" (mic), "Flow Bubble Disabled" (service stopped), "Enable Flow bubble on screen" (overlay missing), "Flow can't insert text"

(accessibility missing), “Keep Wispr Flow running” (battery optimization), or “Bubble is snoozed.”[1]

Fix: Toggle the relevant permission off and back on, then restart Flow. On Mac, System Settings, Privacy and Security, then Microphone and Accessibility. On Android, follow whichever home screen card appears. On iOS, Settings, Wispr Flow, Microphone.

Clamshell mode on Mac. Closing your laptop lid disables the built-in microphone. Flow shows a “Your laptop lid is closed” notification.[2] Connect an external microphone or open the lid.

Another app holds the microphone exclusively. Flow surfaces a specific notification: “Microphone is in use” or “Microphone unavailable.”[3] Close the competing app (Zoom, Teams, Google Meet, Discord, FaceTime are common culprits) and try again.[3]

Mic recording not released after Bubble dismiss on Android. On desktop, dismissing the bubble during dictation could leave the microphone recording for the remainder of the session limit (see The Input Chain, Chapter 18, for the full treatment of mic behavior). This was addressed in recent updates.[4]

Not Pasting

Flow transcribes your speech. You can see the transcript in History. But nothing lands in the text field.

Clipboard conflict on Mac and Windows. Flow temporarily uses the system clipboard to paste text and restores your previous clipboard contents afterward.[5] If the target app blocks clipboard access (Citrix, virtual desktops, corporate apps, password managers), text will not arrive. Test in a plain text editor first. If text appears there but not in your target app, the app is blocking paste.[5]

Recovery shortcuts exist. On Mac, press Ctrl+Cmd+V for “Paste last transcript.” On Windows, Alt+Shift+Z.[5] The Scratchpad (Chapter 16) also stores your most recent transcript: Option+S on Mac, Win+Alt+S on Windows.[5]

Windows privilege conflict. If you see a notification reading “Update admin settings to paste!”, the target app is running with higher privileges than Flow. Quit Flow, then relaunch it as Administrator.[5]

iOS auto-deactivation in restricted fields. Flow automatically deactivates in number, phone, decimal, email address, numbers-and-punctuation, and ASCII-capable number pad fields.[5] Switch to a standard text field.

Android direct insertion. Flow inserts text directly in WhatsApp, Telegram, Messenger, Instagram, Teams, Signal, Slack, Discord, Snapchat, Google Messages, and Gmail, plus the Google search box and Chrome New Tab Page search field.[5] If insertion fails, the Flow Bubble shows a copy button so you can paste manually. In the Chrome address bar, text may be copied to the clipboard rather than inserted directly.[5]

Non-QWERTY and non-Latin keyboard layouts can also break insertion. This is covered under The Insertion Boundary (Chapter 17).

Slow or Failed Transcription

You dictated, Flow recorded, but text either never arrives or takes unusually long.

“Taking longer than usual.” This message appears when Flow’s servers need extra processing time. It is permanently dismissable with “Don’t show again.”[6] On Android, the toast reads: “Taking longer than usual. Your audio is saved in the app.”[6] Common causes: temporary server load, slow internet, VPN or firewall interference.

Audio retention and retry. Audio recordings are stored locally for 14 days. After that, the audio is removed but the transcript text and history entry are kept.[6] With NeverStore (Zero Data Retention) enabled, audio is never saved to History and retry from saved audio is unavailable.[6]

How to retry. On desktop, a failure notification includes Retry and Open History buttons. On iOS, tap the orange triangle warning icon that appears next to the mic button to see details and retry (for server errors) or dismiss (for network errors).[7] On Android, the Flow Bubble shows a Retry button for transcription failures and a Paste button for insertion failures.[7]

Minimum requirements for retry on desktop: the recording must be at least 5 seconds long and less than 14 days old. Dismissed transcripts have no 5-second minimum.[7]

Retry is blocked during active dictation. On desktop, attempting retry while dictating shows a “Cannot retry while dictating” toast.[7]

“No Model Available” and Startup Errors

Flow shows “No Model Available,” “Flow is having trouble starting,” “Audio system failed to load,” or simply stops responding.

What “No Model Available” means: Flow could not load the transcription model. Restarting Flow and checking your internet connection resolves it in most cases.[2]

“Your laptop lid is closed” (Mac only): the built-in mic is unavailable in clamshell mode. Select an external mic.[2]

“Microphone Permission Required”: On Mac, this triggers a system prompt on first use or opens System Settings if you previously denied access. On Windows, it opens system microphone privacy settings.[2]

Escalation path: If the “Flow is having trouble loading” notification persists, the issue moves to “Flow is having trouble starting” after multiple retries. Both notifications offer Restart Flow and Contact us buttons.[2]

Degraded Accuracy

Transcription was working yesterday. Today the output is garbled, words are wrong, or sentences cut off mid-thought.

Most common cause: wrong microphone. A Bluetooth device in your pocket, a webcam mic across the room, or a wireless headset that connected automatically. Check your system sound settings and confirm the correct input device is selected.[8]

Extract and listen to the audio. On Mac and Windows, open History, find the entry, click the three-dot menu, and click Extract audio to save a .wav file.[8] If the audio itself is distorted, the problem is upstream of Flow. If the audio is clean but the transcript is wrong, retry the transcription. Audio extraction is not available on iOS.[8]

Language settings. If Flow is transcribing in the wrong language, check your language selection. On desktop, the Flow Bar language indicator lets you cycle through selected languages; hover to reveal the chevron for the full picker.[4] On Android, Auto-detect is not available; you must select at least one specific language (see One Language Per Breath, Chapter 13).

Dictionary overload. A very large dictionary with hundreds or thousands of entries can sometimes cause odd substitutions. Trim to the most important terms if you see unexpected word replacements.[8]

Flow Bar and Flow Bubble Issues

The desktop Flow Bar or the Android Flow Bubble is missing, flickering, or unresponsive.

Flow Bar hidden deliberately. The right-click menu includes “Hide for 1 hour,” and the bar can also be hidden permanently from Settings.[4] Check there first.

Android Bubble: pulsing loader vs. warning triangle. The pulsing loader means Flow is auto-reconnecting to the accessibility service; no action needed. The warning triangle means reconnection has stalled or accessibility permission was revoked. Tap the triangle to go directly to accessibility settings and re-enable Flow.[4]

Battery optimization is the top Android killer. Aggressive battery management on Samsung, Xiaomi, Redmi, POCO, Vivo, Oppo, OnePlus, Motorola, Huawei, Honor, Realme, and Transsion devices is the most common reason the Flow Bubble disappears in the background.[4] Each manufacturer has its own exemption path. Samsung uses “Never sleeping apps”; Xiaomi, Redmi, POCO, and Vivo use “Autostart”; Oppo uses “Allow Auto-Launch” and “Allow Background Activity”; Huawei and Honor use “App launch” toggles; Realme and OnePlus use battery optimization exclusions; Motorola and Transsion use “Don’t optimize.”[4]

Bubble reappearance. If the Flow Bubble disappears, it should reappear on its own within about 45 seconds. If it does not, open the app from your launcher. If you revoke the “Display over other apps” permission while the bubble is visible, it disappears and will not return until the permission is restored.[9]

Missing First Words

Your dictation starts mid-sentence. The first word or two are gone.

Root cause: wireless microphone wake-up delay. AirPods and other wireless mics can be slow to activate. Flow flags AirPods with a warning symbol in the desktop mic list.[10]

Fix: Switch to the built-in microphone or a wired USB mic, which have zero wake-up delay.[10] If you prefer wireless, pause briefly after pressing the hotkey and wait for the Flow Bar waveform to start moving before speaking. Starting with a filler word ("so," "okay") works; Smart Formatting removes these automatically.[10]

Auto-detect mic setting shows the currently active device name in parentheses (e.g., "Auto-detect (MacBook Pro)"). Selecting your microphone explicitly may reduce connection delays.[10]

Built-in mic labeled "Built-in mic (recommended)" in the selection list.[10] Virtual microphones from audio routing software are hidden from Flow's list unless set as the system default.[10]

Connection Lost

Flow shows "Connection lost," dictation stops mid-sentence, or the app will not connect at all.

VPN and security software are the usual suspects. Flow is incompatible with most VPNs. Common offenders include NordVPN, ExpressVPN, Surfshark, Cisco AnyConnect, GlobalProtect, corporate proxies (Zscaler, Netskope, Palo Alto, Fortinet), antivirus web filters (Norton, McAfee, Bitdefender, Kaspersky), DNS filters (Pi-hole, AdGuard, NextDNS), and macOS firewalls (Little Snitch, LuLu).[11]

What to whitelist: the Wispr Flow application itself, plus the domains wisprflow.ai, api.wisprflow.ai, and inference.wisprflow.com.[11] If you must use a VPN, enable split tunneling and exclude these domains.[11]

iOS partial transcript preservation. If the connection drops mid-dictation on iOS, Flow preserves successfully transcribed segments and pastes them. You get a partial transcript rather than nothing.[12] Flow also switches to a backup transcription path

immediately on first segment failure, without waiting for each subsequent segment.[12]

"Disable Flow Session" timer on iOS controls how long Flow keeps the session alive when the app is backgrounded. Options: Never, 1 hour, 15 min, 5 min (default), Immediately.[12]

Restart, Reset, and Reinstall

Three escalation tiers, from lightest to heaviest.

Quit and relaunch clears background processes. On Mac, Cmd+Q and reopen from Applications. On Windows, right-click the system tray icon, Quit, reopen from Start. On iOS, swipe up and away. On Android, Force stop in Settings, then reopen.[13] If you quit or restart Flow while a dictation is in progress on desktop, the audio is automatically saved and appears in History with a Recover link on relaunch. Exception: a crash or force-kill may not save audio.[13]

Reset and Restart is available on desktop only (Settings, System, Data).[9] This deletes local History, Dictionary, Notes, notifications, meetings, calendar events, and backup files. Stats and settings are preserved.[6,9] Your dictionary re-syncs from your account on the next launch. On iOS and Android, force close or reinstall instead.[9]

Complete removal strips all data, including hidden folders and system permissions. Mac has an uninstall script; Windows has a batch script.[14] On iOS, simply deleting the app does not remove the login session or data shared with the Flow Keyboard extension; you must sign out and remove the keyboard extension first.[14] On Android, auto backup may restore app data; clear storage before uninstalling for a completely fresh state.[14]

App Does Not Start

You click the icon. Nothing happens, or you see a blank screen.

Windows installer. Download the latest installer from wisprflow.ai/downloads.[15]

Sign-in session timeout. On desktop, complete the browser sign-in promptly. If the browser login takes too long, the desktop app resets and you must click Sign in via browser again.[15]

Mac runs in menu bar only. Wispr Flow does not appear in the Dock or the Cmd+Tab switcher. This is by design.[15] Look for the icon in the top-right menu bar.

Android crash loop after microphone permission revoked (Android 14+). Revoking microphone permission caused the app to crash on every launch. Fixed in recent versions: the app now starts in a limited non-recording state and prompts you to restore mic access.[15]

Database corruption from cloud sync. Storing Flow's app data in iCloud or OneDrive can mark database files read-only, causing corruption and crash loops.[9] Move the data folder out of any cloud-synced directory.

Login Issues

Sign-in paths differ by platform. Desktop: Sign in via browser is the only path; all provider selection happens in the browser.[16] iOS: Google and Apple shown by default; Microsoft, SSO, and Email behind "More Options."[16] Android: all five options shown on the login screen.[16]

You cannot switch login methods once your account is created, and multiple emails cannot be linked to a single account.[16]

CAPTCHA blocks. CAPTCHA appears during account creation, password reset, and verification resend, not during standard login. If the CAPTCHA cannot load, the relevant button stays disabled.[17] Android does not include CAPTCHA.[17]

Redirect loops on the download page. Try a different browser with extensions disabled, or clear your browser cache. On mobile, install from the App Store or Google Play instead.[18]

Service Status

Orange banner = degraded performance. Red banner = outage. These appear on the Hub home page on Mac and Windows only; iOS and Android do not show incident banners.[19]

Incident notifications bypass mute settings and cannot be silenced.[19] They are throttled to avoid repeated interruptions during a prolonged incident.[19]

Region-specific. Banners appear only when the active incident affects the region associated with your account. The banner auto-dismisses when the incident is resolved.[19]

Gradual rollout. If you do not see incident banners, the feature may not yet be enabled on your account as of Q2 2026.[19]

Re-Verifying Permissions After Updates

System or app updates can silently reset or revoke permissions on every platform.

Mac: toggle Microphone and Accessibility permissions off and back on in System Settings, then restart Flow.[1]

Windows: check that system microphone access is enabled in Windows Sound Settings. No app-level permission is needed.[1]

iOS: if the "We can't hear you" card appears, tap Go to Settings and re-enable the Microphone toggle.[1]

Android: follow whichever home screen card appears (mic, overlay, accessibility, battery, snooze). On Samsung and other OEM devices, the system can silently drop Flow's accessibility connection without any in-app warning.[1] Flow now sends a notification when this happens; tap it to go directly to accessibility settings.[1]

iOS Audio Chunk Loss

On unstable internet, words or sentences can go missing from a dictation.

Partial transcript preservation. If one segment of a long dictation fails, successfully transcribed segments are preserved and pasted. You get a partial transcript rather than nothing.[12]

Backup transcription path. Flow switches to its backup path immediately on first segment failure. It does not wait for each subsequent segment.[12]

Keyboard disables dictation controls when offline. The controls return automatically when the connection is restored.[12]

Manual cancel does not save audio. If you cancel a recording in progress, the audio is not preserved.[12]

Database Errors

On Mac and Windows, a database error notification appears when the disk is full, local data is corrupted, or the dictionary cannot load. Flow continues running but the dictionary may not apply and history may not save until you restart.[9]

Cloud sync folders cause this. iCloud and OneDrive can mark Flow's database files read-only, triggering corruption and crash loops. Move the data folder out of any synced directory.[9]

Fix: Click Restart Flow in the notification. If the notification persists, use Reset and Restart (Settings, System, Data) for a full recovery.[9]

Getting Support

Three channels, each routed differently.

Report an Issue goes to the support team and receives a direct response. **Share Feedback** goes to the product team; no reply. **Flag a Transcript** is used for model training; no reply.[20]

Attachment limits. Desktop and Android: PNG, JPEG, BMP, or WebP, one file, 10 MB max.[20] iOS: text-only, no image attachments.[20]

Desktop diagnostic logs and config are auto-attached to support reports. iOS and Android send only your message text and any attached image.[20]

Keyboard shortcut on Mac: Cmd+/ opens Talk to support. Submit with Cmd+Enter (Mac) or Ctrl+Enter (Windows).[20]

If you cannot sign in, the desktop login screen has a Help button that opens a "Send a message to the Flow team" dialog. If Flow crashes, the error recovery screen offers a Contact support button that pre-fills an email to support@wisprflow.ai.[20]

Key Points

- Every Flow failure lives at one of four pipeline stages: capture, recognition, cleanup, or insertion; identify the stage before you troubleshoot.
- Wireless microphone wake-up delay is the single most common cause of missing first words; wired or built-in mics eliminate it.

- On Android, aggressive battery optimization from the device manufacturer is the top reason the Flow Bubble disappears in the background.
- Audio is retained locally for 14 days on desktop, giving you a retry window for any failed transcription.
- Reset and Restart on desktop is the nuclear option that deletes local history; use it only when simpler restarts fail.
- Service status banners on Mac and Windows tell you whether an outage is on Flow's side, saving you from troubleshooting a problem you cannot fix.
- When reporting an issue, include your platform, the exact error text, and what you already tried; the support team resolves most cases in one reply.

APPENDIX G: ENDNOTES

Superscript numbers in square brackets in the body text refer to the per-chapter endnotes below.

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